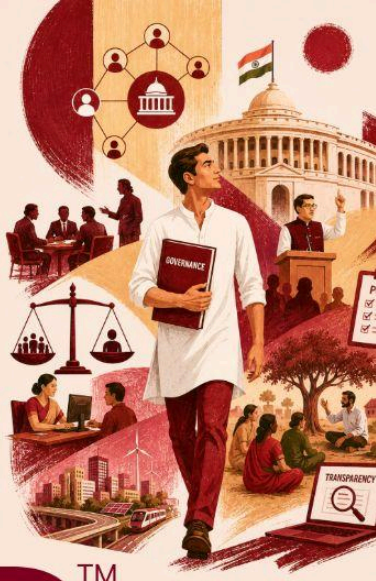
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Table of Contents

1. **Important Aspects of Governance** **3**
   - Good Governance 4
   - Citizen Participation and Good Governance 8
   - Transparency and Accountability 10
   - Citizen Charter 12
   - Social Audit 15
   - Right to Information Act 17
2. **E-Governance** **22**
   - National data governance 30
   - M-Governance 33
   - AI in governance in India 34
3. **Development Process and Development Industry in India** **37**
   - DEVELOPMENT INDUSTRY IN INDIA 38
   - NGO sector in India 43
   - Pressure Groups 46
   - Donor Agencies 49
   - Self-Help Groups 50
   - Micro Finance in India 54
4. **Civil Services** **57**
   - Civil Services 57
   - Lateral Entry in India 60
   - Mission Karmayogi: National Programme for Civil Services Capacity Building (NPCSCB) 62
   - Police Reforms in India 64
   - Prison Reforms in India 67
   - Custodial Torture in India 69
5. **Miscellaneous** **71**
   - Online betting and gambling industry 71
   - Sports Governance in India 73
   - Social media ban on minors 75
   - Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition Rehabilitation and Resettlement (RFCTLARR) Act, 2013 76
   - Census 77
   - Centrally Sponsored Schemes (CSS) and Central Sector Schemes (CS) 79

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Chapter 1

Important Aspects of Governance

Important Aspects of Governance

PYQs

[2026] "Transparency and accountability in governance are not about controlling corruption but about creating the trust of stakeholders in the policy process by following the Rule of Law and Participatory Governance." Comment. (15)

[2024] The Citizens' charter has been a landmark initiative in ensuring citizen-centric administration. But it is yet to reach its full potential. Identify the factors hindering the realisation of its promise and suggest measures to overcome them. (15)

[2024] What are the aims and objectives of recently passed and enforced, The Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024? Whether University/State Education Board examinations, too, are covered under the Act? (15)

[2018] The Citizen's Charter is an ideal instrument of organisational transparency and accountability, but it has its own limitations. Identify the limitations and suggest measures for greater effectiveness of the Citizen's Charters. (15)

"Good governance is not about implementing everything; it's about prioritizing intelligently." - **Ha-Joon Chang**

World Bank: 1992 report entitled "Governance and Development" - "Governance is the manner in which power is exercised in the management of a country's economic and social resources for development."

Corporate Governance - Corporate governance is about promoting corporate fairness, transparency, and accountability. **(World Bank)**

Evolution of Governance in India

Model	Description	Examples
Entitlement-Based Model: Post-Independence Era	**State-led Development and citizens as passive recipient**	**Five-Year Plans (1951)** **License Raj (1950s-1980s)**
Participation-Based Model: Late 20th Century	Participatory democracy and neoliberal economic policy.	**73rd and 74th Amendments** **LPG Reforms**
Rights-Based Model: 21st Century	Recognizing basic services as legal rights.	**Right to Information Act (2005)** **Right to Education Act (2009)** **Food Security Act (2013)**

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Model	Description	Examples
Governance Reforms and Initiatives Post-2014	**Minimum Government Maximum Governance**	**Digital India (2015)** **Goods and Services Tax (GST)**

World Bank's Worldwide Governance Indicators (WGI)

Dimension	Key Indicator	High-Performing Example (2025)
Voice & Accountability	**Free Press** and **Elections**	Norway (**Media Freedom**)
Political Stability	Lack of **Civil Unrest**	Switzerland (**Neutrality / Stability**)
Government Effectiveness	**Digital Public Services**	Estonia (**e-Governance**)
Regulatory Quality	**Ease of Doing Business**	Mauritius (**Regional Hub Policies**)
Rule of Law	**Independent Courts**	Canada (**Judicial Integrity**)
Control of Corruption	**Anti-Bribery Enforcement**	Singapore (**Zero-Tolerance**)

In its report "State of Governance - A Framework of Assessment," the Indian government (DARPG) breaks down governance into five domestic pillars.

1. **Political Dimension:** The manner in which power is contested, exercised, and held accountable by citizens. Eg. Free and fair elections.
2. **Legal & Judicial Dimension:** Resilient laws and an efficient judicial system ensuring access to justice for all. Eg. Removal of colonial laws.
3. **Administrative Dimension:** Management of resources and efficient delivery of services through civil services. Eg. **CPGRAMS** and **DBT.**
4. **Economic Dimension:** Maintaining macroeconomic stability and creating a conducive climate for business. Eg. **GST** and the **Ease of Doing Business** reforms.
5. **Social & Environmental Dimension:** State's ability to ensure equitable benefits for the vulnerable and sustainable resource use. Eg. **PM-JANMAN** mission for PVTGs.

Good Governance

"In the happiness of his people lies the king's happiness, in their welfare his welfare." - **Kautilya**

"The exercise of economic, political and administrative authority to manage a country's affairs at all levels. It comprises the mechanisms, processes and institutions, through which citizens and groups articulate their interests, exercise their legal rights, meet their obligations and mediate their differences." - **UNDP**

Core Principles of Good Governance (UNDP)

1. **Participation:** Direct/indirect citizen involvement in decision-making. Eg. Gram Sabhas.
2. **Rule of Law:** Fair legal frameworks enforced impartially. Eg. Independent judiciary.
3. **Transparency:** Free flow of accessible information. Eg. Mandatory disclosures under the RTI.

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4. **Responsiveness:** Institutions serving stakeholders within timeframes. Eg. Citizens' Charters and CPGRAMS grievance portal.
5. **Consensus Orientation:** Eg. Federal consensus in GST Council meetings.
6. **Equity/Inclusiveness:** Ensuring all members feel valued. Eg. PM Jan Dhan Yojana's universal financial inclusion.
7. **Effectiveness/Efficiency:** Optimizing resources for societal needs. Eg. Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) reducing subsidy leakages.
8. **Accountability:** Answerability of officials to the public. Eg. Mandatory CAG audits of government spending.

Issues with good governance in India

Limited Participation

1. **Political Criminalization** compromises clean democratic participation. Eg. 46% of MLAs have criminal cases (ADR, 2025).
2. **Declining Parliamentary Scrutiny:** Frequent suspensions of MPs reduce time for deliberative legislative participation.
3. **Grassroots Power Gaps:** Local bodies lack the **"3 Fs"** (Funds, Functions, Functionaries).

Rule of Law challenge

1. **Judicial Overload:** 5.5 crore case pendency eroding the 'Justice for All' doctrine.
2. **77% of inmates are under-trials** violating the right to liberty.
3. **Opaque judicial appointments and corruption** in lower judiciary.
4. **Police Reform Stagnation:** Non-implementation of Prakash Singh directives allows continued political interference.

Transparency

1. **Political Funding Opacity:** The lack of a transparent donor-tracking alternative to Electoral Bonds remains a major concern.
2. **RTI Bottlenecks:** High vacancy rates in Information Commissions lead to massive backlogs in appeals.
3. **Whistleblower Risks:** Insufficient protection leads to physical threats.

Responsiveness

1. **Poor Quality of Redressal:** While CPGRAMS handles high volumes, "final disposals" are often procedural rather than substantive.
2. **Administrative Silos:** Lack of inter-ministerial coordination delays time-sensitive project approvals.
3. **Urban Infrastructure Gaps:** Public services fail to keep pace with the needs of rapidly urbanizing populations.

Consensus Orientation

1. **Federal Trust Deficit:** Strained Centre-State relations over tax devolution and Governor roles hinder national consensus. Eg. NEP, 2020 opposition.
2. **Policy Polarization:** Major reform bills often face deadlocks due to a lack of pre-legislative consultation. Eg. 131st Amendment Bill.
3. **Inter-State Disputes** due to a lack of consensus-building platforms. Eg. dysfunctional Inter-state council.

Equity and Inclusiveness

1. **Digital Divide:** Half of rural India lacks high-speed internet, creating a two-tier governance experience.
2. **Gender Participation:** Low female workforce participation limits inclusive economic and administrative governance. 37% FLFPR (Periodic Labour Force Survey, 2025).

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3. **Marginalized Under-representation:** Scheduled Tribes and nomadic communities still struggle for equitable access to basic welfare.

Effectiveness and Efficiency

1. **Subsidy Leakages:** Despite DBT, "Ghost" beneficiaries still siphon off a portion of welfare funds.
2. **Generalist vs Specialist:** The civil service lacks specialized domain expertise required for complex 21st-century governance.
3. **Red Tapism:** Excessive procedural layers delays approvals and hampers EoDB.
4. **High level of corruption due to "Sanskritization". 91st rank** in corruption perception Index.

Accountability

1. **Overlapping Commissions:** Multiple bodies (NHRC, NCW, NCM) lead to "jurisdictional bouncing" for complainants. Eg. Manipur/Sambhal riot investigations.
2. **Underutilized Lokpal:** The anti-corruption ombudsman has seen a low conviction rate despite thousands of complaints.
3. **Weak Enforceability:** Officials rarely face severe career consequences for institutional failures or service delays.

State-Level Measures

1. **Real-Time Governance (Andhra):** Uses AI to monitor service delivery.
2. **Parivar Pehchan Patra (Haryana):** Unique family IDs consolidate welfare schemes to eliminate "ghost" beneficiaries.
3. **K-FON (Kerala):** Provides high-speed internet as a basic right.
4. **5T Governance (Odisha):** Focuses on Transparency, Technology, Teamwork, and Time for systemic AI-led institutional transformation.
5. **Mukhya Mantri Jan Seva (MP):** Doorstep delivery of 68 essential public services.
6. **Jan Sunwai (Rajasthan):** Public hearings that allow citizens to directly question officials regarding missing funds or delayed services.
7. **Social Audit (Meghalaya):** First state to pass the **Community Participation and Public Grievance Redressal Act**, mandating community review of all government projects.
8. **Kudumbashree (Kerala):** A three-tier women's network (NHGs) that handles everything from disaster relief to micro-credit and local planning.
9. **Mission Shakti (Odisha):** Empowers 70 lakh women through Self-Help Groups (SHGs) to manage government properties like paddy procurement centers and hospitals.
10. **Bhagidari System (Delhi):** A formal partnership between **Resident Welfare Associations (RWAs)** and the government to solve local civic issues like waste and water.
11. **People's Plan Campaign (Kerala):** Decentralized planning where 35-40% of the state budget is allocated based on priorities set by local Gram Sabhas.
12. **Van Panchayats (Uttarakhand):** Century-old community forest councils that manage local timber and water resources.

Global Examples

1. **Estonia: The Digital Republic** - Established the "e-Governance Academy" to digitize 99% of public services, including secure blockchain-based i-Voting and e-Residency.
2. **Brazil (Participatory Budgeting):** The "Porto Alegre" model.
3. **Singapore: Zero-Tolerance for Corruption** - The CPIB (Corrupt Practices Investigation Bureau) operates with total independence and high civil servant salaries to deter bribery.

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4. **Norway:** Manages the GPFG (Government Pension Fund Global) with extreme transparency, decoupling oil revenue from current state spending (Assets hit $2.2 trillion in 2025).
5. **Denmark: "High Trust" Welfare Model -** High tax-funded universal services are sustained by a culture of "Social Trust" between citizens and government.
6. **Rwanda: Post-Conflict Centralized Recovery -** Implemented strict performance contracts (Imihigo) for officials to drive poverty alleviation and stability following the 1994 genocide.
7. **New Zealand:** Utilizes the "Wellbeing Budget" framework, prioritizing human and social outcomes over mere GDP growth in official policy.

Issues With Government Schemes:

- **Structural -**
- **Entitlement-Based Model** - Focus on **input-driven subsidies** rather than **outcome-based results**, causing inefficiency.
- **Colonial Legacy** - Persistence of **centralized bureaucracy** and **hierarchical decision-making (Top-Down Approach)**. Eg. ineffective Gram Sabhas.

- **Technological -**
- **Digital Divide** - Poor **digital access** and **digital literacy** exclude rural poor from scheme benefits.
- **Poor Technological Infrastructure** - Eg. **NITI Aayog (2024)**: Less than **30% Gram Panchayats** have internet connectivity.
- **Limited Impact Evaluation Tools** - Absence of **data-driven dashboards** and feedback analytics.

- **Administrative -**
- **Poor Accountability Mechanisms** - Weak **performance audits** and limited citizen oversight. Eg. **lack of enforcement of citizen charters**
- **Inaccurate Targeting** - Outdated **SECC** and **Aadhaar data** cause exclusion errors.
- **Weak Monitoring and Evaluation** - Lack of **third-party audits** and outcome evaluation.
- **Inter-Departmental Coordination** - **Siloed ministries** and weak data sharing hinder convergence.

- **Political -**
- **Populist Spending** - Preference for **short-term electoral schemes** over sustainability. Eg. **Ladli Behna Scheme**
- **Overlapping Jurisdictions** - Duplication among ministries reduces **policy coherence**. Eg. **Jal Jeevan Mission** overlaps with **SBM** in water supply.
- **Centre-State Conflict** - Fiscal and political frictions weaken **cooperative federalism**.

- **Economic -**
- **Misallocation of Funds** - High **administrative expenditure** limits beneficiary impact. Eg. **80% of BBBP funds** went for advertising.
- **Capital vs Revenue Imbalance** - Excess **revenue spending** reduces asset creation. Eg. **MGNREGA (2024)**: **78% on wages**, only **18% on durable assets**.
- **Resource Constraints** - Fiscal pressure curbs **social-sector expansion**. Eg. **low spending on Health and Education**.

- **Social -**

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- **Limited Reach** - Marginalized groups remain excluded due to **social barriers**. Eg. **MoHUA (2024)**: Only **37% SC/ST households** accessed PMAY-Urban.
- **Subsidy dependency** leads to inefficient resource use. Eg. **Punjab's groundwater crisis due to free electricity**.
- **Sustainability Issues** due to weak **community ownership**. Eg. **NSSO**: Under **SBM 30% toilets** became non-functional post-installation.

Major Steps Taken

Administrative Dimension

1. **Transparency and accountability - RTI Act, Social Audits.**
2. **Mission Karmayogi (iGOT 2.0):** Transitioned civil services from "rule-based" to "role-based" competency.
3. **Sādhana Saptah (2026):** a national collaborative capacity-building week to foster skills specifically for "citizen-centric" and responsive local governance.
4. **CPGRAMS 7.0:** for grievance redressal.

Technological Dimension (Digital Governance)

1. **Bhashini AI Platform:** Introduced real-time, voice-enabled translation in 22 Indian languages to bridge the digital divide for non-English speakers.
2. **India-AI Impact Mission (2026):** Deployed "SabhaSaar," an AI tool to automate and transparently document village council meetings to prevent record tampering.
3. **Faceless Tax Administration:** the **New Income Tax Act, 2025** mandates digital-first enforcement and consolidates TDS provisions to eliminate physical harassment.

Legal & Judicial Dimension

1. **New Criminal Laws (BNS, BNSS, BSA):** Replaced colonial-era codes (IPC, CrPC, Evidence Act) to modernize justice and prioritize victims' rights.
2. **Mandatory Digitization of Evidence:** The **Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam (BSA)** now grants legal parity to electronic records and forensic evidence for faster trials.
3. **e-Courts Phase III:** Digitize all court records and establish virtual courts for petty offenses to reduce the 5.5 crore case pendency.

Economic & Fiscal Dimension

1. **Next-Gen GST (2025):** Restructured GST slabs from five down to three (0/5%, 18%, and 40%) to simplify compliance and boost consumption.
2. **National Single Window System (NSWS):** Unified 100+ approvals across central and state departments into a one-stop digital shop for industrial clearances.

Political & Social Dimension

1. **JAM Trinity - Financial inclusion**
2. **Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam:** Implementation of 33% reservation for women in Lok Sabha and Assemblies to ensure gender-inclusive political governance.
3. **PM-JANMAN Mission:** A targeted governance initiative for 75 **Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups (PVTGs)** to provide 100% saturation of basic services.
4. **Aspirational Blocks Programme:** Extended the success of "Aspirational Districts" to 500 blocks to ensure "Last Mile" governance through real-time KPI monitoring.

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Citizen Participation and Good Governance

"The building of a nation is not a government project; it is a **people's project**." **PM Narendra Modi**

"Democracy is not merely a form of government; it is primarily a **mode of associated living**." **B.R. Ambedkar**

"Never doubt that a **small group of thoughtful citizens** can change the world." **Margaret Mead**

"The government's role is to empower, but **citizens' role is to participate**." **2nd ARC Report**

Importance of Citizen Participation in India

1. **Enhanced Accountability:** Citizens act as "vigilance eyes" preventing administrative corruption. Eg. **2025 Social Audit of MNREGA in Meghalaya.**
2. **Resource Optimization:** Local inputs prevent top-down planning failures. Eg. **Village-level drought proofing under Jal Shakti Abhiyan.**
3. **Inclusive Development:** Ensures benefits reach the last person (**Antyodaya**). Eg. **Community-led beneficiary identification for PM-JANMAN mission (2026).**
4. **Policy Legitimacy:** Public feedback during drafting reduces street-level protests. Eg. **23,000 suggestions received for Digital India Act 2025.**
5. **Transparency Boost:** Eg. **4.3 million RTIs filed annually.**
6. **Social Cohesion:** Joint community projects reduce local ethnic/caste frictions. Eg. **"Aspirational Blocks" peace committees in 500 blocks.**
7. **Service Efficiency:** Real-time feedback loops fix broken utilities faster. Eg. **24-hour repair cycles via MyGov feedback portal.**
8. **Democratic Deepening:** Shifts India from "Representative" to "Participatory" status. Eg. **Gram Sabha empowerment under PESA Act 1996.**
9. **Crisis Management:** Community volunteers act as first responders during disasters. Eg. **Local "Disaster Mitras" during 2026 urban floods.**

Major Challenges in Participation

1. **Digital Divide:** Half of rural India lacks the high-speed access needed for digital-governance.
2. **Illiteracy Barriers:** Complex technical language in policy documents excludes the uneducated.
3. **Elite Capture:** Local powerful groups often hijack participatory forums like Gram Sabhas.
4. **Information Asymmetry:** Eg. **Low awareness of "Jan Sunwai" in Bihar.**
5. **Tokenistic Participation:** Post-facto feedback loops reducing public hearings to ceremonial exercises. **Eg. Urban Masterplan "ceremonial" public hearings.**
6. **Gender Disparity:** Social norms often restrict women from speaking in public forums. Eg. **"Pradhan-Patis."**
7. **Fear of Reprisal:** Whistleblowers fear physical or social backlash for exposing local graft.
8. **Resource Constraints:** Small NGOs and civil groups lack funds for sustained advocacy.
9. **Bureaucratic Resistance:** A "secrecy mindset" persists among some officials despite the RTI.
10. **High Inequality:** Extreme poverty forces citizens to prioritize daily wages over civic participation

Andrea Cornwall's **"Seven Sins of Citizen Participation"**

- **Cosmetic Labeling -** Participation acts as a facade to gain "procedural legitimacy" without granting any actual influence over the project. Eg. **EIA**
- **Paternalism - Top down approach in policy making.**
- **Politicization -** Eg. **Elite capture of Gram Sabhas.**

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- **Poor Representation** - Eg. **"Sarpanch-Pati" culture.**
- **Instrumentalization** - Citizens are used as a means to an end, rather than as an active agent.
- **Fragmentation** - Multiple agencies conduct uncoordinated, overlapping consultations, causing "participation fatigue" and administrative confusion. Eg. Parastatals.
- **Overloading** - Excessive administrative burdens on community workers or citizens without providing the necessary resources or compensation. Eg. **ASHA workers.**

Central Initiatives

1. **Gram Sabhas** under PRIs as an instrument of direct democracy.
2. **MyGov 2.0:** World's largest crowdsourcing platform; hit **45 million users** in early 2026.
3. **CPGRAMS 7.0:** AI-based portal that automates grievance sorting for faster disposal.

State Level Best Practices

1. **Meghalaya Social Audit Law:** First state to pass legislation mandating community audits for **21 departments**.
2. **Jan Sunwai (Rajasthan):** Institutionalized public hearings where officials explain spending to the village.
3. **Kerala people's plan campaign** - Decentralized participatory budgeting.

Global Best Practices

1. The **UK Government's Open Data portal.**
2. **Participatory Budgeting - Porto Alegre in Brazil** .
3. The **UK's Citizen Charter introduced in 1991** set service standards for various public services.

Transparency and Accountability

Transparency: The principle that public officials and institutions have a duty to act visibly and provide clear, accessible information about their decisions and actions.

Accountability: The obligation of public authorities to explain, justify, and take responsibility for their actions.

OECD defines open government as

1. The **transparency** in government actions,
2. The **accessibility** of government services and information, and
3. The **responsiveness** of government to new ideas, demands and needs.

"Sunlight is said to be the **best of disinfectants**; electric light the most efficient policeman." - **Justice Louis Brandeis**

"Accountability breeds **response-ability**." - **Stephen Covey**

"Corruption thrives in **secret places** and avoids public places." - **Woodrow Wilson**



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Importance of Transparency and Accountability

Strengthening Democratic Legitimacy

1. **Building Public Trust:** Eg. **Proactive disclosures under Section 4 of RTI.**
2. **Informed Citizenry:** Eg. **information on criminal cases against candidates.**
3. **Upholding Rule of Law:** Eg. **Removal motion against Justice Verma.**

Enhancing Administrative Efficiency

1. **Reducing Leakages:** Eg. **₹3.5 lakh crore saved via DBT-Aadhaar (2026).**
2. **Time-bound Service:** Eg. **Right to Service Act of Maharashtra.**
3. **Optimizing Resource Use:** Eg. **CAG's 2025 performance audit of PMGSY.**

Combating Systemic Corruption

1. **Deterrence of Graft:** Eg. **GeM portal.**
2. **Protects Institutional Integrity:** Eg. **Mandatory social audits in Meghalaya.**

Fostering Economic Stability

1. **Investor Confidence:** clear regulatory and transparent tax regimes
2. **Fiscal Discipline:** Eg. **FRBM Act.**
3. **Market Fair Play:** Eg. **Transparent 5G/6G spectrum auctions.**

Promoting Social Equity

1. **Empowering Vulnerable Groups:** Information allows marginalized communities to demand their rightful share of resources. Eg. **PESA Act.**
2. **Gender Justice:** Transparent reporting exposes wage gaps and representation issues in local bodies.

Major Challenges in India

Political Challenges

1. **Criminalization of Politics:** Candidates with criminal records often resist accountability measures to protect their interests. **45% of current MLAs face criminal cases (ADR, 2025).**
2. **Opaque Election Funding:** lead to nexus of **politician-bureaucrat-corporate (Vohra Committee)**
3. **Political Resistance:** Eg. Reluctance to bring political parties under RTI

Legal-Institutional Challenges

1. **Culture of Secrecy:** A colonial mindset among the lower bureaucracy views public questioning as "interference"
2. **Judicial Pendency:** Massive backlogs undermining timely accountability and justice delivery.
3. **Weak Whistleblower Protection:** Activists face physical threats despite laws, deterring citizens from exposing corruption.
4. **Institutional Vacancies:** Delays in appointing Information Commissioners lead to massive RTI appeal backlogs (over 23000 in CIC).

Technological Challenges

1. **Digital Divide:** Half of rural India lacks the internet access required for e-transparency portals.
2. **Accessibility issue** - lack of content in vernacular languages.

Social Challenges

1. **Information Asymmetry:** Eg. **Low awareness of "Jan Sunwai" in Bihar.**
2. **Elite Capture of** participatory forums like Gram Sabhas. Eg. **"Sarpanch-Pati" culture.**

Mechanisms for Transparency and Accountability

Constitutional -

1. **Judicial review**: Eg. Supreme Court verdict on **Coal Mines Allocation case**.

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2. **Parliamentary Committees**: Eg. **PAC review of MGNREGA** scheme implementation.
3. **Article 311**: It provides safeguards to **civil servants** against arbitrary dismissal, removal, or reduction in rank, ensuring fairness and neutrality in administration.

Legal -

1. **RTI Act**: Promotes "informed citizenry"
2. **Lokpal and Lokayuktas**: It investigates allegations of corruption against public officials.
3. **CAG**: It ensures financial accountability. Eg. **CAG report on 2G Spectrum Allocation**.

Institutional -

1. **CVC**: It supervises vigilance administration and anti-corruption measures.
2. **CIC**: Eg. **directive to RBI to disclose willful defaulters list (2015)**.

Technological-

1. **CPGRAMS**: A centralized system for monitoring and resolving **public grievances**.
2. **e-Governance:** Eg. DBT

Societal -

1. **Media and Civil Society**: Eg. **ADR's 2025 "Know Your Candidate" campaign.**
2. **Participatory Budgeting**: People plan campaigns in Kerala.
3. **Social Audit**: Eg. **MGNREGA social audits in Andhra Pradesh.**
4. **Public Hearings**: Eg. **MKSS Jan Sunwais in Rajasthan**.

The **Second Administrative Reforms Commission (2nd ARC)** identifies transparency as the "antidote to corruption."

Citizen Charter

A **Citizen's Charter** is a public statement that outlines an organization's commitment to providing quality services within a specified timeframe, along with a mechanism for grievance redressal.

Historical Evolution

1. **1991:** First articulated by the Conservative Government of **John Major** in the UK. It was designed to improve the quality of public services by treating citizens as "customers."
2. The model was later adopted by Australia, Canada, and France. In the UK, it was re-launched in 1998 as **"Service First"** under Tony Blair.
3. **Action Plan (1997):** Emerged from a Conference of Chief Ministers chaired by the Prime Minister to create a "Responsive Administration."
4. The Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances (DARPG) spearheaded the initiative to coordinate and formulate charters.
5. The **2nd ARC** recommended the "Sevottam" framework (Service Excellence) to standardize CCs, grievance redressal, and service delivery capability.

Key Components of a Citizen Charter

1. **Vision and Mission:** Statement of the organization's core purpose.
2. **Details of Business:** Clear description of services and goods provided.
3. **Service Standards:** Measurable and time-bound benchmarks (Eg. "Passport in 15 days").
4. **Grievance Redressal:** Information on appeal mechanism if standards aren't met.
5. **Stakeholders:** Identification of specific client groups/users.
6. **Expectations from Citizens:** What the organization needs from the user. Eg. Correct documentation

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Key Principles of CC

1. **Quality:** Constant improvement of service quality.
2. **Choice:** Providing alternatives for the user wherever possible.
3. **Standards:** Setting explicit targets for what to expect and timelines for delivery.
4. **Value:** Ensuring the best value for taxpayers' money.
5. **Accountability:** Making individuals and organizations answerable for service delivery.
6. **Transparency:** Openness in rules, procedures, schemes, and grievances.

Status in India

- **Over 700 Citizen's Charters** have been adopted across Central Ministries/Departments, public sector undertakings, States/UTs, and local bodies.
- More than **20 States have enacted Right to Public Services / Service Guarantee Acts.**
- **IS 15700:2005** of BIS provides certification for adopting the Sevottam framework.
- **CPGRAMS interlinks 91 Central Ministries/Departments and 36 States/UTs**, with more than 74,000 subordinate users. It is integrated with **5 lakh+ Common Service Centres (CSCs) and 2.5 lakh Village Level Entrepreneurs (VLEs)** for last-mile rural access.
- Indian Railways, India Post, Passport Seva, Income Tax (Taxpayers' Charter, 2020), Aadhaar (UIDAI), and Public Distribution System have active charters.

Importance of Citizen Charter in India

Administrative Accountability

1. **Setting Benchmarks:** Provides measurable standards to evaluate performance.
2. **Reducing Discretion:** Clear rules minimize the "human element," reducing chances for corruption. Eg. **Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) verification timelines.**
3. **Consistency: Ensures uniform service across different regions.**
4. **Public Scrutiny:** Empowers citizens to question delays based on written commitments. Eg. **Jan Sunwai using CC benchmarks in Rajasthan.**

Citizen Empowerment

1. **Information Access:** Citizens know exactly what they are entitled to. Eg. **Display of PDS entitlement charts at Ration Shops.**
2. **Voice and Choice:** Encourages user consultation to improve service quality. Eg. **Feedback loops in the Swachh Bharat Mission (2025).**

Organizational Reform

1. **Process Re-engineering:** Forcing departments to simplify internal workflows to meet promised deadlines. Eg. **Single Window System for industrial clearances.**
2. **Performance Management:** Shifts the culture from "process-oriented" to "result-oriented"

Major Challenges in Implementation

Design and Structural Hurdles

1. **Vague Standards:** Use of generic terms like "as soon as possible" instead of specific timelines.
2. **Poor Quality of Standards:** The IIPA Evaluation found that **service delivery standards were absent in 43%** of charters reviewed, and **service quality standards in 38%**.
3. **Lack of Legal Teeth:** Most CCs are not legally enforceable, making them "pious declarations" without penalties.
4. **Limited Consultation** with end-users or NGOs, leading to gaps in service alignment.

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Social and Awareness Gaps

1. **Information Asymmetry: Only 15% of rural citizens are aware of local CCs (2025 Survey).**
2. **Linguistic Barriers:** Charters are often not available in local dialects, excluding non-Hindi/English speakers.

Administrative Resistance

1. **Lack of Training:** Ground-level staff (ASHA/Postmen) are often not trained on the charter's commitments.
2. **One-Size-Fits-All:** Charters are often drafted at HQs without local context.
3. **Rare Updates**: Many charters are outdated, having not been revised since the 1990s.

Best Practices

1. **UK (Charter Mark):** An excellence award given to agencies that meet strict "Citizen First" criteria.
2. **Australia (Service Charters):** Includes a "Redress" clause where citizens can get a refund/credit if service standards are missed.
3. **Canada (Management Accountability Framework):** Links the senior management's promotions directly to their department's CC performance.
4. **Sakala Mission (Karnataka):** Statutory backing through the Karnataka Guarantee of Services to Citizens Act.

Way Forward:

1. **2nd ARC:** Enact a **"Right to Service Act"** at the Centre to make CCs legally enforceable. (**Revive the Right of Citizens for Time Bound Delivery of Goods and Services Bill, 2011**)
2. **Sevottam Implementation (2nd ARC):** Move from mere "declaration" to a "service excellence model" involving capability building.
3. **Mandatory Compensation** if a service is delayed beyond the CC limit
4. **Local Language Mandate: Eg. Use of Bhashini AI for real-time translation.**
5. **External Audits:** Independent third-party NGOs should audit CC performance quarterly.
6. **Staff Incentives:** Link "Mission Karmayogi" performance credits to the successful delivery of CC targets.
7. **Participatory Drafting:** Involve RWAs and Gram Sabhas in the initial drafting phase to ensure realistic standards.
8. **Public Awareness Campaigns:** Use "Nukkad Nataks" and social media to inform citizens of their rights under the CC.

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The **Sevottam Model** is an assessment-improvement framework developed by the **DARPG** in 2006 to elevate the quality of public service delivery in India.

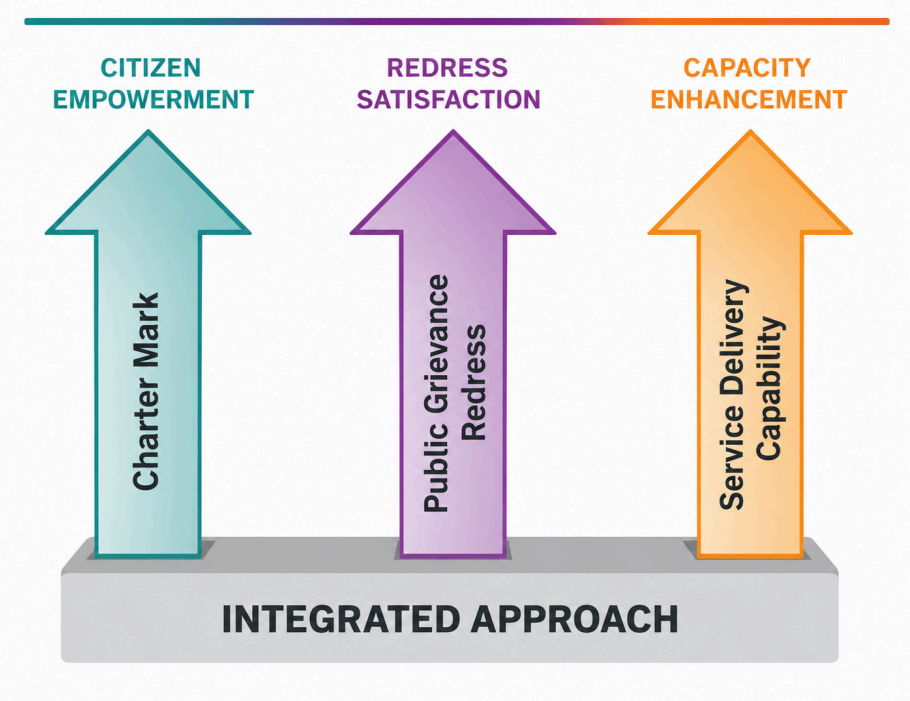
The name combines the Hindi words Seva (Service) and Uttam (Excellent), symbolizing a shift from "administration and control" to "service and enablement."

Core Concept

- **Nature:** A **Quality Management System (QMS)** specifically for public service organizations.
- **Objective:** To provide a roadmap for organizations to assess their service delivery, identify gaps, and implement systemic improvements.
- Compliant organizations are awarded the **IS 15700:2018** certification by the Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS).

The Seven-Step Implementation Model

- **Define:** Identify all services provided and the specific clients (citizens) served.
- **Set Standards:** Establish measurable norms and timelines for each service.
- **Develop Capability:** Build the internal capacity to meet these set standards.
- **Perform:** Implement workflows to achieve the defined service standards.
- **Monitor:** Continuously track performance against the benchmarks.
- **Evaluate:** Assess the impact through independent mechanisms to ensure objectivity.



- **Continuous Improvement:** Use feedback and evaluation results to drive further excellence.

Social Audit

Social Audit is a **democratic process** that ensures public accountability by empowering stakeholders to systematically demand information and scrutinize the implementation of government programs.

Unlike financial audits, it measures **social impact, quality of work, and ethical adherence** alongside expenditure.

Recently, there is a demand for social audits of **Special Intensive Revision exercise** to ensure accuracy in electoral rolls.

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Historical Evolution

1. **Tata Iron and Steel Company Limited** was the **first company to perform social audits in 1979** for measuring its social performance.
2. **Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan (MKSS)** in **Rajasthan (1990s)** organized **Jan Sunwais** (Public Hearings) to expose corruption in local development works and demand minimum wages.
3. Social audit was institutionalized for the first time in India through the **National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (NREGA)**.
4. The **MGNREGS Audit of Schemes Rules (2011)** mandated that state governments establish independent **Social Audit Units (SAUs)**.

Process of Social Audits

1. **Planning:** An annual calendar is prepared by the **Social Audit Unit (SAU)**.
2. **Preparation:** Implementing agencies provide all records (muster rolls, bills, measurement books) to auditors **15 days in advance**.
3. **Verification:** Resource persons visit work sites and cross-verify records by interviewing beneficiaries in their homes.
4. **Gram Sabha Meeting:** Findings are read out in a public meeting. Officials must be present to answer on-record queries.
5. **Public Hearing (Jan Sunwai):** Issues not resolved at the village level are taken to a block or district-level public hearing with senior officials.
6. **Action Taken Report (ATR):** The government must submit an ATR on the findings within a stipulated timeframe (usually 30 days).

Importance of Social Audits in India

Accountability & Corruption Control

1. **Eliminating Ghost Beneficiaries:** Identifies people who only exist on paper.
2. **Preventing Financial Leakage:** Eg. Nearly Rs 900 cr has been misappropriated under the MGNREGA scheme over the past five years as per social audit reports.
3. **Direct Questioning:** Officials are forced to justify expenses in front of the community. **Eg. Jan Sunwais in Rajasthan.**

Quality & Service Delivery

1. **Work Quality Verification:** Citizens check the quality of material used (Eg. cement in roads).
2. **Ensuring Entitlements:** Confirms that laborers receive full wages on time.
3. **Infrastructure Sustainability:** Local monitoring ensures that built assets are actually functional.

Empowerment & Participation

1. **Democratizing Information:** Provides illiterate laborers access to complex financial data.
2. **Boosting Civic Agency:** Citizens transform from passive recipients to active "vigilant" stakeholders. **Eg. Success of "Nigrani Committees" in UP.**
3. **Inclusion of Marginalized:** Mandates participation of women and SC/ST groups.
4. **Conflict Resolution:** Addresses grievances locally before they escalate into legal battles.

Major Challenges in Implementation

Institutional & Political

1. **Bureaucratic Resistance:** Officials often delay records or skip public hearings to avoid scrutiny.
2. **Lack of Financial Independence:** SAUs depend on the very departments they audit for funds.
3. **Political Hijacking:** Powerful local elites intimidate or silence dissent during Gram Sabhas.

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Operational & Structural

1. **Thin Capacity:** Social Audit Units are often understaffed and auditors under-trained
2. **Information Asymmetry:** Complex technical reports are hard for rural citizens to understand. Eg. **Technical jargon in "Measurement Books."**
3. **Inadequate Follow-up:** Findings are reported, but Action Taken Reports (ATRs) are rarely finalized

Social & Legal

1. **Risk to Whistleblowers:** Lack of a robust protection mechanism for those who speak out
2. **Language Barriers:** Reports often not available in the local dialect

Major Successful Case Studies

1. **Meghalaya Social Audit Act**
2. **Andhra Pradesh (Society for Social Audit):** Recovered over **₹150 crore** in embezzled funds since inception.
3. **Sikkim (Village Monitoring):** 100% saturation of social audits in rural development projects with high community attendance.

- The **Ministry of Labour** has issued a framework for conducting social audits under the **Building and Other Construction Workers Act, 2013.**
- Department of Social Justice and Empowerment has established the **National Resource Cell for Social Audit**

Way Forward

1. Enact a **National Social Audit Act** to provide legal protection and permanent funding to SAUs.
2. **Financial Autonomy:** Create a separate corpus for audits, independent of the implementing ministry (recommended by **2nd ARC**).
3. Shift from "Post-facto" (after work) to "Concurrent" (during work) audits using drones and AI tracking.
4. Link social audits with the **Whistleblower Protection Act** to ensure the safety of citizen participants.
5. **Incentivizing Performance:** Link a portion of state grants to the quality and frequency of social audits conducted.

Right to Information Act

The Right to Information **(RTI) Act, 2005** is hailed as the **"Master Key to Good Governance."**

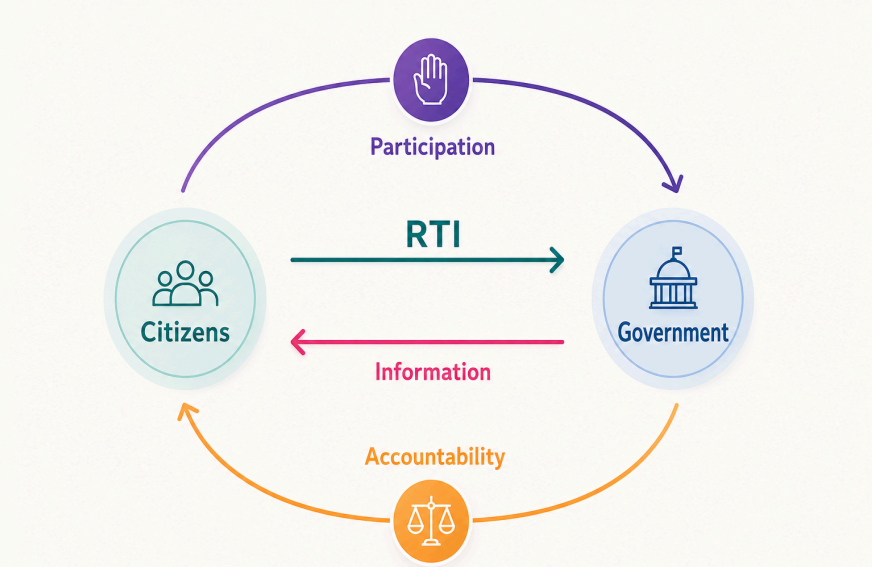
- "The Right to Know is a facet of the Right to Speech and Expression (Article 19)." - **Supreme Court (State of UP v. Raj Narain, 1975)**
- "Information is the currency of democracy." - **Thomas Jefferson**
- "A citizen has a right to know how the government, which he has elected, is functioning." - **Justice P.N. Bhagwati**

Beawar, in central Rajasthan, is called “RTI City” as the 1st demand and protest for RTI was made by MKSS and School for Democracy in 1996.

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Key Provisions of RTI Act, 2005

1. **Section 4(1)(b):** Mandates **proactive disclosure** (Suo Motu) of information by public authorities to minimize the need for filing RTIs.
2. **Section 6:** Allows any citizen to request information in English, Hindi, or the official language of the area. No reason for seeking information is required.
3. **Section 7:** Information must be provided within **30 days** (or **48 hours** if it concerns the life or liberty of a person).
4. **Section 8:** Lists **exemptions** (Eg. national security, cabinet papers, fiduciary relationships). However, Section 8(2) allows disclosure if "public interest outweighs the harm."
5. **Section 20:** Empowers Information Commissions to impose penalties of **₹250 per day (up to ₹25,000) on erring officials.**



RTI Amendment Act, 2019

1. **Tenure:** Removed the fixed 5-year term; tenure is now **"as prescribed by the Central Government"** (currently set at 3 years).
2. **Salaries of Chief/State Information** Commissioners are no longer at par with Election Commissioners; they are now determined by the Centre.
3. The **Central Government** now prescribes the service conditions even for State Information Commissioners.

Significance of RTI Act

For Government

1. **Transparency and Openness:** Mandates **proactive disclosure**, dismantles **bureaucratic secrecy**, and institutionalises **open decision-making.**
2. **Strengthening Institutional Checks: Eg. Electoral Bonds judgment (2024)** upheld **transparency and citizens' rights.**
3. **Institutional Mechanism for Transparency:** Establishment of **Central and State Information Commissions** provides a **quasi-judicial avenue for grievance redressal.**
4. Establishes **India as a leader in open governance. Eg. Bangladesh** modeled RTI laws on **India's Act.**

For Citizens

1. **Informed Citizenry:** Promotes **deliberative democracy**, reduces **information asymmetry**, and builds **public consciousness** about rights. **Eg. Citizens accessing MGNREGA job card data.**
2. **Democratic Deepening:** Extends democracy beyond elections by institutionalising **citizen engagement** and **continuous public oversight.**
3. **Political Accountability:** Brings **judiciary (in part), and public-funded NGOs** under greater **public scrutiny.**

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Administration

1. **Exposure of Corruption and Maladministration:** Eg. **2G Spectrum, Adarsh Housing, Commonwealth Games.**
2. **Improved Service Delivery:** Enables **monitoring of schemes** like **MGNREGA** and **PDS**, improving **transparency, efficiency, and benefit delivery.**

Media and Civil Society

1. **Support for Investigative Journalism:** Journalists have used **RTI** to uncover **policy lapses, irregularities in public spending, and human rights violations.**
2. **Civil Society Empowerment:** Strengthens **NGOs and social activists** by enhancing their ability to demand **accountability, transparency, and evidence-based advocacy.**

Major Challenges in Implementation

Political Challenges

1. Despite the **CIC Decision (3 June 2013)** declaring six national parties "public authorities" under Section 2(h), all refused compliance.
2. **Lack of political will:** Eg. No earmarked central budget for RTI awareness or digitisation.
3. **RTI Amendments 2019 & 2023** reduced autonomy of CIC.

Institutional & Legal Challenges

1. **Massive Pendency:** Over **4 lakh appeals** pending across 29 commissions as of 2024.
2. **Vacancies:** Eg. **9 Commissions were without a Chief in late 2025.**
3. **Penalty Evasion:** Penalties are imposed in only **4% of cases** where they were warranted.
4. **Bureaucratic Resistance: Section 8(1)** exemptions (national security, fiduciary, etc.) are widely misused; **Section 8(2)**'s public-interest override invoked in < 1% cases.

Social & Operational Challenges

1. **Threats to Activists:** Over **100 RTI activists killed** since 2005.
2. **Digital Exclusion:** Poor portal design in regional languages limits rural use.
3. Only **approx 25%** of rural respondents know how to file RTIs (Centre for Media Studies 2023). Awareness is lowest among **women, SC/ST, and rural poor.**
4. Since 2005, only **9%** of commissioners have been women.

Section 44 (3) of Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023 amended **Section 8(1)(j)** of RTI to provide a **blanket ban** on the disclosure of "personal information," removing the "public interest" exception.

Justification for (DPDP) Act, 2023 (Government's Stand)

- **Alignment with Puttaswamy Judgment:** It harmonizes RTI with the 2017 SC verdict that declared privacy a fundamental right under **Article 21.**
- **Removal of Ambiguity:** The previous "public activity/interest" test was subjective; the new phrasing provides a clear "bright-line" rule for PIOs.
- **Preventing Harassment of Officials:** Protects public servants from "targeted info-fishing" that could lead to identity theft or harassment.
- **Global Harmonization (GDPR):** Brings India in line with EU standards where personal data protection is paramount.
- **Section 8(2) Override:** Government claims **Section 8(2)** (Public Interest override) still exists as a general safety valve for the entire Act.
- **Codifying Jurisprudence:** Aligns with **Girish Ramchandra Deshpande case principles** that personal details like IT returns or service records are generally private.

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- **Informed Consent:** Ensures that data provided for a specific purpose (Eg. healthcare) isn't used for another (Eg. public scrutiny) without permission.
- **Ease of Compliance:** Simplifies the job of Public Information Officers who previously struggled to balance competing fundamental rights.

Criticism of the Amendment

- **Removal of "Public Interest" Override**
- **Justice BN Srikrishna Committee** recommended narrow exemptions rather than broader and vague ones.
- The **blanket exemption of and the vague definition of personal information** provides discretion to public authorities.
- **Shielding Corruption:** Details like **Asset Declarations** and educational qualifications of officials are now strictly "personal."
- **Impact on Accountability: Eg. Challenges in accessing PM CARES fund donor details.**
- **Executive Overreach:** The definition of "Personal Information" is now so broad it can cover almost any file notation.
- **Chilling Effect on Journalism:** Investigative reporters collecting "personal data" during probes may be treated as "data fiduciaries."

SC Judgments

1. **State of U.P. vs Raj Narain (1975):** RTI recognised as implicit in Article 19(1)(a).
2. **S.P. Gupta vs President of India (1982):** Citizens have the right to know about public transactions.
3. **People's Union for Civil Liberties vs Union of India (2004):** RTI elevated to the status of a human right linked to Article 21 (Right to Life and Liberty).
4. **Subhash Chandra Agarwal vs. Office of the CJI (2019):** Brought **Office of the Chief Justice of India (CJI)** under RTI.
5. **Electoral Bonds Case:** It struck down the **Electoral Bonds Scheme**, holding that **secrecy in political funding violates Article 19(1)(a)**.

Global Best Practices

1. **Mexico (INAI):** Its Information Commission has the power to **overrule** the government's "national security" classification if human rights violations are suspected.
2. **Estonia:** Operates on a "Once-Only" principle with **X-Road technology**, where all non-sensitive government data is open by default.
3. **South Africa:** Its PAIA law allows citizens to access information even from **private bodies** if it is required to protect a fundamental right.

Way Forward

1. **Fill Vacancies:** Mandate 50% non-bureaucratic appointments (academics, journalists) to diversify commissions.
2. **Statutory Timeframes for Appeals:** Fix a **90-day disposal limit** for Information Commissions (2nd ARC Recommendation).
3. **Harmonize DPDP & RTI:** Amend the 2025 rules to ensure "Public Interest" remains the overriding factor in data disclosure.
4. **Digitize Record-keeping:** Standardize all state portals and integrate them with **Bhashini AI** for multilingual access.
5. **Outcome Budgeting:** Link state grants to the performance of their Information Commissions.

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6. 2nd ARC Recommendations:

a. Establish a National Coordination Committee (NCC) for RTI monitoring.
b. Conduct awareness campaigns through NGOs and educational institutions.
c. Strengthen record management and digitisation.
d. Bring NGOs receiving ≥ ₹1 crore in government funds under RTI purview.

CIVILSDAILY IAS

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Chapter 2

E-Governance

PYQs

[2025] E-governance projects have a built-in bias towards technology and back-end integration than user-centric designs. Examine. (10)

[2024] e-governance is not just about the routine application of digital technology in the service delivery process. It is as much about multifarious interactions for ensuring transparency and accountability. In this context evaluate the role of the 'Interactive Service Model' of e-governance. (15)

[2023] e-governance, as a critical tool of governance, has ushered in effectiveness, transparency and accountability in governments. What inadequacies hamper the enhancement of these features? 10

[2022] Reforming the government delivery system through the Direct Benefit Transfer Scheme is a progressive step, but it has its limitations too. Comment. (10)

[2021] Has digital illiteracy, particularly in rural areas, coupled with lack of Information and Communication Technology(ICT) accessibility hindered socio-economic development? Examine with justification. (15)

[2020] "The emergence of the Fourth Industrial Revolution (Digital Revolution) has initiated e-Governance as an integral part of government". Discuss. (10)

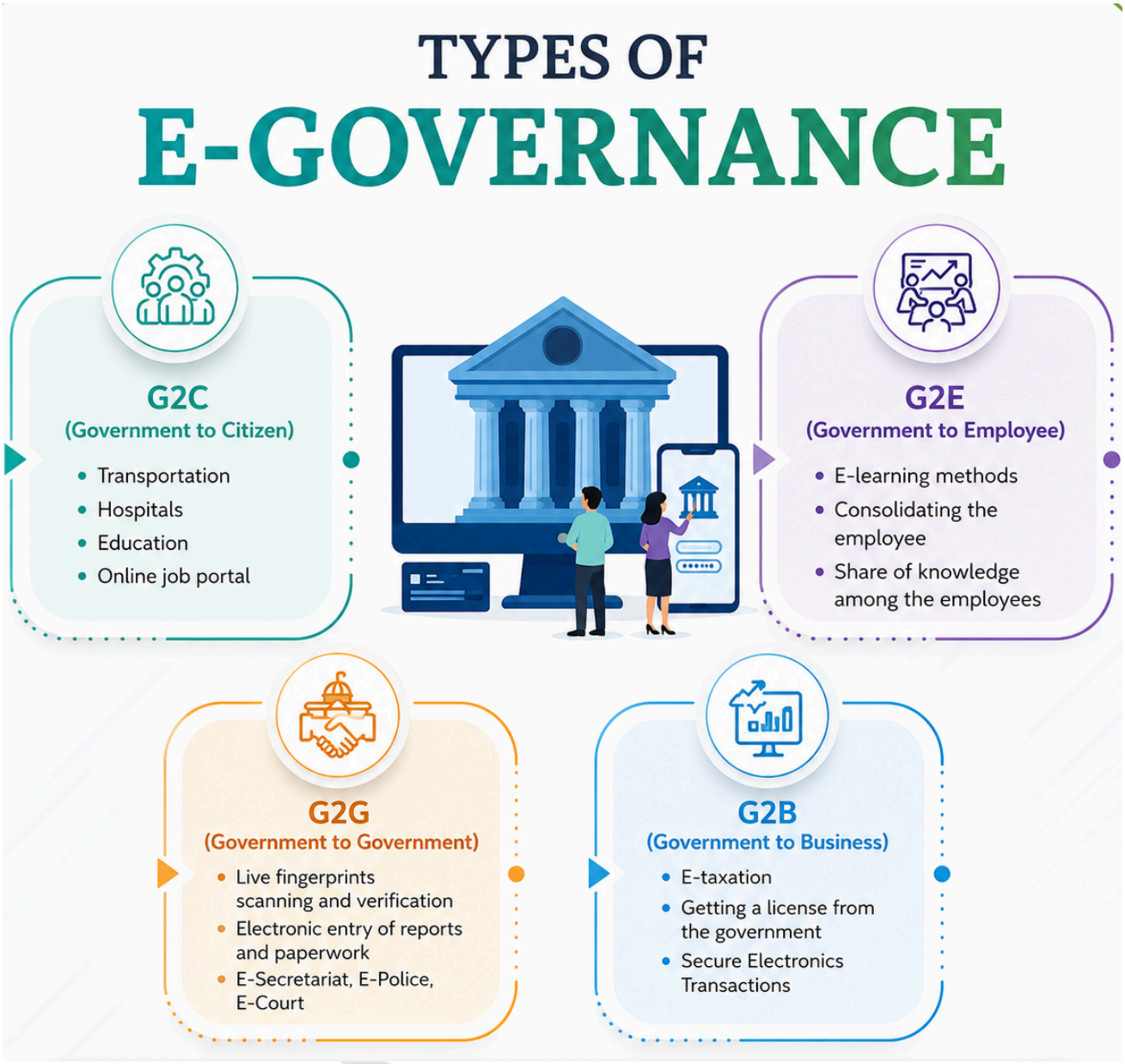
[2019] Implementation of information and Communication Technology (ICT) based Projects / Programmes usually suffers in terms of certain vital factors. Identify these factors, and suggest measures for their effective implementation. (10)

[2018] E-governance is not only about utilization of the power of new technology, but also much about the critical importance of the 'use value' of information. Explain. (10)

The World Bank defines e-governance as the use by government agencies of information technologies that can transform relations with citizens, businesses, and other arms of government.

"E-governance is easy governance, effective governance, and also economic governance. E-governance paves the way for good governance." - **Narendra Modi**

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Data

1. **The Digital Economy** contributed **13% to GDP in 2025-26**. Expected to reach **~20% by 2030**.
2. **Infrastructure**
   a. **1 billion internet connections**. Active internet users reached **958 million** in 2026.
   b. **Rural India accounts for 57%** of active internet users (~548 million), growing four times faster than urban regions.
   c. **BharatNet:** Over **2.15 lakh Gram Panchayats** are connected via optical fiber.
   d. India is the world's 2nd largest 5G market. 5G services cover **99.9% of districts.**
3. **Language Inclusion (BHASHINI):** Supports **35+ Indian languages, 1,600+ AI models, 18 language services**.
4. **Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI)**
   a. Over **144 crore Aadhaar numbers** have been generated. In 2025 alone, more than **2,707 crore** authentication transactions were performed.

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b. **UPI Dominance: ₹300 lakh crore** processed via **228 billion** transactions (2025). Powers **85% of India's digital payments** and **~50% of global** real-time transactions.

c. **DigiLocker Growth:** over **62 crore registered users** with more than **832 crore documents** issued digitally.

d. **DBT Savings:** estimated **₹3.48 lakh crore** by eliminating leakages and "ghost" beneficiaries.

e. **Jan Dhan Accounts:** Total **57.71 crore** accounts with deposits exceeding **₹2.94 lakh crore**. Over 55% of these accounts belong to women.



5. **E-Service Delivery**

a. **Total E-Services:** India provides **24,563 e-services** across States and UTs.

b. **Service Saturation:** 13 States have achieved **100% saturation** of the 59 mandatory e-services. National saturation stands at **>81%**.

c. **UMANG Platform:** Provides a single-window access to over **2,000 central and state services** to crores of monthly active users.

6. **E-Governance in Education (PM e-VIDYA)**

a. **DIKSHA (School Education):** Registered users reached **2.1 crore** in early 2026. Offers curriculum-linked content in **33+ languages** using AI translation.

b. **SWAYAM (Higher Education):**
Cumulative enrollments crossed **5.80 crore learners** by January 2026.
Over **4,400 unique courses** are active, with **52.8 lakh certifications** awarded.

c. **SWAYAM Prabha (On-Air):**
Expanded to **48 DTH channels** delivering 24/7 educational content.
Specialized channels for **CWSN** (Children with Special Needs) including sign-language content.
Academic Bank of Credits (ABC): Over **3.5 crore higher education students** are now using the ABC to digitally store and transfer credits between universities.

7. **E-Governance in Health**

a. Approximately **88.5 crore ABHA (Ayushman Bharat Health Account)** IDs have been created.

b. Over **65 crore health records** have been digitally linked to ABHA IDs.

c. **Telemedicine (e-Sanjeevani)** Served over **39.5 crore patients** since inception.

d. **3.21 lakh healthcare facilities** and **2.24 lakh doctors** are registered on the National Health Registries (HFR/HPR).

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8. **Emerging Tech & Governance**
    a. **IndiaAI Mission:** India acquired **38,000 GPUs** by late 2025 to power sovereign AI. India ranks **3rd globally** in the 2025 Global AI Vibrancy Ranking.
    b. **Mission Karmayogi:** Over **1.64 crore "Karmayogis"** (government officials) are now onboarded on the iGOT platform for digital-first behavioral and functional training.

State Government E-Governance Initiatives in India

1. **e-UNNAT (Jammu & Kashmir):** Provides over 1,100 services online. J&K transitioned to 100% digital service delivery in 2024-25.
2. **Seva Sindhu (Karnataka):** One-stop-shop for all departmental services. Integrated with the Sakala Mission, it ensures that if a service is not delivered within the timeframe listed in the Citizen Charter, the officer is fined, and the citizen is compensated automatically.
3. **Nivesh Mitra (Uttar Pradesh):** Single Window Clearance for Entrepreneurs.
4. **e-Mitra (Rajasthan):** Public-Private Partnership (PPP) based Kiosk model. Over 85,000 kiosks across the state.
5. **MahaIT / Aaple Sarkar (Maharashtra):** Handles over 2 crore transactions annually. Its integration with DigiLocker ensures that certificates issued (caste, domicile) are automatically pushed to the citizen's digital vault.
6. **Bhulekh (Odisha):** Online access to land records and ownership details.
7. **Bhoomi Project (**Karnataka**):** Digitization of land records and mutation services.

Benefits of e-Governance

For Government

1. **Improved Policy Implementation:** Real-time data from MIS and dashboards enables **evidence-based decision-making.** Eg. PM Gati Shakti platform.
2. **Enhanced Transparency:** Online systems reduce discretion and corruption through **audit trails** and **public data disclosure**.
3. **Cost and Time Efficiency:** Automation reduces paperwork, manual processing, and duplication across ministries.
4. **Better Inter-departmental Coordination:** Integrated platforms like **e-Office**, **SPARROW**, and **CPGRAMS** improve information flow.
5. **Fiscal Management:** Digital payments (PFMS, GeM) ensure **direct fund tracking** and **reduction in leakages**.
6. **Disaster and Crisis Response:** Digital governance tools enable **real-time monitoring and quick response** Eg. CoWIN, Aarogya Setu.

For Citizens

1. **Ease of Access to Services:** 24×7 online access to certificates, licenses, and schemes Eg. **UMANG, DigiLocker**.
2. **Reduced Corruption and Intermediaries:** Direct interface with government through **DBT and Aadhaar authentication**.
3. **Inclusive Service Delivery:** CSCs and **mobile governance** extend services to **rural and remote areas**.
4. **Empowerment through Information: Open Government Data (OGD)** and **RTI portals** strengthen citizen awareness and participation.
5. **Faster Grievance Redressal:** Platforms like **CPGRAMS** and **MyGov** enable real-time complaint resolution and policy feedback.

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For Businesses

1. **Simplified Regulatory Processes:** Online systems like **MCA21**, **GSTN**, and **NSWS** streamline approvals and compliance.
2. **Ease of Doing Business:** Paperless, faceless processes reduce delays and improve India's global competitiveness.
3. **Transparency in Procurement: Government e-Marketplace (GeM)** ensures open, competitive bidding and fair pricing.
4. **Digital Payments and Tax Systems:** e-Payments, **TReDS**, and e-Procurement ensure efficient financial transactions.
5. **Predictable Business Environment:** Data-driven governance promotes **policy stability** and investor confidence.

For Administration

1. **Improved Record Management: e-Office, e-File, and e-District** systems streamline file movement and documentation.
2. **Enhanced Monitoring and Evaluation:** Real-time dashboards help top-level monitoring of projects. Eg. **PRAGATI**
3. **Reduced Bureaucratic Red Tape:** Automation simplifies approvals and interdepartmental coordination.
4. **Skill Development and Capacity Building:** Eg. mission karmayogi iGot platform
5. **Accountability and Performance Tracking:** Online service delivery makes officers accountable through measurable timelines.
6. **Paperless and Eco-friendly Administration:** Digital correspondence reduces environmental impact and office costs.
7. **It lays the foundation for SMART Governance:**
   a. **Simple** - E-documentation, online submission, online service delivery, etc.
   b. **Moral**- Removes bribes, red-tapism.
   c. **Accountable** - All data is available online for everyone.
   d. **Responsive** - More informed citizens --> responsible govt.
   e. **Transparent** - No room for concealing information.

USE VALUE OF INFORMATION

Use value of information refers to the **practical worth or benefit** that information provides to a user when applied for decision-making, problem-solving, or achieving specific goals.

Significance

- **Decision-Making Value** - It reduces uncertainty and provides evidence-based options for action. **Eg.** RBI uses inflation data to decide repo rate.
- **Operational Value** - Improves day-to-day functioning of organisations through real-time monitoring. **Eg.** Indian Railways' Real-Time Train Information System (RTIS).
- **Strategic Value** - Information helps in long-term planning, foresight, and competitive positioning by identifying trends and patterns. **Eg.** NITI Aayog's NDAP.
- **Economic/Commercial Value** - Data-driven products and services generate revenue and economic growth.
- **Social/Welfare Value** - Information helps target welfare schemes accurately & reduce leakages. **Eg.** DBT enabled direct transfer of **₹40+ lakh crore** across 1,200+ schemes.
- **Predictive/Anticipatory Value** - It enables forecasting future events, risks, and opportunities - crucial for disaster management and planning. **Eg.** IMD's AI-based cyclone tracking.

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- **Transparency & Accountability Value -** Information empowers citizens to hold governments accountable & exposing corruption. **Eg.** RTI exposed scams like 2G spectrum.
- **Educational/Knowledge Value -** Information builds human capital through learning, skilling, and capacity-building. **Eg.** SWAYAM platform offers 5,000+ MOOC courses.

ISSUES AND CHALLENGES:

Policy and Legal Challenges

1. **Regulatory Gap for Emerging Tech:** Existing laws (IT Act 2000) are outdated for AI, Deepfakes, and Blockchain. **Eg. Lack of a specific "AI Liability" law**.
2. **Privacy vs. Transparency Conflict:** The **DPDP Act 2023** blanket ban on "personal information" has weakened the RTI Act.
3. **Lack of Inter-operability Standards:** Different states use different software architectures, making cross-border data exchange difficult.

Social and Demographic Dimension

1. **The Persistence of Digital Divide: Only 38% of rural households** have high-speed broadband vs. 85% in urban clusters.
2. **Digital Illiteracy:** only 38% rural population digitally literate. **Eg. Dependence on "CSC Middlemen"** for simple tasks like PM-Kisan registration due to UI/UX complexity.
3. **Linguistic Barriers:** Eg. **Despite "Bhashini,"** real-time voice-to-text accuracy in tribal dialects (like Santhali or Gondi) remains below 60%.
4. **Digital gender gap:** Only 37% of Indian women have adopted mobile internet and only 26% use it regularly. (UNDP).
5. **Aadhaar exclusion:** A 2017 starvation death in Jharkhand's Simdega due to Aadhaar-linked ration card failure exposed authentication risks.

Institutional and Administrative Dimension

1. **Bureaucratic Resistance:** Lower-level officials often view e-governance as a threat to their discretionary power.
2. **Manpower & Skill Gaps:** Eg. **Dependence on private consultants** for maintaining critical state data centers (SDCs).
3. **Poor Grievance Redressal: CPGRAMS 7.0 reports 20% pendency** exceeding 30 days due to lack of local-level "Digital Accountability."

Economic and Financial Dimension

1. **Affordability barrier:** Smartphones remain unaffordable for 27% of rural households despite cheap data plans.
2. **High implementation cost:** Maintenance, hardware refresh and software upgrades strain smaller state IT budgets like in NE states.
3. **Inadequate cyber budget:** Union Budget 2026-27 allocated only ₹790 crore for cybersecurity.

Security and Technical Dimension

1. **Cybersecurity Threats: CERT-In reported 2.94 million cyber incidents** in 2025, specifically targeting state-owned utility grids.
2. Due to fraudulent transactions and misuse of data, the **trust of the people** is compromised. Eg. leaking of Aadhar Data.
3. **Citizen financial loss:** Indians lost ₹22,845 crore to cyber fraud in 2024, up 206% from ₹7,465 crore in 2023.

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Infrastructural dimension

1. **Rural-urban tele-density gap:** Urban tele-density stood at 151% while rural lagged at just 60% (TRAI Report).
2. **Low fiber penetration in villages:** Only 3.8% of rural households have fiber connections vs 15.3% in urban areas (NSSO 80th Round, 2025).
3. **Slow internet speeds:** India ranked 26th globally for mobile internet speeds in November 2025, behind South Korea and Singapore.
4. **Power and connectivity failures:** Aadhaar-based PDS authentication frequently fails due to weak 2G networks and erratic power supply.

Emerging/technological dimension

1. **AI-powered fraud rise:** Deepfake videos impersonating officials, family members emerged as major fraud vectors in 2025 (DSCI Report).
2. **Surveillance concerns:** Aadhaar linkage across schemes raises mass profiling and privacy violation risks.
3. **Less than 9% encryption:** Less than 9% of sensitive cloud data in India is encrypted, increasing breach impact (Check Point 2025).

WAY FORWARD

1. Enact a **National e-Governance Act** to make digital service delivery a mandatory right rather than an administrative choice.
2. **Accelerate BharatNet completion:** Connect remaining 55,000 GPs and 3.8 lakh non-GP villages by 2026 under Amended BharatNet Programme.
3. Strengthen **Common Service Centres** as "Digital Post Offices." Eg. **Rajasthan's e-Mitra** model
4. **Adopt X-Road interoperability layer (Estonia):** handles 2.7 billion data queries with "once-only" principle - citizen submits info only once. 99% services online.
5. **Implement 2nd ARC's 11th Report fully:**
   a. Adopt a national "enterprise architecture" framework.
   b. Mandatory Business Process Re-engineering before digitisation.
   c. Build SMART (Simple, Moral, Accountable, Responsive, Transparent) governance.
6. **Strengthen PMGDISHA-style programs to bridge digital divide:**
   a. Set gender-specific targets.
   b. Replicate Kerala's Akshaya model and Google's Internet Saathi.
   c. Provide subsidised smartphones to rural women (MeitY 2024).
7. **Mandate multilingual portals:** Use Bhashini (AI translation in 14 languages) and SabhaSaar tool.
8. **Strengthen CERT-In** and adopt **"security-by-design"** for all DPI.
9. **Leverage AI/Blockchain:** Use AI for predictive grievance redressal (CPGRAMS), blockchain for tamper-proof land records (Telangana model).

2ND ARC ON E-GOVERNANCE

Building the Foundation

- **Government Commitment:** Political will and support at all levels.
- **Public Awareness &** demand for e-government services.
- Government **Process Reengineering** to be compatible with e-governance.
- **State Data Centers** for secure data management.

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Fourth Industrial Revolution and E-Governance

Key Pillars - Industry 4.0 is built on nine interconnected technological pillars that create "Cyber-Physical Systems" (CPS).

- **Big Data & Analytics**
- **Autonomous Robots**
- **Simulation (Digital Twins)**
- **Universal System Integration**
- **Industrial Internet of Things (IIoT)**
- **Cybersecurity**
- **Cloud Computing**
- **Additive Manufacturing (3D Printing)**
- **Augmented Reality (AR)**

Role of E-Governance in the 4IR Era

- **Data-Driven Policymaking** - Eg. **NITI Aayog's NDAP integrates 52 ministries' data**
- **Transition to "Anticipatory" Governance** - predict citizen needs before they apply.
- **Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) as a Utility** - India's **JAM Trinity** acts as the foundation for all 4IR interactions.
- **Real-time Service Optimization (IoT & AI)** - Eg. **Smart Energy Meters** and AI-managed water grids
- **Enhancing Transparency (Blockchain)** - E-governance uses 4IR's decentralized ledger technology to eliminate "file tampering." Eg. Telangana's blockchain-based land records
- **Inclusive governance (Conversational AI)** - Eg. **Bhashini AI** integration
- **IoT-Enabled Smart Governance** - Eg. Pune's smart traffic management
- **Drone & Geospatial Governance** - Eg. SVAMITVA scheme drone-mapped 3.4 lakh villages

E-governance projects have a built-in bias towards technology and back-end integration than user-centric designs. Examine.

TECHNOLOGY & BACK-END BIAS

Complex user interface + Digital Divide + Digital illiteracy = Digital Exclusion

- **Portals Built in Silos - Eg.** separate logins for **Income Tax, EPFO, GST, Passport Seva**
- **Mandatory Online - Only Approach** excludes those without smartphones, internet, or skills. **27% of rural households** still can't afford smartphones (NSSO 2025).
- **One-Size-Fits-All Design** - Portals designed for urban, English-speaking, smartphone-using youth; ignore tribal, rural, women users.
- **Poor Mobile Optimisation** - Many portals are still desktop-first.
- **Aadhaar-Linked Service Failures- Eg. Santoshi Kumari (11) starvation death** in Simdega, Jharkhand (2017).
- **PM-Kisan Validation Failures** - Multi-stage Aadhaar-bank validation prioritised tech integration over farmer experience.
- **Linguistic Exclusion** - Most government portals in English/Hindi.
- **Digital Illiteracy Ignored - Eg. 1 in 2 rural and 2 in 5 urban offline households** don't know how to use the internet (NSSO CMS-T 2025).
- **Server Crashes During Peak Use** - Eg. **Income Tax portal failures**

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- **Excluding Disabled & Elderly -** Faceless income tax, e-KYC processes inaccessible for visually-impaired.

COUNTER-ARGUMENTS

- **UMANG App - Aggregates 1,700+ services from Centre, States, Local bodies on a single citizen-facing mobile app.**
- **DigiLocker - Citizen-friendly storage; 196 million users, 6.27 billion documents issued.**
- **MyGov Platform - Direct citizen engagement, suggestions, and participation in policymaking.**
- **Bhashini - AI translation in 20 Indian languages, 1 million+ downloads; addresses linguistic exclusion.**
- **Account Aggregator Framework - Consent-based, user-controlled financial data sharing.**
- **PM-WANI Scheme - Public Wi-Fi for last-mile connectivity for non-smartphone users.**
- **Kisan e-Mitra - Voice-based AI chatbot in 11 languages for farmers.**
- **CSCs (5+ lakh centres) - Assisted access for non-digital-native citizens at village level.**

National data governance

The **National Data Governance Framework Policy (NDGFP), 2022 (MeitY)** defines it as a system to "transform and modernize data collection and management of governments through standardised guidelines, rules, data management and security standards."

KEY PILLARS OF DATA GOVERNANCE

1. **Data Quality:** Ensuring accuracy, completeness, consistency, and timeliness of data.
2. **Data Security:** Protecting data through encryption, access controls, and cybersecurity safeguards.
3. **Data Privacy:** Safeguarding personal data and respecting individual consent.
4. **Data Stewardship:** Assigning clear roles (data owners, stewards) and accountability.
5. **Data Architecture:** Building structured systems for storage, integration, and interoperability.
6. **Metadata Management:** Standardising definitions, formats, and lineage of data.
7. **Compliance:** Adherence to laws like DPDP Act 2023, GDPR (where applicable).
8. **Data Lifecycle Management:** Governing data from creation to deletion.

IMPORTANCE OF DATA IN GOVERNANCE

1. **Evidence-Based Policy:** Shifting from "opinion-based" to "data-driven" decisions. **Eg. Using soil health data to target fertilizer subsidies.**
2. **Precision Targeting:** Reducing leakages in welfare. Aadhaar-linked DBT saved **₹3.5 lakh crore**
3. Proactive and efficient Service Delivery
4. **Disaster Resilience:** Real-time tracking for mitigation. **Eg. SACHET portal for geo-targeted cyclone alerts.**
5. **Resource Optimization**: Identifying infrastructure gaps. **Eg. PM Gati Shakti's multi-modal data layers.**
6. **Accountability:** Social audits powered by granular village-level expenditure data.
7. **Predictive governance:** AI-based grievance redressal on CPGRAMS; predictive analytics for crop, traffic, weather.
8. **Transparency and accountability:** RTI + open data portal (data.gov.in) make government records accessible to citizens.

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9. **Financial inclusion:** Account Aggregator framework enables data-based credit access for 50+ crore Jan Dhan account holders.
10. **National security:** Real-time data analytics aids law enforcement. **Eg. I4C froze 24.67 lakh mule accounts using data analytics.**

CHALLENGES IN DATA GOVERNANCE IN INDIA

1. **Data silos:** Most public data collected, stored, and operated in silos with no semantic interoperability across ministries.
2. **Lack of common standards**: Absence of commonly accepted data definitions hampers AI development and inter-departmental sharing.
3. **Government data breaches:** BSNL breach (May 2024) leaked 278 GB; eMigrate Portal (MEA) exposed 2 lakh records; Star Health breach (2024).
4. **Cyber incidents surge:** Rose from 10.29 lakh (2022) to 22.68 lakh (2024). over 120% jump.
5. **Privacy concerns:** Justice Srikrishna criticised DPDP for wide government exemptions on grounds of "sovereignty," "public order."
6. **No specific NPD law:** Non-Personal Data still lacks enforceable regime; NDGFP 2022 still under finalisation.
7. **Cross-border data flow ambiguity:** DPDP allows transfers but list of restricted countries not yet notified by the government.
8. **Capacity deficit:** Most government departments lack trained Data Protection Officers; under 9% of cloud data encrypted (Check Point 2025).
9. **Storage Costs:** Managing "Zettabytes" of public data requires massive capital for Green Data Centres.
10. **Re-identification Risk:** Fears that "anonymized" data can be de-anonymized using advanced AI.
11. **CERT-In RTI exemption (2023)**: Reduces accountability of cybersecurity agencies over breach disclosures (Internet Freedom Foundation).

STEPS TAKEN FOR DATA GOVERNANCE

Legal & Policy Framework

1. **DPDP Act 2023 + DPDP Rules 2025 (notified in, 2025)** - comprehensive data protection law.
2. **Draft National Data Governance Framework Policy (NDGFP), 2022** - for non-personal data sharing.

Institutional Mechanisms

1. **Data Protection Board of India (DPBI) - adjudicating body under DPDP Act.**
2. **India Data Management Office (IDMO)** - under MeitY/DIC.
3. **CERT-In, NCIIPC, I4C** - for cybersecurity coordination.

Key Provisions of the DPDP Act, 2023

The Act is built on the foundation of **consent and accountability**, focusing on three primary actors: **Data Principal** (Citizen), **Data Fiduciary** (Entity collecting data), and **Data Processor** (Entity processing data on behalf of the Fiduciary).

- Applies to **digital personal data** (online or digitized offline data). It has **extra-territorial jurisdiction** if the entity offers goods/services to individuals in India.
- **Consent-Centric Processing:** Data can only be processed for a **lawful purpose** with the individual's "free, specific, informed, unconditional, and unambiguous" consent.
- **Legitimate Uses (Non-Consensual):**
  - Voluntary sharing for a specific purpose.
  - Provision of government subsidies/benefits.

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- Medical emergencies or employment-related purposes.
- **Rights of Data Principals:**
  - **Right to Access:** To know what data is held and with whom it is shared.
  - **Right to Correction/Erasure:** To update inaccurate data or request deletion once the purpose is served.
  - **Right to Grievance Redressal:** Access to a mechanism to resolve complaints.
  - **Right to Nominate:** Appoint a person to exercise rights in case of death or incapacity.
- **Obligations of Data Fiduciaries:**
  - Ensure data **accuracy** and **completeness**.
  - Implement **reasonable security safeguards** to prevent breaches.
  - **Storage Limitation:** Delete data once the specific purpose is met.
- **Significant Data Fiduciaries (SDFs):** Entities notified by the Govt (based on volume/sensitivity of data) must:
  - Appoint a **Data Protection Officer (DPO)** based in India.
  - Conduct periodic **Data Protection Impact Assessments (DPIA)**.
  - Undergo independent **data audits**.
- The Act provides for the establishment of the **Data Protection Board of India for monitoring compliance**, **imposing penalties**, handling **data breach responses** and **hearing grievances**.

Key Provisions of the DPDP Rules, 2025

- **Cross-Border Data Transfers:** Permitted globally except to countries on a government-notified restricted list (yet to be released).
- **Standalone Notices:** Privacy notices cannot be buried in "Terms of Service." They must be **itemized** and in plain language.
- **Ease of Withdrawal:** The process to withdraw consent must be as easy as giving it (Eg. if it took 2 clicks to agree, it must take 2 clicks to opt out).
- Introduces **Consent Managers**, registered intermediaries who allow citizens to manage, review, and withdraw consent across multiple platforms via a single digital dashboard.
- **72-Hour Window:** Data Fiduciaries must notify the **Data Protection Board (DPB)** and the affected individuals of any breach within **72 hours** of becoming aware of it.
- **Mandatory Safeguards:** Specifies technical measures like **encryption, masking, and tokenization** for protecting data at rest and in transit.
- **Verifiable Parental Consent:** Platforms must use "verifiable" methods (ID tokens, government databases) to confirm parental consent for users under 18.
- **Prohibited Practices:** Strict ban on **behavioral tracking** and **targeted advertising** directed at children.
- **Automatic Deletion:** For certain "high-interaction" platforms (like social media with >2 crore users), data must be deleted if the user hasn't logged in for **3 years**, unless legally required otherwise.
- **Exemptions:** Personal/domestic use, public data, research, statistics, and notified government agencies for national security exempted.

WAY FORWARD

1. **Enact Non-Personal Data Law** - Finalize NDGFP and pass enforceable legislation on NPD as per Kris Gopalakrishnan Committee recommendations.
2. **Adopt Estonia's "Once-Only" principle** - Citizen data submitted once should be reused across ministries; reduces redundancy.
3. **Establish national data architecture** - Create common metadata standards and semantic interoperability across all 52 ministries.

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4. **Strengthen institutional independence** - Make DPBI truly autonomous (currently government-appointed); bring CERT-In back under RTI for accountability.
5. **Build state capacity** - Train Data Protection Officers in every ministry/department under iGOT Karmayogi.
6. **Adopt "privacy by design"** - Build encryption, access controls, and audit logs into every government IT system from inception (DPDP Rule 6 mandates).
7. **Digital Empowerment of citizens** - Awareness campaigns about Data Principal rights - to access, correct, erase, and grievance redressal under DPDP Act.
8. **Sectoral data frameworks** for nuanced governance. Eg. Health (DigitalHealth Mission), Finance (Account Aggregator).
9. **Global cooperation** - Align with G20 Digital Public Infrastructure framework (India's 2023 G20 outcome); sign cross-border data adequacy pacts; engage with UN AI Advisory Body.

M-Governance

M-Governance is a sub-domain of e-Governance that leverages mobile technologies (SMS, Apps, USSD, IVRS) to provide public services and information to citizens and businesses anytime, anywhere.

Key Data Points

1. India crossed **1.03 billion internet users** by late 2025, with a penetration rate of **70%** .
2. Approximately **96.6% of internet users** in India access the web via mobile devices.
3. The UMANG app hosts over **1,745 services** with a user base of **5.58 crore** citizens.
4. Average monthly data consumption per Indian reached **36 GB** in 2026, up from 2.8 GB in 2016.
5. India has over **400 million active 5G users** as of January 2026.

Significance of M-Governance

1. **Bridging the Rural-Urban Divide:** Mobile penetration is higher than PC ownership in rural areas.
2. **Financial Inclusion (UPI-Mobile):** Mobile-based UPI handles **₹28.33 lakh crore monthly** (Jan 2026), bringing the unbanked into the formal economy.
3. **Disaster Resilience:** Real-time geo-fencing alerts. Eg. **SACHET app sent 100+ million alerts during the 2025 monsoon.**
4. **Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT):** Eliminating leakages via mobile authentication. **Saved ₹3.5 lakh crore cumulative by late 2025.**
5. **Direct Farmer Connect:** Apps like **Kisan Suvidha** provide real-time market prices.
6. **Empowering the Differently Abled:** Voice-controlled governance. Eg. **DIVYA app (2026) uses AI for screen-reading government forms.**
7. **Ease of Doing Business (MSMEs):** Eg. **Udyam portal on mobile** reduced registration time to under 3 minutes.

Major Issues & Challenges

1. **Cybersecurity Threats:** Mobile apps are "honeypots". **CERT-In reported 2.94 million cyber incidents in 2025.**
2. **Digital Illiteracy:** Elderly and rural populations struggle with complex UIs. **2025 NSO report indicates only 35% of rural adults can use a mobile app independently.**
3. **App Stability Issues:** Eg. **User reviews of UMANG** citing login permission errors and slow speeds.
4. **Privacy Concerns (DPDP Act):** Tension between data sharing and privacy.

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5. **Network Congestion: 20% of rural villages still have unstable 4G/5G signals.**
6. **Linguistic Barriers:** Advanced services are often English-centric
7. **Storage Constraints:** Low-end smartphones (~₹5k-8k) lack space for multiple government apps.
8. **Fragmented Portals:** Citizens often have to download 10 different apps for 10 state services.

Way Forward & Global Best Practices

1. **Implement "Super-Apps":** Consolidate all services into one interface (like UMANG but with better stability) to solve storage and fragmentation issues.
2. **Voice-First Governance:** Use **Bhashini AI** to make all services voice-enabled for those who cannot read or type.
3. **Offline Mode:** Design apps to store data locally and sync when the network returns (**Singapore's LifeSG**).
4. **Zero-Rating Data:** Government should partner with telcos to provide "Data-Free" access to essential M-Gov portals .
5. **"Once-Only" principle:** Adopt Estonia's model where data moves securely between departments, ensuring the citizen only provides info "once."

AI in governance in India

SIGNIFICANCE OF AI IN GOVERNANCE

1. **Targeted Service Delivery** - AI enables precise welfare targeting, reducing leakages and identifying genuine beneficiaries through data analytics.
2. **Predictive Policing** - AI helps predict crime hotspots, identify patterns, and prevent crimes proactively. **Eg.** I4C froze 24.67 lakh mule accounts using AI-based fraud detection in 2024.
3. **Healthcare Transformation** - AI assists diagnosis, drug discovery, and pandemic response, especially in resource-constrained settings.
4. **Educational Personalization:** Tailoring learning content to student needs through adaptive AI platforms. Eg. **DIKSHA 2.0**
5. **Agricultural Productivity** - AI-driven advisories on weather, pest control, and crop selection boost farmer income and yields. Eg. Kisan e-Mitra chatbot in 11 languages
6. **Faster Grievance Redressal** - AI automates complaint analysis and routing, reducing pendency in citizen grievance systems
7. **Judicial Efficiency:** Eg. **"SUVAS" AI tool translates legal documents into 22 regional languages for 10 high courts.**
8. **Linguistic Inclusion** - Eg. Bhashini platform supports 22 Indian languages
9. **Cybersecurity & National Security** - AI detects threats, prevents fraud, identifies deepfakes, and bolsters national defence systems.
10. **Economic Growth Driver** - AI projected to contribute $1.7 trillion to India's economy by 2035
11. **Disaster Management** - AI predicts floods, cyclones, and earthquakes; enables rapid response and resource allocation.
12. **Smart Urban Governance** - AI optimizes traffic, waste management, water supply, and energy use in smart cities. Eg. Bengaluru's AI-sync traffic signals

MAJOR CHALLENGES

1. **Algorithmic Bias** - AI models trained on biased data can discriminate against marginalised groups, denying fair access. Eg. PM-Kisan validation errors stranded 2.18 crore families.

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2. **Deepfake & Misinformation** - Generative AI enables hyper-realistic fake videos, threatening elections, reputations, and social harmony. Eg. Deepfake "digital arrest" scams
3. **Data Privacy Risks** - AI systems require massive data; raises concerns about consent, surveillance, and misuse.
4. **Black Box Problem** - Lack of explainability in deep learning makes AI decisions opaque, hindering accountability.
5. **Job Displacement** - Automation threatens jobs in IT, BPO, manufacturing; widens inequality without reskilling support.
6. **Regulatory Gap** - India lacks dedicated AI law; current rules scattered across IT Act 2000, DPDP Act, sectoral guidelines.
7. **Compute & Data Scarcity** - Heavy dependence on foreign GPUs and lack of India-specific datasets for training models.
8. **Skills & Talent Shortage** - Despite Stanford AI Index ranking India #1 in skill penetration, deep tech talent remains limited.
9. **Ethical & Constitutional Concerns** - Use of Facial Recognition Technology (FRT), surveillance raise rights violation concerns.

AI REGULATION IN INDIA

1. **"Lightweight" Approach** - India has chosen **NOT to enact a dedicated AI Act**; instead leverages existing laws - IT Act 2000, DPDP Act 2023, Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita 2023, Consumer Protection Act 2019.
2. **IT Amendment Rules, 2026:** Mandates prominent labeling of **Synthetically Generated Information (SGI)**; requires takedown of harmful deepfakes within **3 hours**.
3. **India AI Governance Guidelines** - Principle-based, **techno-legal framework**; drafted by Prof. Balaraman Ravindran Committee. Built on **Seven Sutras** and **Six Pillars**

   Seven Sutras (Principles):
   a. Trust as Foundation
   b. People First
   c. Innovation over Restraint
   d. Fairness & Equity
   e. Accountability
   f. Understandable by Design
   g. Safety, Resilience & Sustainability

   Six Pillars: Infrastructure, Capacity Building, Policy & Regulation, Risk Mitigation, Accountability, Institutions.
4. **IndiaAI Mission (March 2024) -**
   a. **IndiaAI Compute** - 38,000+ GPUs onboarded at subsidised ₹65/hour.
   b. **Application Development Initiative** - 30 applications approved by July 2025; CyberGuard AI Hackathon.
   c. **AIKosh (Dataset Platform)** - 5,500+ datasets, 251 AI models across 20 sectors; 3,85,000 visits, 11,000 users, 26,000 downloads (Dec 2025).
   d. **Foundation Models** - 12 startups selected for developing India's own Large Multimodal Models using Indian data and languages.
   e. **FutureSkills** - Supports 8,000 UG, 5,000 PG, 500 PhD scholars; 31 Data and AI Labs launched; 73 institutes onboarding PhD students.
   f. **Startup Financing** - IndiaAI Startups Global program (March 2025) helps 10 startups expand to Europe via Station F & HEC Paris.
   g. **Safe & Trusted AI** - 13 projects selected; AI Safety Institute EoI on 9 May 2025.

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5. **National Strategy for AI, 2018 (NITI Aayog) -** First strategic document; "AI for All" vision; identified 5 focus sectors - healthcare, agriculture, education, smart cities, smart mobility.
6. **Sectoral Regulators**
   a. **RBI**: Cybersecurity Framework for AI in fintech
   b. **SEBI**: Oversees AI in trading algorithms
   c. **IRDAI**: AI in insurance underwriting
   d. **ICMR**: Ethical Guidelines for AI in Biomedical Research
7. **New Institutional Mechanisms (Proposed in Nov 2025 Guidelines)**
   a. **AI Governance Group (AIGG)** - inter-agency coordination
   b. **AI Safety Institute (AISI)** - testing, benchmarks, evaluations
   c. **Technology & Policy Expert Committee (TPEC)** - technical advisory

GLOBAL BEST PRACTICES

1. **EU AI Act (2024) - Risk-Based Approach -** Classifies AI into 4 risk tiers: unacceptable (banned), high, limited, minimal. Mandates transparency and conformity assessments. Penalties up to €35 million or 7% global turnover.
2. **China - Generative AI Regulations (2023) -** Strict content controls; mandatory security assessments; algorithm registration; deepfake labelling requirements.
3. **OECD AI Principles (2019) -** 10 principles on inclusive growth, human-centred values, transparency, accountability, robustness.

WAY FORWARD

1. **Operationalize India AI Governance Guidelines Promptly -** Notify AI Governance Group (AIGG), AI Safety Institute (AISI), and Technology & Policy Expert Committee (TPEC); fully resource them.
2. **Adopt Risk-Based Regulation (NITI Aayog) -** Stratify AI use cases by risk level - high-risk, medium-risk (healthcare diagnosis), low-risk (chatbots). Differentiated obligations.
3. Pass **Digital India Act** to replace IT Act 2000 - redefine "intermediary" to cover Generative AI; clarify safe harbour under Section 79.
4. **Strengthen Data Foundations -** finalize National Data Governance Framework Policy; expand IndiaAI Datasets Platform with diverse, anonymised data.
5. **Build Sovereign Compute Infrastructure -** develop indigenous AI chips under India Semiconductor Mission; promote affordable, shared compute access for startups and researchers.
6. **Mandate Transparency & Explainability -** mandate algorithm audits, bias testing, and explainable AI (XAI) for high-risk systems.
7. **Capacity Building & Skilling -** Expand IndiaAI FutureSkills - train 1 lakh+ AI professionals by 2030, establish more Centres of Excellence.
8. **Deepfake & Misinformation Safeguards -** Mandate watermarking of AI-generated content & collaborate with platforms for rapid takedown of harmful synthetic media.
9. **Global Cooperation & Leadership -** Lead Global South AI agenda & engage with the UN AI Advisory Body for global benchmarks.

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Chapter 3

Development Process and Development Industry in India

PYQs

[2026] To what extent do pressure groups, social movements and corporate lobbies deepen pluralistic democracy in India by representing excluded interests? Analyse whether the growing convergence of corporate wealth and political power poses a threat to the autonomy of formal democratic institutions. (15)

[2025] Civil Society Organizations are often perceived as being more anti-State actors than non-State actors. Do you agree? Justify. (10)

[2025] What are environmental pressure groups? Discuss their role in raising awareness, influencing policies and advocating for environmental protection in India. (15)

[2025] "In contemporary development models, decision-making and problem-solving responsibilities are not located close to the source of information and execution, defeating the objectives of development." Critically evaluate. (15)

[2024] Public charitable trusts have the potential to make India's development more inclusive as they relate to certain vital public issues. Comment. (10)

[2023] Discuss the contribution of civil society groups for women's effective and meaningful participation and representation in state legislatures in India. 15

[2022] The Gati-Shakti Yojana needs meticulous coordination between the government and the private sector to achieve the goal of connectivity. Discuss. (10)

[2021] "Pressure groups play a vital role in influencing public policy making in India." Explain how the business associations contribute to public policies. (10)

[2021] Can Civil Society and Non-Governmental Organizations present an alternative model of public service delivery to benefit the common citizen. Discuss the challenges of this alternative model. (15)

[2021] Can the vicious cycle of gender inequality, poverty and malnutrition be broken through microfinancing of women SHGs? Explain with examples. (10)

[2020] "Micro-Finance as an anti-poverty vaccine, is aimed at asset creation and income security of the rural poor in India". Evaluate the role of Self-Help Groups in achieving the twin objectives along with empowering women in rural India. (15)

[2019] 'In the context of neo-liberal paradigm of development planning, multi-level planning is expected to make operations cost effective and remove many implementation blockages.' Discuss. (15)

[2019] The need for cooperation among various service sectors has been an inherent component of development discourse. Partnership bridges bring the gap among the sectors. It also sets in motion a culture of 'Collaboration' and 'team spirit'. In the light of statements above examine India's Development process. (15)

[2019] What are the methods used by the Farmers organizations to influence the policy- makers in India and how effective are these methods? (10)

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[2018] "Policy contradictions among various competing sectors and stakeholders have resulted in inadequate protection and prevention of degradation to the environment." Comment with relevant illustrations. (10)

DEVELOPMENT INDUSTRY IN INDIA

1. **The United Nations** defines **development as a comprehensive economic, social, and political process** that aims to improve the **well-being and quality** of life of people.
2. The **"Development Industry"** refers to the **vast ecosystem of organisations, agencies, professionals, and funding flows** that drive **socio-economic development**.
3. **Development processes** refer to the **multi-faceted, multi-actor, sequenced approaches** through which a society advances economically, socially, politically, environmentally, and culturally.
4. It includes **government bodies, NGOs, multilateral and bilateral donor agencies, corporate CSR, philanthropic foundations, social enterprises, consultancies, research institutions, and academia**.
5. The term **"development industry"** was popularised by scholars like **James Ferguson (1990, "The Anti-Politics Machine")** and **Arturo Escobar (1995, "Encountering Development")** - critically describing development as an **organised, professionalised, well-funded sector** with its own bureaucracies, jargon, careers, and priorities.
6. The **2nd ARC's 9th Report (2008)** rightly observed that **"social capital is a shared destiny"**, requiring **structured engagement** between **State, Market, Civil Society, and Citizens**.

- According to **Amartya Sen's capability approach (Development as Freedom, 1999)**, development is the **expansion of human freedoms** & not just GDP growth.
- **Mahatma Gandhi's "Sarvodaya"** envisioned **welfare of all**
- **Dr. B.R. Ambedkar's vision** prioritised **social democracy** as the foundation of political democracy.

Development in India has evolved through different paradigms:

1. **State-led** (Nehruvian planning, 1947-1980s)
2. **Market-led** (post-1991 LPG reforms)
3. **Rights-based** (2000s - RTI, MGNREGA, NFSA)
4. **Multi-stakeholder/SDG-aligned** (2014-present)

KEY DIMENSIONS OF DEVELOPMENT

1. **Economic Development** - GDP growth, industrialisation, infrastructure, employment, financial inclusion.
2. **Social Development** - Education, health, gender equality, social inclusion, poverty alleviation.
3. **Human Development** - Capabilities, dignity, choices, freedoms (Sen, Mahbub ul Haq).
4. **Sustainable Development** - Environmental protection, climate action, intergenerational equity.
5. **Political Development** - Democratic deepening, decentralisation, participation, rights.
6. **Cultural Development** - Heritage protection, linguistic diversity, plurality.
7. **Technological Development** - Digital transformation, innovation, R&D, AI/4IR.
8. **Inclusive Development** - Equitable access for dalits, tribals, women, minorities, persons with disabilities.

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TYPES OF DEVELOPMENT PROCESSES

- **Top-Down vs Bottom-Up Approach -** Centrally planned (Nehruvian model) vs Panchayati Raj, SHGs, community-driven (Gandhi's vision).
- **State-Led vs Market-Led -** PSUs, Five-Year Plans vs Post-1991 reforms; PPP models.
- **Growth-Centric vs Welfare-Centric -** GDP-focused (Mahalanobis model) vs MGNREGA, NFSA - rights-based.
- **Sector-Specific vs Integrated Approach -** PMAY (Housing), Ayushman Bharat (Health) vs Aspirational Districts; Smart Cities Mission.
- **Capital-Intensive vs Labour-Intensive -** Heavy industries, IT vs MGNREGA, PMKVY, MSMEs.
- **Centralised vs Decentralised -** Centrally Sponsored Schemes (CSS) vs PRIs.
- **Rights-Based vs Need-Based -** NFSA (legal entitlement) vs Subsidies, targeted welfare.

Major Stages of the Developmental Process in the Neoliberal Paradigm

Policy Formulation Stage- To design evidence-based, participatory, and coordinated policies aligning national goals with local needs.

1. **Integrated Planning** - Multi-sectoral, multi-level planning. Eg. PM Gati Shakti.
2. **Bottom-Up Approach** - Eg. PESA
3. **Rationalisation and Deregulation** - Eg. **EoDB**, **Single Window Clearance System**.

Policy Implementation Stage - To ensure efficient, transparent, and inclusive execution of development programmes.

1. **Outcome-Oriented Governance** - Focus on **measurable results** through performance indicators. Eg. PFMS, PRAGATI Portal
2. **Avoiding Duplication and Overlaps** - Eg. Samagra Shiksha Abhiyan
3. **Public-Private Partnerships (PPPs)** - Eg. **Smart Cities Mission**, **Bharatmala Project**.
4. **Technology-Driven Implementation** - Eg. **GeM portal**, **JAM trinity**.
5. **Decentralized Execution** - Eg. **District Mineral Foundation (DMF)**.

Monitoring and Evaluation Stage- To ensure accountability, transparency, and learning through continuous review.

1. **Data-Driven Monitoring** - Use of **dashboards, MIS, and real-time analytics**. **Eg. Aspirational district program**.
2. **Social Accountability** - Citizens directly monitor outcomes through **social audits, public hearings, and RTI**. **Eg. Jan Sunwai in Rajasthan**.
3. **Feedback Loops and Corrective Action** - Eg. **MyGov platform**, **CPGRAMS**.

Crisis Management and Adaptive Response Stage- To ensure continuity, resilience, and adaptability of development during emergencies.

1. **Institutional Flexibility** - Eg. **Atmanirbhar Bharat Abhiyan** during COVID-19.
2. **Multi-Stakeholder Coordination** - Eg. **COVID-19 vaccination drive** combining government logistics with CSR and volunteer support.
3. **Safety Nets for Vulnerable Groups** - Eg. PM Garib Kalyan Yojana.
4. **Learning and Institutional Resilience** - Incorporating **crisis lessons** into long-term policy frameworks.

Achievements of development process

Political

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- **46% women representation in local bodies**
- **Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam**

Social Development & Poverty Reduction

- **Poverty Levels:** extreme poverty in India has declined significantly to **5.3% (WB)**.
- **415 million escaped multidimensional poverty (2005-2021)** - UNDP/OPHI.
- **MPI dropped from 55% to 11.28%** (NITI Aayog 2024).
- **Universal food security** through NFSA
- **Clean Water & Sanitation:**
  - **99.6%** of rural households now have access to improved drinking water sources.
  - Over **96% of villages** achieved "ODF Plus" status under the Swachh Bharat Mission.
- **Health:** MMR declined from **130 (2014-16) to 97 (2018-20)**

Economic

- **GDP Growth:** India remains the fastest-growing major economy globally.
- **Forex Reserves** reached a historic high of **$701.4 billion** in 2026.

Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) & Financial Inclusion

- **Aadhaar & Identity:** Over **144 crore** unique digital IDs have been generated.
- **UPI:** In January 2026, UPI processed **21.7 billion transactions** worth approximately **₹28.33 lakh crore** in a single month.
- **Jan Dhan Yojana:** accounts reached **57.71 crore**, with deposits exceeding **₹2.94 lakh crore**.
- **Connectivity:** 5G services now cover **99.9% of districts** in India.

Infrastructure

- **Road Expansion: National Highway network: 1.46 lakh km (2024)** vs 33,650 km (1991).
- **Aviation:** India is now the world's 3rd largest domestic aviation market.
- **Renewable Energy:** India achieved its Paris Agreement target (50% electric capacity from non-fossil sources) in June 2025.

Major Challenges in the Neoliberal Developmental Process

Economic Challenges

1. **Rising Inequality - Oxfam (2025):** Top 1% own more than 40% of India's wealth.
2. **Jobless Growth** due to automation and capital-intensive industries.
3. **Agrarian Distress** - **stagnant farm incomes, rising farmer suicides.**
4. **Overdependence on the Private Sector** - PPPs often lead to **cost escalation and profit over public welfare**.

Social Challenges

1. **Exclusion** - Market-led reforms benefit **urban and skilled groups**, marginalizing **rural poor, tribals, and women**. Eg. Digital divide.
2. **Erosion of Welfare State** - Neoliberalism prioritizes fiscal discipline, leading to **cuts in social expenditure**. Eg. Reduction in **subsidies and welfare allocations**.
3. **Regional Imbalances** - Rich states grow faster than poor states. Eg. Southern states vs BIMARU states
4. **Marginalisation of Vulnerable Groups - Eg. forest rights eroded** by mining/dams.
5. **Commodification of Social Sectors** - Eg. Rise in **private education and hospital costs**.

Governance and Institutional Challenges

1. **Weak Regulatory Capacity** - Regulatory capture by powerful corporate interests limits transparency.

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2. **Policy Fragmentation** - Multiple ministries and overlapping jurisdictions hinder **policy coherence**. Eg. overlapping central-state policies.
3. **Accountability Deficits** - Privatization blurs **public responsibility**; weak grievance redressal in PPPs.
4. **Bureaucratic Resistance and** legacy of hierarchical bureaucracy limits **adaptability to participatory governance**. Eg. marginalisation of Gram Sabhas.

Environmental and Sustainability Challenges

1. **Resource Overexploitation** - Growth-oriented development leads to **deforestation, groundwater depletion, and pollution**.
2. **Unsustainable Urbanization** - Rapid city expansion without ecological planning causes **waste mismanagement and congestion**. Eg. Urban Flooding.
3. **Climate Vulnerability and Inequity** - Poor communities bear a disproportionate burden of **climate disasters and displacement**.

Technological and Digital Challenges

1. **Digital Divide** - Only **43% rural households** have internet access (NFHS-5, 2021).
2. **Data Privacy and Cybersecurity Risks** - Eg. **Aadhaar data leak**.
3. **Automation and Future of Work** - AI and robotics threaten traditional jobs; absence of social protection systems for displaced workers.

Crisis Management and Resilience Gaps

1. **Weak Safety Nets - 90%+ workforce in the informal sector without social security.**
2. **Over-centralization during emergencies**- Eg. Disaster Management Act during COVID.

Way Forward for Strengthening the Neoliberal Developmental Process

1. **Inclusive Growth Model** - Address inequality through progressive taxation and universal services. Eg. Implement **wealth tax/inheritance tax** (Piketty).
2. **Strengthen Public Services** - Eg. Health spending to **5% of GDP**; education to **6% (NEP 2020 target)**.
3. **Universal Social Protection** - Extend safety net to informal workers comprehensively. Eg. **E-Shram** to be linked with PMJAY, pension, insurance.
4. **Decent Work Agenda** - Quality jobs in MSMEs, manufacturing, services. Eg. minimum wages enforcement; social security for all.
5. **Climate-Just Development** - Green growth aligned with climate goals. Eg. **net-zero by 2070** (India's NDC); LiFE movement.



Stakeholders in governance

6. **Cooperative Federalism** - Strengthen GST Council & address state revenue concerns.
7. **Sen's Capability Approach** - focus on freedoms, capabilities. Eg. **HDI improvement** as core metric.
8. **Strengthening Institutional Foundations**
   a. From **"Generalist" to "Specialist" Governance** through Mission Karmayogi and Lateral entry.
   b. Moving toward a **"Trust-based" Compliance** regime for reducing "Inspector Raj."

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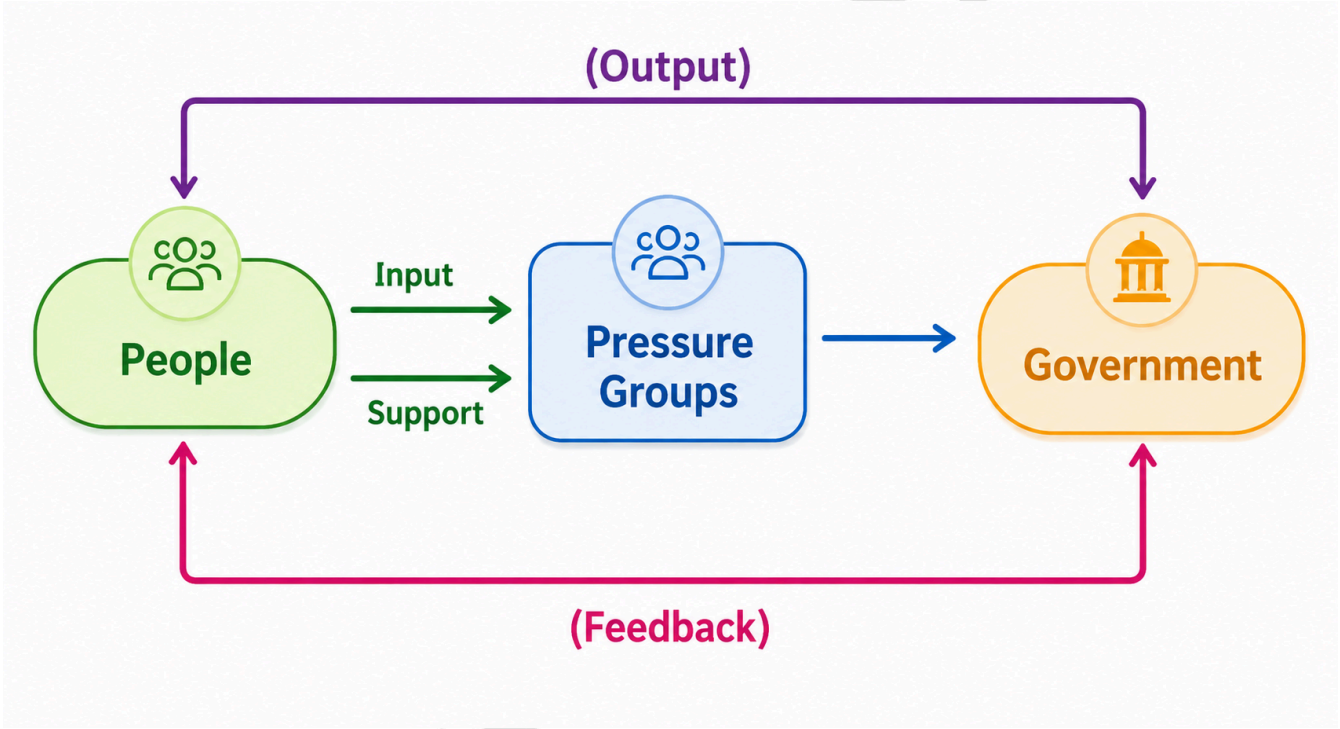
9. **Global Leadership** - Lead Global South through inclusive globalisation. **Eg.** DPI exports to 50+ countries.

NGO sector in India

NGOs or **CSOs** are voluntary, not-for-profit entities that operate independently of the government to address social, economic, environmental, and political issues.

India has **34+ lakh registered NGOs** (NITI Aayog Darpan portal), among the largest in the world.

The **2nd ARC** notes that "NGOs are the conscience keepers of the nation."



Legal Provisions:

1. **Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA), 2010:** The law makes sure that those who receive foreign donations use them for their intended purpose.
2. Indian NGOs come under 3 segments:
   a. **Societies**: Societies have to register under **the Societies Registration Act, 1860.**
   b. **Trusts**: Private trusts are registered under the central government's **Indian Trusts Act, 1882**, and public ones are registered under the state legislation concerned.
   c. **Companies**: They are set up according to section 8 of the **Companies Act, 2013.**

Role of NGOs

PESTLE Framework

Political

Electoral Accountability: Monitoring the criminal and financial backgrounds of candidates to ensure informed voting. Eg. **Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR).**

Policy Lobbying: Mobilizing public opinion to influence legislative agendas and push for decentralized power.

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Economic

1. **Skill Alignment for 4IR:** Eg. **Physics Wallah Foundation** partnered with the government to provide AI-driven upskilling to 15,000 SC/OBC students for the "Future Skills" mission.
2. **Financial Last-Mile Connectivity:** Helping unbanked populations access credit and formal financial systems. Eg. **SEWA.**

Social

1. **Independent Education Audits:** Eg. **Pratham's ASER 2025** report served as the primary evidence base for the Ministry of Education to launch "Remedial Learning 2.0."
2. **Healthcare Extension:** Eg. **HelpAge India** operated 180+ Mobile Healthcare Units in 2026, serving 2.5 million elderly citizens in high-altitude Himalayan regions.
3. Complement **government schemes** like NRLM, MGNREGA, PMKVY. Eg. **Aga Khan Rural Support Programme.**

Technological

1. **Digital Inclusion Bridges:** Eg. **Digital Empowerment Foundation (DEF)** trained 1,000 "Soochnapreneurs" in 2026 to use Bhashini AI bots for local grievance redressal.
2. **Algorithm Watchdog:** Monitoring and reporting algorithmic bias or privacy breaches in public data systems. Eg. **Internet Freedom Foundation (IFF).**
3. Diffuse **grassroots innovations** and low-cost technologies. Eg. **Barefoot College**, **Akshaya Centres (Kerala).**

Legal

1. **Legal Aid and Rights Advocacy:** Providing free legal representation to marginalized groups to ensure they can exercise their statutory rights.
2. **Enforcing Accountability:** Eg. **MKSS (Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan)** conducted social audits of MGNREGA, leading to legal action against wage misappropriation.

Environmental

1. **Climate Resilience Pilots:** Eg. **Sree Puram Foundation** established 2026 "Net Zero Village" pilots in Kerala using decentralized solar micro-grid technology.
2. **Environmental Policy Monitoring:** Lobbying for stricter environmental standards and monitoring industrial compliance. Eg. **Greenpeace India**'s "Clean Air 2026" campaign.

Temporal Framework: Role of NGOs in Governance

Policy Making

- **Research-Based Advocacy:** Eg. **Pratham's ASER reports** influenced **NIPUN Bharat Mission** (2021) and **NEP 2020**'s foundational literacy focus.

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- **Agenda Setting - Advocate policy reforms** and **rights-based legislations**. Eg. MKSS for RTI.
- **Drafting Expertise:** Eg. **The Naz Foundation's** long-term data on LGBTQ+ health led to inclusive revisions in the 2025-26 Transgender Protection Rules.
- **Public Mobilisation -** Eg. **India Against Corruption** movement led to **Lokpal and Lokayuktas Act, 2013**; **Nirbhaya movement** led to **Criminal Law (Amendment) Act, 2013**.

Implementation

- **Last-Mile Service Delivery:** Eg. **Akshaya Patra Foundation** implemented the PM-POSHAN initiative, serving 2.2 million hot meals daily across 16 states.
- **Capacity Building of Local Bodies:** Eg. **PRIA (Participatory Research in Asia)** trained 10,000 woman Sarpanches on managing digital financial accounts.
- **Public-Private Partnership (PPP):** Eg. **Tata Trusts** partnered with the Jal Jeevan Mission in 2025 to manage community-led water quality testing in 5,000 villages.

Feedback & Monitoring

- **Social Audits:** Eg. **MKSS-led social audits** in Rajasthan exposed MGNREGA leakages
- **Citizen Feedback Loops:** Eg. **Praja Foundation** released the "2025 Urban Governance Scorecard," ranking 28 cities based on citizen satisfaction.
- **Independent Impact Assessment:** Eg. **Wada Na Todo Abhiyan**, in collaboration with the **Right to Food Campaign**, monitors the implementation of the National Food Security Act.

Crisis Management

- **Immediate First Response:** Eg. **Khalsa Aid** and **Hemkunt Foundation** supplied oxygen concentrators in the 2nd wave (2021). **CRY (Child Rights and You)** distributed digital learning kits.
- **Rehabilitation & Long-Term Resilience:** Eg. **SEEDS India** built 50,000+ disaster-resilient homes after Uttarakhand floods (2013).
- **Global Coordination and Resource Mobilization:** Eg. **GiveIndia Foundation** coordinated ₹200 crore emergency funding for Northern India's heatwave relief operations.

Issues in functioning of NGOs

Regulatory and Legal Challenges

1. **Multiple registration laws:** Societies Registration Act (1860), Indian Trusts Act (1882), Companies Act (2013, Section 8) - **create overlap and confusion.**
2. The Foreign Contribution **(Regulation) Act, 2010** (amended 2020) imposes strict limits on foreign funding, affecting operations of small NGOs.
3. **Lack of uniform national framework:** Absence of a single regulatory authority or national accreditation mechanism.

Financial Constraints and Sustainability

1. **54%** of NGOs have less than three months' worth of reserve funds.
2. **Most grants (foreign or CSR) are project-based**, offering little support for core expenses like salaries, infrastructure, admin, and research.
3. **Overdependence on Foreign Contributions**: Unlike US/UK where 70% NGO funding is domestic, **Indian domestic philanthropy contributes only 30%.**
4. **CSR Skew Toward Certain Sectors: Underfunded areas** like legal aid, gender justice, governance, and advocacy receive minimal attention.
5. **Funding Skewed Towards Large NGOs: Eg. Top 100 NGOs receive 60% of CSR funds.**

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Accountability and Transparency Deficits

1. **CBI report: <10% NGOs file audited financial statements.**
2. **Anti Developmental Role:** Eg. **IB Report** - NGO activism leading to loss of 2% of GDP
3. **Over 20,600 NGOs lost FCRA licenses (2020-23)** for non-compliance or procedural lapses.
4. **Instances of fund diversion**, money laundering, or political misuse reduce public trust. Eg. **cancellation of Greenpeace licence.**

Capacity and Professionalism Gaps

1. **Inadequate skilled staff:** NGOs lack professionals trained in project management, technology, and data analysis.
2. **Dependence on volunteers:** High turnover affects program continuity and institutional memory.

Coordination Issues with Government and Other Stakeholders

1. **Trust deficit with bureaucracy:** Government views NGOs as adversarial or politically motivated.
2. **Shrinking Civic Space:** NGOs critical of the government face investigations, raids, and registration cancellations. Eg. **Lawyers Collective, Amnesty International India halted operations in 2020 citing "incessant harassment"**

Public Perception and Trust Deficit

1. **Negative media portrayal:** Scandals and funding controversies erode credibility.
2. **Low citizen engagement:** Limited awareness about the developmental role of NGOs.
3. **Allegations of Religious Conversion:** Faith-based NGOs face accusations of using welfare for proselytisation, fueling controversies. Eg. **Compassion International.**

Government steps:

1. **NITI AAYOG DARPAN PORTAL (2015)**
   a. Mandatory registration to receive government grants and CSR funds.
   b. Provides Unique ID to NGOs for traceability.
   c. Public disclosure of NGO details (board members, projects, financials).
2. **FOREIGN CONTRIBUTION (REGULATION) ACT, 2010 (Amended 2020)**
   a. Mandatory **SBI Delhi Main Branch** account for all FCRA recipients.
   b. **Aadhaar mandatory** for all office-bearers.
   c. **Sub-granting prohibited** - recipients can't transfer funds to other NGOs.
   d. Administrative expenses capped at **20%** (reduced from 50%).
   e. **Re-registration every 5 years.**
   f. Public servants barred from receiving foreign contributions.
   g. **Impact: 20,664 FCRA licenses cancelled** between 2014-2022; only **16,383 NGOs** had valid FCRA registration in 2024 (MHA data); upheld by SC in **Noel Harper v. UoI**.
3. **INCOME TAX ACT**
   a. **Section 12A/12AB** - Tax exemption for charitable trusts/NGOs.
   b. **Section 80G** - 50% or 100% tax deduction for donors.
   c. **Re-registration mandatory** under amended provisions. **Renewal every 5 years.**
4. **ASPIRATIONAL DISTRICTS PROGRAMME (2018) & ASPIRATIONAL BLOCKS PROGRAMME (2023):** NGOs as implementing and capacity-building partners.
5. **NATIONAL VOLUNTARY SECTOR POLICY, 2007**
   a. Recognises **independence and autonomy** of NGOs.
   b. Promotes **multi-stakeholder dialogue.**
   c. Encourages **transparency and accountability.**
   d. Recommends **simplified registration and compliance.**

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e. Advocates **fair, equitable, transparent funding mechanisms.**

Way forward:

1. **Implement Vijay Kumar Committee's "Light Regulation":** Reduce NGO harassment through modernised registration, less physical interface with IT/FCRA officials, and trust-based oversight.
2. **Establish National Accreditation Council:** Rating NGOs based on governance, transparency, and impact. (2nd ARC).
3. **Enact Separate Voluntary Sector Law** replacing fragmented Societies Act, Trusts Act, and state-level rules for unified regulation.
4. **Update National Voluntary Sector Policy 2007** to reflect digital era, climate action, SDG localisation, and post-FCRA 2020 realities.
5. **Streamline FCRA Process:** Time-bound disposal, pre-show-cause hearings, independent appellate authority to balance national security with civic freedom.
6. **Strengthen Domestic Philanthropy:** Eg. institutionalised Daan Utsav for retail philanthropy
7. **Capacity Building Mission** for training, technology adoption, and M&E systems for grassroots NGOs in underserved regions.
8. **Institutionalise Partnership Models:** Scale Aspirational Districts approach (co-creation, not patronage) across all social sector schemes.
9. **Protect Civic Space:** Whistleblower protection, charter of NGO rights aligned with Article 19(1)(c), independent grievance redressal mechanisms.
10. **Adopt Global Best Practices:** Learn from UK Charity Commission (single regulator), USA's Charity Navigator (rating), Australia's ACNC (unified oversight).

NGOs are **"integral cogs in the wheel of good governance"**. A balanced partnership between genuine NGOs and the government is crucial for India's progress.

Pressure Groups

Pressure Group is any group in society that, through political action, seeks to achieve changes that it regards as desirable or to prevent changes that it regards as undesirable.

According to **Prof. V.O.** Key pressure groups are "private associations formed to influence public policy."

Scholarly Comments

1. **Samuel H. Finer:** "Invisible empires" or "Anonymous empires."
2. **Richard D. Lambert:** "Unofficial government."
3. **Finer:** PGs are the **"Auxiliary drains of representation."**
4. **Rajni Kothari:** PGs are **"Agents of modernization"** and **"Reservoirs of leadership."**

CHARACTERISTICS OF PRESSURE GROUPS:

1. **Non-political, Goal-Oriented** - Eg. Greenpeace India influences environmental policy.
2. **Common Interest or Shared Goal** - Eg. CII represents the shared business interests of Indian industry.
3. **Organized Structure** - Eg. AIKS (All India Kisan Sabha).
4. **Adaptive and Dynamic** - Eg. IAC movement evolved into the Aam Aadmi Party.
5. **Diverse Representation** - Eg.Dalit Panthers (caste-based), NSUI (students), CII (industry).
6. **Voluntary Membership** - Eg. Doctors voluntarily join Indian Medical Association (IMA).
7. **Use of Multiple Tactics** - Eg. AITUC uses strikes, petitions, lobbying, and media campaigns.

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8. **Issue-Based Mobilisation** - Eg. Narmada Bachao Andolan for Sardar Sarovar Dam.
9. **Resource Mobilisation** - Eg. Industry groups like FICCI, ASSOCHAM.
10. **Variable Influence** - Eg. Powerful groups like CII influence the Budget; smaller groups like fishing community associations have limited reach.

METHODS USED BY PRESSURE GROUPS

DIRECT METHODS

1. **Lobbying** - Eg. **FICCI, CII, ASSOCHAM** lobby the Finance Ministry annually before the Budget.
2. **Pre-Legislative Consultation** - Eg. **The Internet Freedom Foundation** submitted detailed comments on the DPDP **Bill.**
3. **Direct Negotiations** - Eg. **Samyukt Kisan Morcha (SKM)** held **11 rounds of talks** with the government during Farm Laws agitation.
4. **Memoranda & Petitions** - Eg. **Indian Medical Association (IMA)** submitted a memorandum opposing the National **Medical Commission Bill.**
5. **Tripartite Negotiations** - Eg. Industry-government-trade union discussions on labour issues.
6. **Membership in Advisory Boards** - Eg. Niti Aayog Tribal Sub-Group includes tribal organisation representatives.
7. **Public Interest Litigation (PIL)** - Eg. **Common Cause** PIL - **Puttaswamy** verdict.

INDIRECT METHODS

1. **Media Campaigns** - Using newspapers, TV, radio, and digital media to highlight issues.
2. **Social Media Mobilisation** - Eg. #MeToo movement (2018).
3. **Demonstrations, Marches, Rallies** - Eg. **Lokpal Movement (2011).**
4. **Strikes & Bandhs** - Eg. **Bharat Bandh** by trade unions.
5. **Hartal, Dharna, and Satyagraha** - **Irom Sharmila's 16-year fast** against AFSPA in Manipur.

ILLEGAL/UNETHICAL METHODS

1. **Bribery & Corruption** - Eg. **Niira Radia Tapes (2010)** exposed the corporate-bureaucrat-media nexus on policy decisions.
2. **Violent Protests & Vandalism** - Eg. **Jat Reservation Agitation (2016).**
3. **Rail Roko & Rasta Roko (Forcefully Blocking).**
4. **Targeted Violence & Intimidation** - Eg. **Cow Vigilante Lynchings by vigilante groups.**
5. **Coercion of Public Officials** - Eg. Gherao of MLAs/officers during Anti-CAA protests.

POSITIVE ROLE OF PRESSURE GROUPS IN A DEMOCRACY:

1. **Agents of Political Modernization and Socialization (structural-functional approach)**
   a. Act as a **link between government and society**, communicating public aspirations.
   b. Promote **political education** and civic engagement.
   c. Eg. **Bharatiya Kisan Union (BKU):** Represents farmers' interests.
2. **Strengthen participatory democracy**
   a. Ensure **continuous citizen engagement** in democracy beyond elections.
   b. Keep **democratic conscience alive** by sustaining pluralism and debate.
   c. People get a **'safety-valve'** outlet for individual and collective grievances and demands.
3. **Interest Articulation** - Crystallize and express **diverse social interests** in an organized form. Eg. Draft Lokpal Act proposed by IAC.
4. **Acting as Watchdogs** - Monitor government actions, expose corruption, and rights violations. **Eg. ADR** PIL leading to SC's directive mandating disclosure of candidates' criminal records.

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5. **Role in Legislative Process** - Eg. **MKSS (Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan)** under Aruna Roy spearheaded **RTI Act, 2005.**
6. **Filling Information Gap** - Eg. **CSE (Sunita Narain)** exposed **pesticides in Coca-Cola/Pepsi (2003)**, leading to BIS standards.
7. **Facilitates Social Progress** - Eg. **Women's and environmental movements**, **NAZ Foundation's fight against Section 377**.
8. **Future political leadership** - Eg. Arvind Kejriwal (earlier part of IAC campaign).

Issues and Shortcomings of Pressure Groups

STRUCTURAL/ORGANISATIONAL ISSUES

1. **Lack of Internal Democracy** - Lack genuine member participation in decision-making.
2. **Weak Institutional Capacity** - Smaller groups lack professional staff, M&E systems, and research capabilities for effective advocacy.
3. **Exert 'Behind the Scenes' Influence** - Eg. The tobacco lobby delayed anti-tobacco legislation.

ECONOMIC/FINANCIAL ISSUES

1. **Funding Opacity** - Raises sovereignty and accountability concerns. **Eg.** 20,664 FCRA licenses cancelled (2014-22).
2. **Corporate Capture** - Eg. Niira Radia Tapes (2010) exposed the corporate-bureaucrat-media nexus on policy decisions.
3. **Unregulated Lobbying** - India lacks formal lobbying laws, enabling informal and unaccounted policy influence.

POLITICAL/IDEOLOGICAL ISSUES

1. **Politicisation & Party Affiliation** - Eg. INTUC-Congress, BMS-RSS, CITU-CPI(M), AITUC-CPI; ABVP-RSS student affiliation.
2. **Caste-based pressure groups** fuel social divisions over collective democratic interests. Eg. Patidar Andolan (2015).
3. **Religious pressure groups** exacerbate communal tensions, harming social fabric. Eg. VHP/Bajrang Dal in Babri demolition (1992); PFI banned under UAPA in September 2022.
4. **Narrow Sectional Interests** - Eg. IMA opposed NEXT exam and NMC Bill 2019 despite the need for medical education reforms.

ETHICAL/LEGAL ISSUES

1. **Violent & Illegal Methods** - Eg. Jat Reservation Agitation (2016) caused ₹34,000 crore property damage in Haryana.
2. **Disrupting Public Life** - Strikes, bandhs, and blockades inconvenience common citizens and affect essential services.
3. **Bribery & Corruption** to influence policy and legislative decisions. Eg. 2G Spectrum Scam (2010).

ADDITIONAL CONCERNS

1. **"Briefcase NGOs"** - Many fake groups exist only on paper for fund laundering and tax evasion. **Eg.** CBI to SC (2016): only 10% of 30 lakh NGOs file annual returns.
2. **Elite Capture** - Pressure groups dominated by urban, educated elites.
3. **Shrinking Civic Space** - Government raids and "anti-national" labelling restrict legitimate dissent and advocacy. Eg. Amnesty International India halted (2020).

Way Forward

1. **Prof. Anand Chakravarty** - GOI should show greater accommodation towards pressure groups to better address alienation and secessionist trends.

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2. **Mandatory Registration under a defined legal framework.** Eg. under Companies Act or Societies Registration Act.

1. **Financial Transparency**
   - **Mandatory Disclosure of Funding**
   - **Cap on corporate or foreign donations**
   - **Public Access** to funding and expenditure reports

Lobbying Legislation: Enact a comprehensive **"Lobbying Regulation Act"** similar to those in the USA or EU to:
- Define what constitutes lobbying.
- Mandate **disclosure of lobbying activities**, beneficiaries, and costs involved.
- Register lobbyists and establish a **code of conduct**.
- **Voluntary Code**: Encourage pressure groups to adopt a **voluntary code of ethics** and principles of **non-partisanship, transparency, and accountability**.

Independent Oversight Body: Establish an autonomous body (Eg. a **Public Interest Advocacy Commission**) to:
- Monitor compliance.
- Handle grievances and complaints.
- Penalize non-compliance.

Pressure groups' proactive engagement is vital for building a vibrant, resilient, and prosperous India by its centenary of independence.

Donor Agencies

Donor Agencies are **bilateral, multilateral, or private organisations** that provide **financial aid, technical assistance, capacity building, and policy support** to recipient countries to advance development, governance, humanitarian, and policy objectives.

They include:

1. **Multilateral agencies:** World Bank, IMF, ADB, UN bodies (UNDP, UNICEF, WHO, FAO).
2. **Bilateral agencies:** USAID (USA), DFID/FCDO (UK), JICA (Japan), GIZ (Germany), AFD (France).
3. **Private foundations:** Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation, Ford Foundation.
4. **Faith-based donors:** Christian Aid, Caritas, Aga Khan Foundation.
5. **Sovereign Wealth/Climate Funds:** Green Climate Fund, Global Environment Facility (GEF).

POSITIVE ROLE OF DONOR AGENCIES IN GOVERNANCE

1. **Financial Resource Mobilisation** - Eg. **World Bank's $1.5 billion loan** for Swachh Bharat Mission (2015).
2. **Technical Expertise & Knowledge Transfer** - Eg. **JICA** transferred Delhi Metro technology.
3. **Capacity Building of Governments** - Eg. **UNDP-NITI Aayog partnership** on SDG localisation.
4. **Strengthening Civil Society** - Donors fund pressure groups, NGOs, and watchdog institutions for accountability. Eg. **Open Society Foundations** funded human rights work globally.
5. **Catalysing Policy Reforms** - Eg. **IMF-WB conditional aid** triggered India's **LPG** reforms.
6. **Health & Pandemic Response** - Eg. **GAVI funded India's Universal Immunisation Programme**; **Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation supported polio eradication.**
7. **Poverty Alleviation & Livelihood** - Eg. **The World Bank funded NRLM (Aajeevika)** with $1 billion.
8. **Climate Action & Environment** - Eg. **Green Climate Fund (GCF)** committed $250+ million to India for climate adaptation.
9. **Disaster Relief & Humanitarian Aid** - Eg. **UN, USAID, JICA** provided ₹1,000+ crore aid after the 2004 **Indian Ocean Tsunami.**

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10. **Innovation & Pilot Projects** - Eg. **Omidyar Network** seeded **Aadhaar-based DBT pilots**.
11. **Peace-Building & Conflict Resolution** - Eg. **UN Peace Building Fund** in Sri Lanka, **UNHCR** support for refugees.

NEGATIVE ROLE / CONCERNS

1. **Erosion of Sovereignty** - Eg. **Structural Adjustment Programmes (SAPs)** by IMF/World Bank criticised as "shock therapy".
2. **Donor-Driven Agendas** - Recipient countries align priorities with donor preferences, distorting national needs.
3. **Tied Aid** - Eg. **USAID** historically tied to US suppliers
4. **Foreign Influence on Domestic Politics** - Eg. **2014 IB Report** flagged **Greenpeace, Cordaid, Amnesty** as threats to "economic security"
5. **Bypassing State Institutions** - Donors often work directly with NGOs, weakening state capacity.
6. **Aid Dependency Syndrome** - Long-term aid creates dependency, reducing motivation for self-sufficient governance.
7. **Geopolitical Tool** - Eg. **China's BRI loans** criticised as "debt-trap diplomacy."
8. **Funding Religious Conversion** - Some faith-based donors accused of using welfare for proselytisation. Eg. **Compassion International**.

WAY FORWARD AND GLOBAL BEST PRACTICES

1. **ADOPT PARIS DECLARATION ON AID EFFECTIVENESS (2005)** - Five Principles for effective aid:
   a. **Ownership** - Recipient country leads development priorities.
   b. **Alignment** - Donors align with recipient strategies.
   c. **Harmonisation** - Donors coordinate, avoid duplication.
   d. **Managing for Results** - Outcome-based monitoring.
   e. **Mutual Accountability** - Both donors and recipients are accountable.
2. **Strengthen domestic resource mobilisation by improving tax-GDP ratio**
   a. **Avoid duplication and competition** through coordinated platforms.

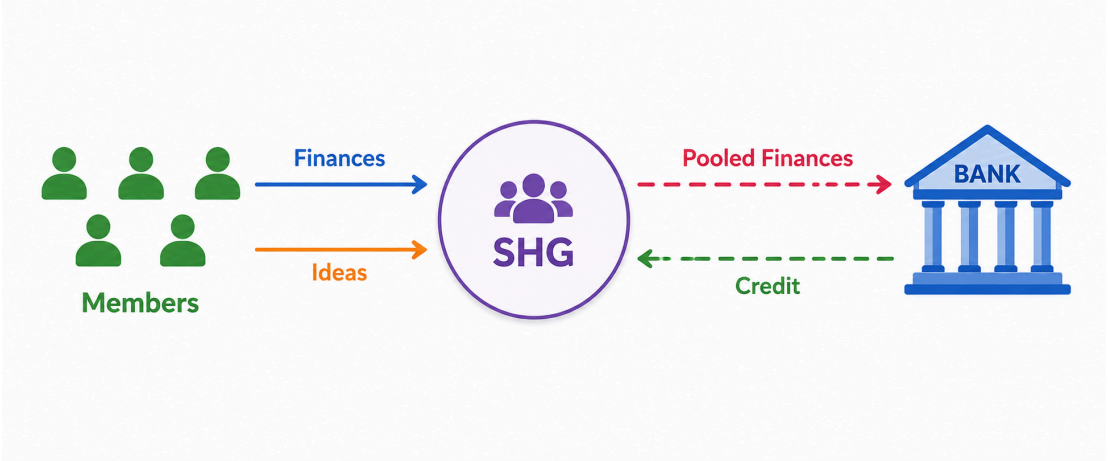
Self-Help Groups

According to **NABARD**, an SHG is *"a small economically homogenous and affinity group of rural poor voluntarily coming together to save small amounts regularly, mutually agreeing to contribute to a common fund and to meet their emergency needs on the basis of mutual help."*

Under the **DAY-NRLM, 2011**, SHGs are organised into a **three-tier structure**:

1. **Self-Help Groups (SHGs)** at village level
2. **Village Organisations (VOs)** at hamlet/village level
3. **Cluster Level Federations (CLFs)** at GP/block level

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KEY FEATURES / PILLARS / PRINCIPLES OF SHG

1. **Group Size - 10-25 members** with homogeneous socio-economic background.
2. **Voluntary & Self-Selected**
3. **Regular Savings**
4. **Inter-loaning**
5. **Bank Linkage (SHG-BLP since 1992)**
6. **Group Decision-Making** - Democratic, participatory.
7. **Joint Liability** for loan repayment - peer pressure ensures discipline.

ROLE OF SHGs IN WOMEN EMPOWERMENT

I. Economic Empowerment

1. **Promotes culture of savings and access to Credit:** over **10.05 crore women** are mobilized into **90.9 lakh SHGs**, accessing institutional credit worth over **₹12 lakh crore**.
2. **Income Generation:** They facilitate the shift from subsistence labor to micro-entrepreneurship through programs like the **Lakhpati Didi** initiative.
3. **Asset Ownership:** Land, livestock, equipment ownership in women's names. **Eg. SHG members are 17% more likely** to own assets vs non-members (NRLM Impact Study).
4. **Poverty Alleviation:** SHGs act as a safety net, reducing the "vulnerability to shocks" (like health emergencies) that often push families into a debt trap.

II. Social Empowerment

1. **Enhanced Status in Family:** Financial contribution to the household gives women a greater say in domestic decision-making, such as children's education and healthcare.
2. **Collective Voice against Social Evils:** SHGs provide a platform for women to unite against local issues like domestic violence, dowry, child marriage, and alcoholism.
3. **Building Self-Confidence:** Group interactions, public speaking during meetings, and managing group finances significantly boost the self-esteem and "agency" of women.
4. **Awareness of Rights:** SHGs serve as information hubs where women learn about their legal rights, government schemes, and nutritional/health practices.
5. **Reduced Domestic Violence & Social Empowerment:** Collective action and economic independence strengthens mobility, voice & agency.
6. **Health & Nutrition:** Eg. SHG-rich districts showed **higher iron pill consumption, immunisation, ANC visits** (NFHS-5).
7. **Educational Outcomes:** Eg. Reduced school dropout in SHG-active areas (**Pratham ASER**).

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III. Political Empowerment

1. **Leadership Development:** The hierarchical structure of SHGs (President, Secretary, Treasurer) creates a training ground for leadership skills.
2. **Grievance Redressal:** SHG federations act as pressure groups to hold local administration accountable for the delivery of public services like water, electricity, and sanitation.

MAJOR CHALLENGES FACED BY SHGs

A. ECONOMIC CHALLENGES

1. **Limited Bank Linkage -** Majority SHGs remain at the savings stage. Full credit linkage is incomplete despite SHG-BLP since 1992.
2. **Inadequate Capitalisation -** Revolving Fund (₹20,000-30,000) and CIF (up to ₹2.5 lakh) often insufficient for scaling enterprises.
3. **Weak Market Linkages -** SHG products lack quality, branding, packaging, and access to organised markets. Most SHGs sell only locally.

B. OPERATIONAL CHALLENGES

1. **Quality vs Quantity Dilemma - Eg.** Significant share of "**defunct SHGs**" - formed but inactive in meetings, savings, lending (NABARD).
2. **Capacity Deficit -** SHG members and federation leaders lack functional literacy, accounting, digital, leadership skills.
3. **Poor Digital Adoption -** Limited usage of digital banking, e-commerce, MIS platforms due to digital literacy gaps.
4. **Bureaucratic Delays -** Approval processes for grants, fund disbursement, bank linkage face procedural delays.

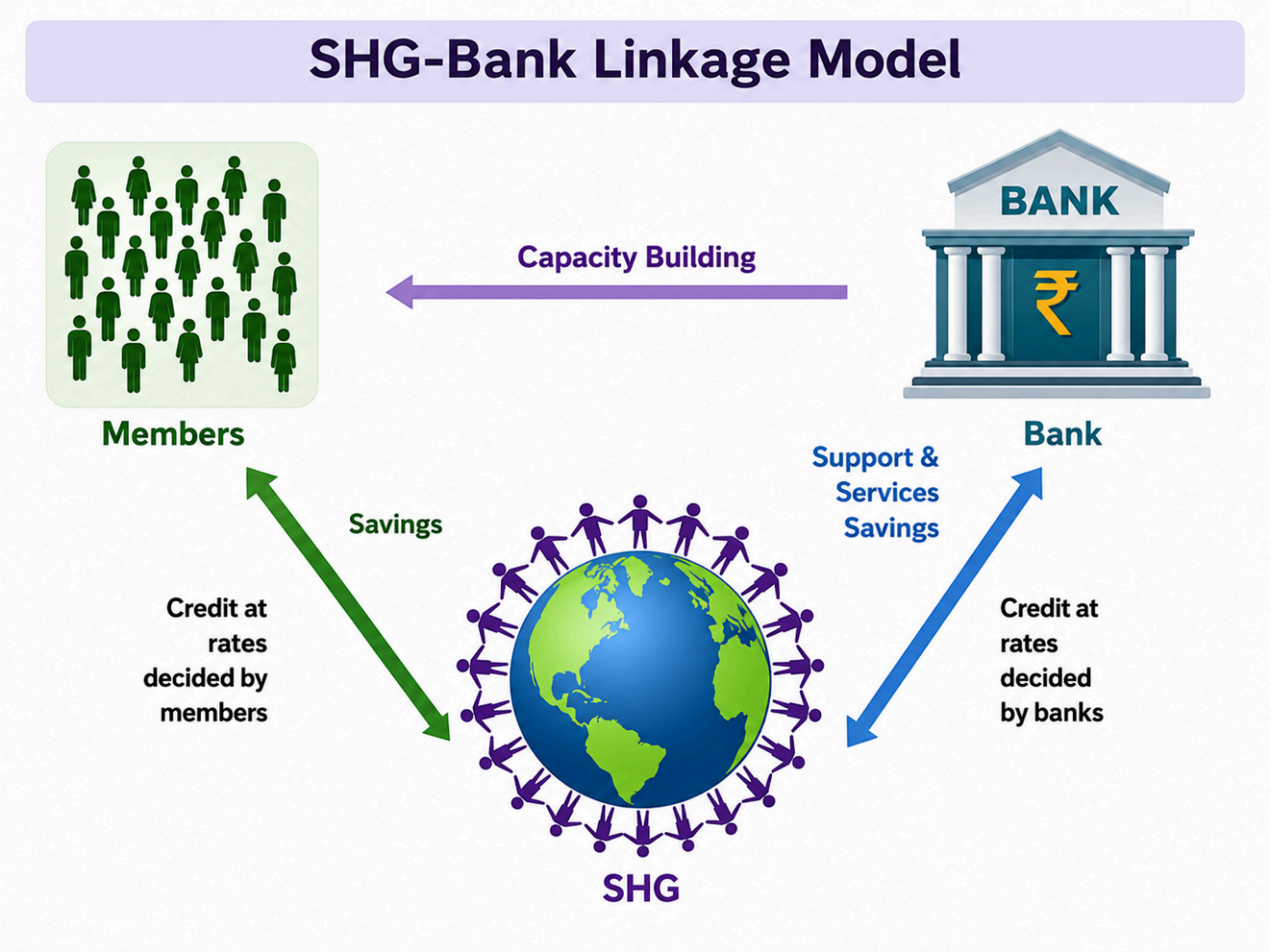
C. SOCIAL CHALLENGES

1. **Patriarchal Resistance -** opposition to women's economic activity, mobility, group meetings. **Eg.** only **~40% women** have control over their own earnings. (**NFHS-5**)
2. **Elite Capture Within Groups -** Better-off, more literate, upper-caste members dominate SHG leadership and benefits. Dalit, Adivasi members marginalized within mixed-caste groups.
3. **Geographical Imbalance -** southern states ahead, northeastern states, J&K, Ladakh, tribal districts lag.
4. Women's **domestic responsibilities** limit time for SHG meetings and economic activities. **Eg.** women spend **7+ hours daily on unpaid domestic work** vs men's 1.5 hours.

MAJOR STEPS BY GOVERNMENTS

1. **DAY-NRLM, 2011 -** Mobilise at least one woman from each rural poor household into SHGs and federations to enable poverty reduction and economic transformation.
   a. **90.90 lakh SHGs formed**
   b. **10.05 crore women households mobilised**
   c. Reach extended to **7,145 blocks across 745 districts**
   d. **₹58,714.44 crore** total capitalisation support disbursed since inception
   e. 3-tier structure: **SHG → VO → CLF** institutionalised nationwide
2. **SHG Bank Linkage Programme (SHG-BLP, 1992) -** pioneered by NABARD

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   a. **World's largest microfinance programme** by volume
   b. **96%+ loan repayment rate**
   c. Cumulative credit disbursement crossed **₹4+ lakh crore**
   d. **CAGR of 10.8% in credit linkages** over last decade (Economic Survey 2022-23)
3. **Lakhpati Didi Initiative (2023):** Make 3 crore women SHG members earn ₹1 lakh+ annually through livelihood diversification, skilling, and enterprise scaling.
4. **Namo Drone Didi Yojana:** Provide drones to women SHGs for agricultural rental services; build new income stream and tech-led empowerment.
5. **Start-up Village Entrepreneurship Programme:** Enable SHGs to start small enterprises in non-farm sector through Community Enterprise Fund.
6. **Micro-Enterprise Development (MED):** Support nano enterprises through finance, skill development, and market linkages for SHG members.
7. **Mahila Kisan Sashaktikaran Pariyojana (MKSP):** Empower women farmers through agricultural skill-building, sustainable farming practices, and asset creation.
8. **MGNREGA-SHG Convergence:** SHG members serve as social auditors, mates (worksite supervisors), planning participants in Gram Sabhas.

STATE GOVERNMENT INITIATIVES

1. **Kudumbashree - Kerala (1998)**
   a. **World's largest women SHG network - 45+ lakh members** in 3+ lakh SHGs.
   b. Pioneered urban SHGs; integrated with local self-government.

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   c. **UNDP, World Bank** recognised as global benchmark.
2. **JEEViKA -** Bihar Rural Livelihoods Project (2007) - **1+ crore women mobilised in 10+ lakh SHGs.**
3. **Mahalir Thittam -** Tamil Nadu - **80+ lakh women in 6.5+ lakh SHGs.**
4. **Mission Shakti -** Odisha (2001) - **70+ lakh women in 6+ lakh SHGs.** Mission Shakti Bazaar for SHG product marketing.
5. **MAVIM (Mahila Arthik Vikas Mahamandal) -** Maharashtra
   a. **20+ lakh women in 1.5+ lakh SHGs.**
   b. Tej Swini Project; market access through MAVIM brand.
   c. Credit facilitation via partnerships with NABARD, SIDBI.

WAY FORWARD

1. **Universal Saturation -** Mobilise remaining rural poor women households into SHGs.
2. Form **corporate-SHG alliances** to provide **mentorship**, **technology**, and **market access.** Eg. **Google's Women Will**
3. **Institutionalizing Federations -** Creating a three-tier structure (SHG-VO-CLF) provides economies of scale for large-scale procurement and marketing.
4. **Credit-Plus Approach -** Shifting focus from mere loan disbursement to providing technical consultancy and business incubation services. Eg. NABARD's **"Enterprise Hubs"**
5. **Mainstreaming into E-commerce** by developing dedicated logistics and branding support. **Eg. "Womaniya on GeM"** initiative
6. **Universal Insurance Coverage -** Protecting members against health and climate shocks ensures that enterprise capital isn't diverted for emergencies.
7. **Integrating SHG development plans with Gram Panchayat Development Plans (GPDP)** to optimize rural resource allocation.
8. **Financial Product Customization -** "flexible repayment" products that align with the seasonal income cycles of rural women.

Micro Finance in India

Microfinance is a banking service provided to unemployed or low-income individuals or groups who otherwise have no access to formal financial services.

In India, it primarily involves collateral-free loans to households with an annual income of up to **₹3 lakh** (as per RBI's 2022/2025 Master Directions).

Data Points

1. **Gross Loan Portfolio (GLP):** Estimated at **₹4.1 trillion**
2. **Borrower Base:** Approximately **8.2 crore**
3. NBFC-MFIs hold the largest share (~40%), followed by Banks (32%) and Small Finance Banks (SFBs).

MODELS OF MICROFINANCE IN INDIA

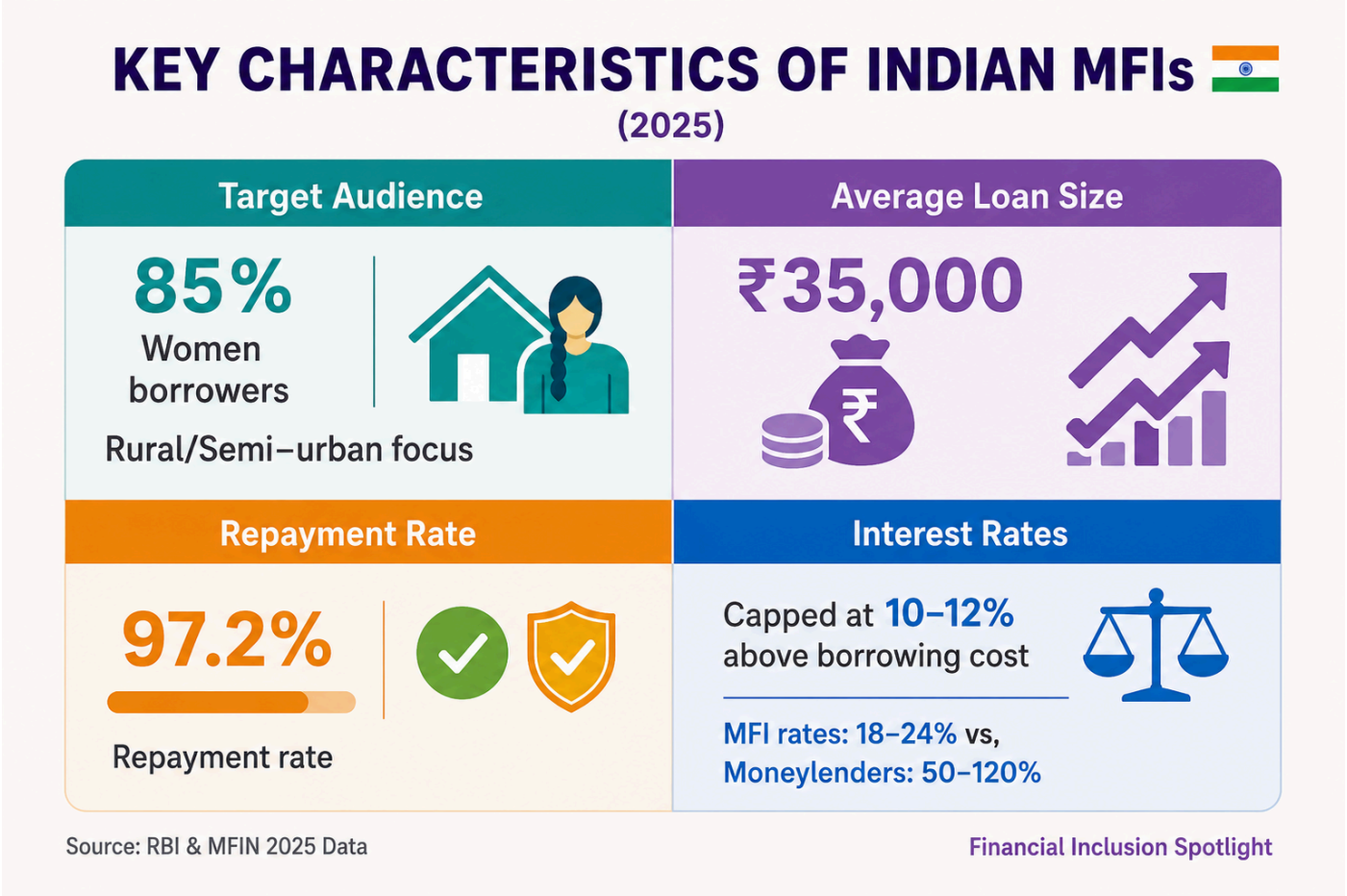
1. **SHG-Bank Linkage Programme (SHG-BLP, 1992)** - Group savings → Bank linkage → Credit access
2. **Microfinance Institutions (MFI) Model - Joint Liability Groups (JLGs)** of 5-10 members Eg. Bandhan, Ujjivan, Spandana
3. **Banks (Direct Lending)**
   a. **Public Sector Banks, RRBs** - direct microfinance
   b. **Small Finance Banks (SFBs)** - dedicated MFI-style banking

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4. **Cooperative Banks** - Urban cooperative banks, rural cooperatives
5. **Government Schemes**
   a. **PMMY/MUDRA** - micro-loans up to ₹10 lakh
   b. **Stand-Up India** - for SC/ST/women
   c. **PM Vishwakarma** - for traditional artisans
6. **Digital/Fintech Platforms 0 Use Account Aggregator Framework (RBI).** Eg. Kreditbee, MoneyTap, ZestMoney

Benefits/Significance

1. **Financial Inclusion** - Eg. Over **80% of micro-loans** in 2026 reached women in rural "shadow regions."



2. **Poverty Alleviation** - Funds income-generating activities that break the cycle of subsistence living and debt.
3. **Reduction of Moneylender Exploitation** - Moneylenders charged 60-100% interest; microfinance offers 18-26%.
4. **Entrepreneurship Promotion** - Provides seed capital for small-scale ventures like tailoring, or handicrafts. **Eg.** Micro-enterprises supported by MFIs contributed **2.03% to GVA** in FY 2025.
5. **Women Empowerment** - Direct access to credit increases women's decision-making power within the household and community. Eg. Kudumbshree model
6. **Consumption Smoothing** - Helps low-income families manage seasonal income fluctuations and emergency household expenditures.
7. Small successful repayments generate **credit scores,** enabling future access to larger commercial bank loans.
8. **Sustainable Livelihoods** - Supports transition to climate-resilient farming or green energy products like solar pumps.

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Major Challenges

1. **Over-Indebtedness** - Multiple lenders targeting the same borrower lead to a debt trap beyond repayment capacity. Eg. **AP Microfinance Crisis (2010)**.
2. **High Interest Rates** - Higher operational costs in rural areas result in interest rates (18-24%) exceeding commercial bank rates.
3. **Ghost Borrowing** - Male family members using women as "fronts" to secure loans, diluting the empowerment goal.
4. **Inadequate Risk Management** - MFIs often lack visibility into a borrower's gold loans or informal moneylender debts.
5. **Limited Product Diversification** - Most MFIs focus on credit; insurance, savings, pension underdeveloped.
6. **Coercive Collection Practices** - Despite RBI bans, aggressive field agents sometimes use social pressure and violence for repayment.
7. **Regulatory Fragmentation** - Different rules for Banks vs. NBFC-MFIs sometimes create an unlevel playing field and "Regulatory Arbitrage."
8. **Loan Waiver promise** during elections disrupts credit discipline and repayment culture.
9. **Technological Frauds** - increasing vulnerability to phishing and unauthorized app-based lending. **Eg. CERT-In** reported a 20% rise in "Fake MFI App" scams in early 2026.

Way Forward

1. **Credit Guarantee Scheme** to lower the risk for lenders in remote areas.
2. **Account Aggregator (AA) Integration:** Using AA to view a borrower's holistic "Cash-flow" rather than just their "Credit score."
3. **Limiting the number of lenders per borrower to three from four.**
4. **Diversify Products** beyond credit - savings, insurance (PMJJBY, PMSBY), pension (APY), remittances.
5. Channel **CSR funds** for microfinance ecosystem strengthening.

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Chapter 4

Civil Services

Civil Services

PYQs

[2026] Analyse the advantages and limitations of the generalist structure of the Indian Civil Services in contemporary governance. (10)

[2024] The Doctrine of Democratic Governance makes it necessary that the public perception of the integrity and commitment of civil servants becomes absolutely positive. Discuss. (10)

[2020] "Institutional quality is a crucial driver of economic performance". In this context suggest reforms in Civil Service for strengthening democracy. (10)

1. "The Civil Services are the steel frame of India." - **Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel**
2. "Civil services are the principal instrument through which government policies are translated into action and citizens are served." - **2nd ARC Report**
3. "Bureaucracy is the most rational known means of exercising authority over human beings." - **Max Weber**
4. "The character of public servants determines the character of governance." - **C. Rajagopalachari**

Constitutional Provisions - Part XIV (Articles 308-323)

1. **Article 309** - Parliament/State Legislatures regulate recruitment and conditions of services.
2. **Article 310** - Civil servants hold office during the **pleasure of the President** (Union) or **Governor** (State), subject to Article 311 safeguards.
3. **Article 311 - Safeguards Against Dismissal**
   a. 311(1): No dismissal/removal/reduction in rank by authority subordinate to appointing authority
   b. 311(2): Cannot be dismissed/removed/reduced in rank without **inquiry** and **opportunity to be heard**
   c. Exceptions: National security, conviction by court, impracticality of holding inquiry
4. **Article 312** - Empowers Rajya Sabha (with **2/3rd majority**) to create new All India Services

Legal framework

1. **All India Services Act, 1951** - Provides framework for IAS, IPS, IFoS recruitment, training, conduct.
2. **AIS (Conduct) Rules, 1968** - Code of conduct for All India Services officers.
3. **AIS (Discipline & Appeal) Rules, 1969** - Procedures for disciplinary action.
4. **Central Civil Services (CCS) Conduct Rules, 1964** - Conduct rules for central government civil servants.
5. **CCS (Classification, Control & Appeal) Rules, 1965** - Disciplinary procedures.

Role of Civil Services in a Democracy

1. **Implementation of Laws and Policies** - Civil services **translate legislative intent into administrative action**.

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2. Act as **custodians of the Constitution, upholding rule of law, equality, and impartiality** in administration.
3. Provide **evidence-based, professional, and non-partisan advice** to ministers for policy formulation.
4. **Ensuring Administrative Continuity** - Provide **institutional memory and stability** amidst political changes.
5. Ensure **effective service delivery** in education, health, and welfare sectors through decentralized administration.
6. **Promoting Social and Economic Development** - Act as change agents in poverty reduction, rural development, and inclusive growth.
7. **Strengthening Democratic Accountability** - Facilitate transparent governance through RTI implementation, grievance redressal, and citizen charters.
8. **Disaster and Crisis Management** - Lead **on-ground response and coordination** during natural disasters and public emergencies.
9. **National Integration -** All India Services foster national unity by serving across states.
10. **Bridging Citizen-State Gap -** Civil servants are the **face of government** for common citizens.
11. **Custodians of Public Resources -** Manage public finances, natural resources, and public assets responsibly.
12. **Safeguarding Democratic Institutions -** Civil servants in EC, CAG, UPSC, ECI uphold institutional integrity. **Eg. T.N. Seshan** (CEC 1990-96), **Vinod Rai** (CAG 2008-13).

Major Issues in Civil Services

1. **Political Interference:** Frequent "punishment transfers" and pressure to favor specific interests. **Eg. Ashok Khemka** transferred 50+ times in 30 years.
2. **Lack of Specialization:** The "Generalist vs. Specialist" debate; officers often lack deep domain expertise in sectors like AI or Climate Finance.
3. **Bureaucratic Apathy:** The "Status Quoist" mindset that resists rapid technological or social change.
4. "**politicisation of bureaucracy**" (2nd ARC) - Eg. increasing trend of VRS to join political party.
5. **Lack of Accountability -** Disciplinary actions rare; protection under Article 311 sometimes misused. **Eg.** only **1% of complaints lead to dismissal.**
6. **Delayed Decision-Making -** Risk-averse culture leads to file delays and "**not on my watch**" mentality.
7. **Gender & Diversity Gap -** Women only **~14% of IAS officers** in 2024.
8. **Colonial Mindset (Mai-baap culture):** A persistence of the "Officer" vs. "Sevak" divide, hindering citizen-centricity.
9. **Inefficient Performance Appraisal:** Reliance on subjective Annual Confidential Reports (ACRs) rather than outcome-based metrics. **2nd ARC** called APARs "**meaningless ritual.**"
10. **Structural Rigidity:** Strict hierarchy and "Silo-based" functioning prevent inter-departmental collaboration. **Eg.** File movement through 8-10 levels; "**babudom**" critiqued by 2nd ARC.
11. **Skill Gap:** Difficulty in keeping pace with rapid digital advancements (Eg. Blockchain and Big Data).
12. **Outdated Recruitment Process -** UPSC exam emphasises rote learning; doesn't adequately test leadership, integrity, empathy.
13. **Corruption** - India ranked **96/180 in CPI 2024** (Transparency International)
14. **Lack of Tenure Security:** Frequent shifts prevent officers from seeing long-term projects (like infrastructure) through to completion.

Civil services reforms suggested by committees

1. **Hota Committee (2004)**

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   a. Recommended **fixed tenure** for senior posts.
   b. **Performance-based promotions.**
2. **2nd Administrative Reforms Commission (2005-09)**
   a. **Fixed minimum tenure** of 3 years.
   b. **Civil Services Authority** for postings/transfers.
   c. **Performance-based evaluation** (replace APARs).
   d. **Lateral entry** for specialists.
   e. **Code of Ethics** for civil services.
   f. **Citizen Charter** mandatory.
   g. **Sevottam framework** for service delivery.
   h. **Right to Service Act** in states.
   i. **e-governance** to reduce corruption.
3. **Baswan Committee (2016) -** Proposed reducing the upper age limit and removing "Optional" papers to level the playing field.
4. **Surinder Nath Committee (2003) - objective evaluation, 360-degree feedback in** Performance Appraisal Report (PAR)

Steps Taken by Government

1. **Mission Karmayogi:** Moving from "Rule-based" to "Role-based" learning via the **iGOT platform**.
2. **Lateral Entry:** Inducting private-sector experts at Joint Secretary and Director levels to bring in domain specialization.
3. **National Training Conclave:** Institutionalizing a "Shared Training Ecosystem" for all Group A services.
4. **Digital Transformation (e-Office):** Transitioning to paperless governance to increase speed and accountability.
5. **360-Degree Performance Appraisal:** Multi-source feedback system for senior bureaucrats - supplements traditional APARs.
6. **Rule 16(3) of AIS (Death-cum-Retirement Benefits) Rules:** Compulsory retirement of officers with doubtful integrity at 50/55 years; **400+ officers** retired between 2014-23.

Civil Service Board

The **Civil Services Board (CSB)** is an **institutional mechanism** to ensure **transparent, merit-based, and depoliticised postings, transfers, and promotions** of civil servants in India.

Supreme Court Directives (T.S.R. Subramanian Verdict, 2013):

- **Fixed Minimum Tenure** to enable independent functioning.
- **Civil Services Board** at Centre and State levels to advise on postings, transfers, and disciplinary matters.
- Civil servants should not act on **oral instructions** from political superiors; all directions must be in writing.

Implementation Following Verdict

- The Centre issued instructions to all ministries to implement Supreme Court directions.
- **All India Services Rules, 2007** amended to incorporate CSB framework.

Composition of civil services board

At the Centre (CSB)

- **Cabinet Secretary** - Chairman
- **Secretary, Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT)** - Member

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- **Secretary of the concerned Ministry/Department** - Member
- Recommendations to ACC - Appointments Committee of the Cabinet

At State Level (State CSB)

- **Chief Secretary** - Chairman
- **Senior-most Additional Chief Secretary** - Member
- **Principal Secretary/Secretary, General Administration Department (GAD)** - Member
- **Senior officer (varies by state)**

Key functions of civil services board

- **Recommending Postings & Transfers** for senior-level postings (Joint Secretary and above).
- **Ensuring Fixed Tenure - minimum 2-3 year tenure**
- **Reviewing Premature Transfers**
- **Advising on Disciplinary Matters**
- **Advising on Empanelment** based on performance and integrity.
- **Maintaining Transfer Database**
- **Recommending Sensitive Postings**
- **Promoting Good Governance Norms** - Recommends best practices in personnel administration in line with 2nd ARC, Hota Committee.

Issues in CSB functioning

- **Non-Statutory Nature**
- **Lack of Independence** - Cabinet Secretary/Chief Secretary headed - not independent from political executive.
- **Advisory, Not Binding**
- **Weak Enforcement** - No penalty for ignoring CSB recommendations
- **Political Workarounds**- **"Compelling public interest"** clause used to justify transfer.
- **Limited Coverage** - Mainly applies to senior posts; junior officers' transfers remain at ministerial discretion.
- **No Public Disclosure** - CSB deliberations are confidential;
- **State-Level Resistance** - Some states have notified CSBs but bypass them in practice. **Eg. West Bengal**

Lateral Entry in India

Lateral Entry refers to the **direct recruitment of domain experts and professionals** from the **private sector, academia, PSUs, and international organisations** into **mid and senior-level positions** in the Government of India.

Hota Committee (2004), 2nd Administrative Reforms Commission (10th Report), Surinder Nath Committee (2003), NITI Aayog 3-Year Action Agenda (2017) all have supported lateral entry

1. **First Formal Notification - June 2018** - DoPT issued advertisement for **10 lateral entry positions** at **Joint Secretary level**.
2. **2021 onwards** - extended to **Director and Deputy Secretary** levels.
3. In August **2024**, the government **withdrew the lateral entry notification** following political backlash from opposition parties and concerns over **reservation policy non-implementation**.
4. Since 2018, only **63 appointments** have been made

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SIGNIFICANCE / NEED FOR LATERAL ENTRY

1. **Domain Expertise:** Modern governance requires deep specialisation in finance, technology, climate, AI, biotech. Eg. Nandan Nilekani as UIDAI chairman
2. **Complexity of Modern Governance:** Issues like **AI regulation, blockchain, cybersecurity, semiconductor strategy** demand technical know-how beyond generalist training.
3. **Bringing Fresh Perspectives:** Private sector, academia bring **innovative thinking** and **best practices**.
4. Covers the **structural shortfall** of nearly 1,500+ IAS officers at middle-management levels.
5. **Performance-Driven Culture:** Lateral entrants on contracts emphasise outcomes over process, challenging "**babu**" mindset.
6. **Reducing Political Interference:** Domain experts on fixed-term contracts less susceptible to political pressure for routine work.
7. **Global Best Practices:** USA, UK, Singapore, Australia have well-established lateral entry systems.
8. **Reform Catalyst:** Lateral entrants challenge status quo, push reforms. **Eg. Dr. Raghuram Rajan** (RBI Governor 2013-16)
9. **Aligning with "Minimum Government, Maximum Governance":** Bring efficiency-driven private sector approach to public administration.
10. **Agility in Governance:** Faster response to niche crises (Eg. global supply chain disruptions or pandemic logistics).

MAJOR CHALLENGES / LIMITATIONS

1. **Reservation Concerns -** Lateral entry currently doesn't follow **SC/ST/OBC reservation** as per Constitution (Articles 16(4), 16(4A)).
2. **Demoralisation of Career Civil Servants -** IAS/IPS officers feel sidelined by direct entry at senior levels.
3. **Bureaucratic Resistance:** "Insiders" often view lateral entrants as threats, leading to a hostile work environment and friction in hierarchy.
4. **Conflict of Interest:** Corporate professionals may bring biases or have future links with private firms, risking "Policy Capture."
5. **Transparency Concerns:** Recruitment via interviews (rather than a rigorous multi-stage exam) is criticized as being open to favoritism.
6. **Cultural Mismatch -** Private sector culture (efficiency, speed) clashes with bureaucratic culture (process, hierarchy).
7. **Limited Tenure Impact -** Fixed contracts of 3-5 years insufficient for institutional impact.
8. **Revolving Door Concerns -** Movement between government and private sector raises corruption risks.
9. Lateral entrants enter at senior levels without **grassroots/field exposure** career IAS gain in district postings - may lack ground reality understanding.
10. **Inadequate Orientation -** Limited induction training; entrants struggle with RTI, parliamentary processes, government systems.
11. **Risk of Politicisation -** Critics fear lateral entry may become a tool to bring in politically aligned individuals.

WAY FORWARD

1. Ensure **SC/ST/OBC/EWS reservation** in lateral entry as per Constitutional mandate (Articles 14, 16).
2. Enact a **dedicated law** for lateral entry to provide legal certainty, clear eligibility, transparent process.
3. **UPSC-Driven Selection** to ensure **merit, transparency, and credibility** (as per 2nd ARC).
4. Conduct **rigorous sector specific need assessment** before each notification.

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5. **Robust Conflict of Interest Norms** - Mandatory **cooling-off period** after government service, financial disclosures and recusal protocols.
6. **Comprehensive Induction Training** at **LBSNAA/IIPA** on government systems, ethics, parliamentary procedures, RTI Act, public finance.
7. **Performance Evaluation** - Annual review with **360-degree feedback**; non-performers should not have contracts extended.
8. **Diversity & Inclusion** - Ensure **gender, regional, and social diversity** in lateral entry pool
9. **Career Civil Service Reforms in Parallel** - Strengthen **Mission Karmayogi (2020)**, in-service specialisation, deputation to private sector to build domain expertise within IAS.
10. **Knowledge Transfer Mechanisms** - Lateral entrants should mentor career civil servants to build institutional capacity.
11. **Ethical Charter for Lateral Entrants** - Specific code of conduct to prevent revolving door conflicts. Align with **CCS Conduct Rules**.

Mission Karmayogi: National Programme for Civil Services Capacity Building (NPCSCB)

Mission Karmayogi is a **landmark initiative** of the Government of India aimed at **transforming civil services capacity building** in India.

It represents a **paradigm shift** from "rules-based" to "**roles-based**" capacity building, equipping every civil servant with **right competencies, attitude, and behaviour** to serve a **New India**.

"To build a civil service that is anchored in Indian ethos and shares an aspirational view of India's future." - PM Narendra Modi

The mission is anchored in **Prime Minister's vision** of:

1. **"Reform, Perform, Transform"**
2. **"Maximum Governance, Minimum Government"**
3. **"Citizen-Centric Service Delivery"**
4. **"Transition from Karmachari to Karmayogi"**

Why Mission Karmayogi?

1. **Outdated Training Methods** - Traditional training siloed, classroom-based, rules-focused - inadequate for modern governance.
2. **Recommendations of Various Committees**
   a. **2nd ARC (10th Report, 2008)**: competency-based capacity building.
   b. **Hota Committee (2004)**: Modernise civil services training.
   c. **Baswan Committee (2016)**: Reform civil services examination and training.
3. **Complex 21st Century Challenges** - AI, climate change, cybersecurity, pandemics - civil servants need new competencies.
4. **Citizen Expectations** - Rising demand for responsive, transparent, technology-driven service delivery.
5. **Global Best Practices - Singapore Civil Service College, USA's FEI, UK's Civil Service Learning** demonstrated the value of continuous capacity building.

KEY OBJECTIVES

1. **Build a Future-Ready Civil Service** - Equipped to address India's complex governance challenges and **Viksit Bharat 2047** vision.

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2. **Citizen-Centric Approach-** Move from rule-based to role-based; serve citizens efficiently
3. **Continuous Lifelong Learning -** Lifelong, on-demand, multi-platform learning ecosystem.
4. **Domain Specialisation -** Build expertise in specific sectors (finance, technology, climate, etc.).
5. **Behavioural Transformation -** Shift mindset from regulator to facilitator; from "babu" to **karmayogi** (servant of duty).
6. **Standardised Training -** Across all India Services, Central Services, and state services.
7. **Performance-Linked Capacity Building -** Career progression linked to skill development.
8. **Make India Self-Reliant in Public Administration -** Build institutional capacity matching global best practices.

SIX KEY PILLARS

1. **Policy Framework -** National Programme for Civil Services Capacity Building.
2. **Institutional Framework**
   a. **Public Human Resources Council (PHRC)** - Apex policy body. Chaired by the **PM.**
   b. **Capacity Building Commission (CBC)** - Implementation. Approves Annual Capacity Building Plans (ACBPs) of all departments.
   c. **Karmayogi Bharat** - Special Purpose Vehicle (SPV) - Owns and operates **iGOT Karmayogi Platform.**
   d. **Coordination Unit** under Cabinet Secretariat - Coordinates between PHRC, CBC, Karmayogi Bharat, ministries.
3. **Competency Framework - FRACs Approach** - **F**rameworks of **R**oles, **A**ctivities, and **C**ompetencies for every government position.
4. **iGOT Karmayogi Platform** - comprehensive online learning system.
5. **Electronic Human Resource Management System (e-HRMS) -** Digital platform for managing civil servant lifecycle - from joining to retirement.
6. **Monitoring & Evaluation Framework -** Real-time performance tracking.

iGOT KARMAYOGI PLATFORM

1. **Comprehensive Online Learning -** Curated courses across domains, self-paced and structured learning paths & mobile-friendly access.
2. **Personalised Learning -** AI-driven course recommendations based on role.
3. **Multi-Format Content** Video lectures, interactive modules, case studies, quizzes, simulations, virtual classrooms.
4. **Multi-Lingual Support -** Bhashini integration for translation.
5. **Certifications -** Course completion certificates, Skill badges - Linked to performance appraisal.
6. **Marketplace Model**
   a. Content from premier institutions: **IIMs, IITs, LBSNAA, IIPA, NIPFP, NCAER, etc.**
   b. Global partners: **Harvard, MIT, Singapore Civil Service College, OECD.**
7. **Discussion Forums** for peer learning, expert mentorship.
8. **Performance Linkage -** Learning records integrated with **e-HRMS and** inputs for **Annual Performance Appraisal Reports (APARs).**

PROGRESS AND ACHIEVEMENTS

1. **30+ lakh civil servants** enrolled on iGOT Karmayogi platform.
2. **1,500+ courses** available.
3. **80+ ministries/departments** onboarded.
4. **Annual Capacity Building Plans (ACBPs)** prepared for major ministries.

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5. **Over 1.5 crore learning hours** logged.
6. **Multi-lingual content** in 14+ languages.

SIGNIFICANCE

1. **First Comprehensive Capacity Building Reform.**
2. **Competency-Based Approach** - Shift from "training" to "**capacity building**" rooted in role-specific competencies.
3. **Democratisation of Training** - Even junior-most civil servants get access to world-class learning content.
4. **Anchored in Indian Ethos - Eg. "Karmayogi"** drawn from Bhagavad Gita.
5. **Future-Ready Bureaucracy** - Equips civil servants for AI, climate change, cybersecurity, geopolitics.
6. **Citizen-Centric Mindset** - Transforms bureaucratic mindset towards citizen service.
7. **Cost-Effective** - Online platform reduces training costs compared to physical institutes.
8. **Global Partnerships** - Brings world-class content to Indian civil servants.
9. **Performance-Linked** - Learning integrated with career progression - incentivises continuous learning.
10. **Scalable Model** - Can be extended to **state civil services, PSUs, local governments**.

CHALLENGES / LIMITATIONS

1. **Quality of Content** - Concerns over depth, quality, and relevance of some courses.
2. **Digital Divide** - Frontline civil servants in remote areas may lack reliable internet.
3. **Time Constraints** - Civil servants overburdened with regular work.
4. **Verification of Learning** - Difficult to ensure genuine engagement vs mere "tick-box" compliance.
5. Cultural transformation from **"babu" to "karmayogi" requires more than training.**
6. **Top-Down Approach** - insufficient consultation with bureaucracy on design.

WAY FORWARD

1. **Outcome-Based Evaluation** - Move beyond enrolment numbers to **measurable behavioural and service delivery improvements**.
2. **Mandatory Annual Learning Hours** - Specify minimum learning hours linked to APAR scores and promotions.
3. **Strengthen FRACs Framework** - Update role-competency mappings annually based on emerging needs.
4. **Strong Quality Assurance** - External evaluation of course content; regular curriculum updates.
5. **Strengthen Behavioural Training** - Focus on ethics, empathy, integrity, leadership - not just technical skills.
6. **Global Benchmarking** - Periodic comparison with **Singapore Civil Service College, UK Civil Service Learning, USA's FEI**.
7. **Mental Health Component** - Add modules on stress management, burnout prevention for civil servants.

Police Reforms in India

The Indian police system, governed primarily by the **colonial-era Police Act of 1861**, has long faced calls for **modernisation, professionalisation, and depoliticisation**.

"In the police, change is desired, but never realized." - Justice K.T. Thomas

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MAJOR ISSUES IN INDIAN POLICING

STRUCTURAL ISSUES

1. **Colonial Legacy -** Police Act 1861 designed for British colonial control - not democratic policing. **Police are seen** as "ruler's force" not "citizen's friend".
2. **Political Interference -** Frequent transfers, postings used as political tools. **2nd ARC** flagged "transfer industry".
3. **Dual Role Conflict -** Police perform both **law-and-order** and **investigation** - leading to overload and poor quality of both.

RESOURCE ISSUES

1. **Inadequate Budget -** Police expenditure only **3.1% of total state budgets** (NCRB3). Modernisation of Police Forces Scheme (MPF) underutilised.
2. **Poor Forensic Capacity -** Half of all sanctioned forensic posts vacant nationally.
3. **Low Conviction Rates -** Conviction rate hovers around **55% for IPC crimes** (NCRB); even lower for serious crimes. **Eg.** Conviction rate for **rape cases ~28%, murder ~43%**.

HUMAN RESOURCE ISSUES

1. **Severe Manpower Shortage - Police-population ratio: 155 per 1 lakh vs sanctioned 197.5; UN-recommended 222 (IJR 2025).**
2. **Stress and Mental Health Crisis -** Long working hours (14-16 hours/day), no weekly off, high suicide rates.
3. **Gender Gap -** Women constitute only **11.7% of the police force** (BPRD 2023).
4. Cybercrime, gender sensitisation, juvenile justice, forensics training **"thin and inconsistent"** (IJR 2025).

ACCOUNTABILITY ISSUES

1. **Custodial Violence & Deaths - Tamil Nadu's Sathankulam case (2020)** - Jeyaraj-Bennix custodial deaths.
2. **Encounter Killings -** "Fake encounters" raise serious human rights concerns. **Eg. Hyderabad Disha case (Dec 2019)** - 4 accused killed in encounter.
3. **India hasn't ratified UN Convention Against Torture (UNCAT)** despite signing in 1997. Eg. **Law Commission's 273rd Report (2017)** recommended Anti-Torture Bill; not enacted.
4. **Communalism in Policing -** Allegations of biased policing in communal incidents. Eg. **Hashimpura massacre (1987)** - PAC personnel killed 38 Muslims.
5. **Corruption -** Police perceived as the most **corrupt institution.**

OPERATIONAL ISSUES

1. **Outdated Investigation Methods -** Heavy reliance on confessions; lack of scientific investigation.
2. **Tech Adoption Gap -** Slow adoption of AI, predictive policing, body cameras. Eg. **CCTNS (Crime and Criminal Tracking Network and Systems)** is still incomplete in many states.

MAJOR POLICE REFORM COMMITTEE RECOMMENDATIONS

1. **National Police Commission (NPC), 1977-81**
   a. Replace **Police Act 1861** with new comprehensive law.
   b. **State Security Commission** to insulate police from political interference.
   c. **Separation of investigation from law-and-order.**
2. **Ribeiro Committee, 1998-99**
   a. Police Performance and Accountability Commission.
   b. Civilian oversight mechanisms.
3. **Padmanabhaiah Committee, 2000**
   a. Specialisation in law-and-order, investigation, traffic.

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   b. Community policing.
4. **Malimath Committee, 2003 (Criminal Justice System)**
   a. **Separation of investigation from law-and-order.**
   b. **Special wings** for organised crime, cyber crime, terrorism.
   c. **Forensic infrastructure** modernisation.
   d. **Witness protection scheme.**
   e. **Investigation Officers' Cadre.**
5. **Soli Sorabjee Committee** - Drafted **Model Police Act, 2006**
6. **Justice Verma Committee, 2013**
   a. **Gender sensitisation training** for police, **special protocols** for crimes against women.
   b. **CCTV in police stations.**
   c. **Women police representation.**
7. **Law Commission 273rd Report (2017)**: Anti-Torture Bill - pending implementation.

SUPREME COURT'S PRAKASH SINGH JUDGMENT (2006) - 7 BINDING DIRECTIVES

1. **State Security Commission (SSC)** - To prevent unwarranted political interference in policing
2. **Selection and Tenure of DGP**
   a. DGP to be selected from a panel of senior-most officers.
   b. **Fixed tenure of 2 years**, irrespective of date of superannuation.
   c. Selection through a transparent process (UPSC empanelment).
3. **Fixed tenure of 2 years** for IG, DIG, SP, SHO
4. **Separation of Investigation from Law-and-Order** - For crimes punishable with **7+ years imprisonment**, separate **Investigation Cadre** in police.
5. **Police Establishment Board (PEB) Independent body of senior police officers** to handle transfers, postings, promotions of officers below DSP rank and service-related matters.
6. **Police Complaints Authority (PCA)**
   a. **State-level PCA** for senior officers (SP and above).
   b. **District-level PCA** for junior officers.
   c. To inquire into misconduct, custodial deaths, serious complaints.
7. **National Security Commission (NSC)** - Prepare panel for selection of Chiefs of CAPFs. **Fixed tenure of 2 years** for CAPF chiefs.

Justice K.T. Thomas Committee (2010): **17 of 18 states** that passed new laws **diluted SC directions**.

MAJOR IMPEDIMENTS IN POLICE REFORMS

1. **Police is a State subject** under **Entry 2, List II** of the Seventh Schedule, making reform politically sensitive and federally complex.
2. **Political Resistance** to give up control over police transfers and operations.
3. **Bureaucratic Inertia** - Senior police officers often resist reforms threatening hierarchy.
4. **Lack of Public Pressure** - Police reforms not a salient electoral issue.
5. **Resource Constraints** in poor states for modernization.

Way Forward

1. **Implement Prakash Singh Verdict** - Centre should issue advisories; create monitoring mechanism for state-wise compliance.
2. **Replace Police Act 1861** - States to enact new Police Acts based on **Model Police Act 2006** without dilution.

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3. **Independent Police Complaints Authority** - at state and district levels with non-government members & quasi-judicial powers.
4. **Separation of Investigation from Law-and-Order** - Specialised **Investigation Cadre (Malimath Committee).**
5. **Modernisation**
   a. **Increase MPF Scheme allocation**
   b. Forensic infrastructure (DNA labs, cyber forensics)
   c. **AI/predictive policing** (with ethical safeguards)
6. **Improve Working Conditions**
   a. **8-hour shifts** (Kerala model)
   b. Adequate housing, healthcare, mental health support
   c. **Weekly off** mandatory
7. Enact **Anti-Torture Bill** as per **Law Commission's 273rd Report (2017)**; ratify **UNCAT**.
8. **Strengthen Community Policing** - Replicate **Kerala Janamaithri**, **Punjab Saanjh** models.
9. **Continuous Training** in gender sensitisation, human rights, cyber crime, forensics.
10. **Enhance Transparency - CCTV in all police stations** (SC mandate in Paramvir Singh Saini, 2020), Body cameras for officers.
11. **Address Custodial Violence** - Implement **D.K. Basu guidelines (1997)** strictly.
12. **Research-Based Reform** - Strengthen **Bureau of Police Research and Development (BPRD)** for periodic policing surveys.
13. **Specialisation** - Dedicated wings for cyber crime, organised crime, terror, financial crimes, women's crimes.
14. **Citizen Charter** - Time-bound services; mandatory complaint registration; FIR online.

Best Practices

- **United Kingdom - Independent Office for Police Conduct (IOPC)** to investigate police misconduct.
- **Kerala Police Act, 2011 - Strong State Security Commission, District Police Complaints Authority.**
- **Janamaithri Suraksha Project** - Community policing model.
- **Andhra Pradesh - Disha Police Stations** for women safety.
- **Mumbai - Damini Squad** - Anti-eve teasing squad with women officers.

Prison Reforms in India

Prisons is a State subject under Entry 4, List II of the Seventh Schedule, governed primarily by the colonial-era Prisons **Act, 1894**

The India Justice Report (IJR) 2025 describes Indian prisons as **"warehouses of injustice"**

MAJOR ISSUES WITH PRISONS IN INDIA

1. **Severe Overcrowding** - National average occupancy: **131%** (IJR 2025). **176 prisons** at >200% occupancy. **Moradabad District Prison (UP) at 497%** - highest in India.
2. **Inadequate Capacity Growth** - Eg. Projected inmate population by 2030: **6.8 lakh**; expected capacity only **5.15 lakh** (IJR 2025).
3. **76% of the prison population are undertrials** (up from 66% in 2012) - **4.39 lakh undertrials** of total ~5.77 lakh inmates (IJR 2025).

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4. **Long Pre-Trial Detention - 22% of undertrials** spend 1-3 years in jail (up from 18% in 2012).
5. **Bail Hurdles for Poor -** Surety requirements, financial barriers prevent release; **only 15% access timely legal aid** (IJR 2025).
6. **Caste/Class Bias in Detention - 66% of undertrials are from SC/ST/OBC** communities (IJR 2025).
7. **Acute Staff Shortage -** Inmate-to-staff ratio is **nearly double the benchmark** (IJR 2025). doctor-to-prisoner ratio **1:775** vs Model Prison Manual norm of **1:300**.
8. **Mental Health Crisis -** Only **25 psychologists/psychiatrists** for **5.7 lakh prisoners** - 1 per **22,929 inmates** vs benchmark of **1 per 500** (IJR 2025).
9. **Limited Independent Oversight -** Board of Visitors inactive in many states; NHRC, SHRC oversight weak.
10. Many prisons lack gender-sensitive facilities - private counselling spaces, women medical staff.
11. **Disability Data Gap - No comprehensive data** on inmates with disabilities or those acquiring disabilities in prisons (IJR 2025).
12. **Lack of Vocational Training -** Most prisons lack quality skill development; recidivism remains high.
13. **Open Prisons Underutilised -** Only **86 open prisons** in India for **5.7+ lakh inmates**.

MAJOR COMMITTEE RECOMMENDATIONS

1. **Mulla Committee (1980-83) - All-India Committee on Jail Reforms**
   a. **National Prisons Commission** as monitoring body
   b. **Uniform prisons law** for entire country
   c. **Prison administration professionalisation - Indian Prisons Service**
   d. **Open prisons expansion**
   e. **After-care services** for released prisoners
2. **Justice Amitava Roy Committee (Sept 2018)**
   a. **Plea bargaining** active use
   b. **Lawyers' presence** at police interrogation
   c. **Free legal aid** mandatory
   d. **Special fast-track courts** for undertrial cases
3. **Law Commission's 268th Report (2017)**
   a. **Easier bail** for indigent accused
   b. **Personal bonds without sureties**
   c. **Bail review every 3 months** for undertrials
4. **Law Commission's 273rd Report (2017) - Anti-Torture Bill** & recommended ratification of UNCAT

MAJOR SUPREME COURT JUDGMENTS / GUIDELINES

1. **Hussainara Khatoon v. State of Bihar (1979) -** Right to **speedy trial** under Article 21
2. **D.K. Basu v. State of West Bengal (1997)**
   a. 11 guidelines on **arrest and custodial procedures**
   b. Mandatory: arrest memo, identification of arrestee, medical examination, info to family
3. **Ramamurthy v. State of Karnataka (1997) -** Recommended **uniform prison law** across India

GOVERNMENT INITIATIVES (RECENT)

1. **E-Prisons Software -** Prison Management Application integrated with **Interoperable Criminal Justice System (ICJS)**.
2. **Undertrial Review Committees (UTRCs) -** Mandatory in every district; meet quarterly to review undertrials' release eligibility.
3. **Section 479 BNSS -** Release after half (or one-third for first-time offenders) of maximum sentence.

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4. **Modernisation of Prisons Scheme.**
5. **Model Prison Manual 2016 + Model Prisons Act 2023.**
6. Vocational training in prisons through **PMKVY**.

WAY FORWARD

1. **Implement Model Prisons & Correctional Services Act, 2023**
2. **Address Undertrial Crisis**
   a. **Strict implementation of BNSS Section 479** - release after 1/3 (first offender) or 1/2 (others) of maximum sentence
   b. **Active Undertrial Review Committees** in every district
   c. **Special fast-track courts** for undertrial cases (Justice Amitava Roy 2018)
3. **Expand Open Prisons** - scaling **Rajasthan's Sanganer Open Prison model**
4. **Strengthen Free Legal Aid** - expand **Para-Legal Volunteer (PLV)** network.
5. **All India Prison Service (**Mulla Committee**)** - professional, specialised cadre.
6. **Decongestion Measures**
   a. Plea bargaining (Section 265 BNSS)
   b. Probation, parole expansion
   c. Bail reforms (Law Commission 268th Report)
   d. Compounding of minor offences
7. **Technology Adoption**
   a. **E-Prisons Software** in all prisons
   b. **Video conferencing** (currently 86% of prisons)
   c. **Electronic anklets** for parolees
8. **Prisoner Reintegration** - After-care homes, employment support, social reintegration programmes.

INTERNATIONAL FRAMEWORK

- **UN Standard Minimum Rules for Treatment of Prisoners (Nelson Mandela Rules), 2015.**
- **UN Convention Against Torture (UNCAT)** - India signed (1997), not ratified.
- **Bangkok Rules** - for women prisoners.
- **Beijing Rules** - for juvenile justice.

Best Practices

- **Norway - Halden Prison Model** - focus on **rehabilitation, dignity, normality**.

Custodial Torture in India

Custodial torture refers to the **physical, psychological, or sexual abuse** of a person while in the custody of law enforcement agencies.

RECENT DATA (2025-2026)

1. **170 custodial deaths** reported across India in first 75 days of 2026 (MHA).
2. Annual figures over the past 5 years range between **140 and 176.**
3. **Only 1 case** of disciplinary action over **5 years (2021-22 to 2025-26)** - in **Tamil Nadu**.

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CAUSES OF CUSTODIAL TORTURE

1. **Colonial Police Mindset - Police Act 1861** designed for British colonial control, not democratic policing.
2. **Confession-Centric Investigation -** Police rely on confessions extracted through coercion rather than scientific investigation.
3. **Pressure to Solve Cases Quickly -** Political pressure, media glare, and target-driven policing push for fast results. **Eg. Hyderabad Disha case (December 2019)**
4. **Inadequate Training -** Police lack training in **scientific interrogation, human rights, forensic methods**.
5. **Police-population ratio: 155 per lakh** vs UN-recommended 222. Overworked officers resort to shortcuts.
6. **Low Accountability - 0 convictions in 6 years (2018-2023); only 3 convictions in 25 years (1999-2023)**.
7. **NHRC's Limited Powers -** NHRC can only **recommend**, not enforce. Limited capacity to **conduct independent investigations**.
8. **No Anti-Torture Law - UNCAT signed (1997) but not ratified**
9. **Lack of CCTV Coverage - 17% of police stations have NO CCTV** despite SC's **Paramvir Singh Saini (2020)** mandate (IJR 2025).
10. **Code of Silence ("Blue Wall") -** Internal police culture protects errant colleagues from accountability.
11. **Media Sensationalism -** Demand for instant justice; encouraging "encounter culture".

MAJOR CASE STUDIES

1. **B. Ajith Kumar Case - Tamil Nadu (June 2025).**
2. **Sathankulam Case - Tamil Nadu (June 2020) - P. Jeyaraj (58) and his son J. Bennix (31)** arrested for keeping shop open beyond COVID curfew hours. **Brutally tortured**; both died.

WAY FORWARD

1. **Ratify UNCAT and Enact Anti-Torture Law** as per **Law Commission 273rd Report (2017)**.
2. **Strict Implementation of D.K. Basu Guidelines - 11 mandatory steps** to be enforced through digital tracking.
3. **Universal CCTV Coverage - Paramvir Singh Saini (2020)** SC mandate.
4. **Reverse Burden of Proof -** For custodial injuries/deaths, **burden of proof** should shift to police (Law Commission 273rd Report).
5. **Strengthen NHRC -** Grant **investigative powers** independent of police.
6. **Modernise Investigation -** Move from confession-centric to **forensic, scientific investigation**:
7. **Compensation Framework - Nilabati Behera (1993)** principles should be codified.
8. **Legal Aid at Detention -** mandatory presence of lawyer during interrogation (D.K. Basu).

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Chapter 5

Miscellaneous

Online betting and gambling industry

Data Points

1. **Market Valuation: $5.02 billion** in 2024-25 and is projected to reach **$10.77 billion by 2030**.
2. **User Base:** over **517 million online gamers** (**155 million** engaging in money-based gaming)
3. India represents **20% of the global gaming user base**

Factors Behind Growth

1. **Vibrant start-up ecosystem:** Eg. **Games24X7, Mobile Premier League etc**
2. **Smartphone Penetration:** Eg. Mobile gamers form **90%** of the total 517 million gamer base.
3. **Digital Payment Revolution:** Seamless UPI and e-wallet integration allow instant deposits and withdrawals.
4. The **mainstream success of cricket-based fantasy leagues normalized predictive wagering** as a social activity. Eg. Platforms like **Dream11.**
5. **Influencer & Celebrity Marketing** has reduced the social stigma associated with betting.
6. **Offshore Platforms Access:** Use of encrypted mirror sites and VPNs allows users to bypass domestic restrictions.
7. **Data Affordability:** India continues to have the world's cheapest mobile data, allowing for prolonged, low-cost gaming sessions.
8. **Gamification of Betting:** Using leaderboards, badges, and loyalty points makes the betting experience feel like a recreational video game.

Negative Impacts

1. **Financial Ruin:** Predatory algorithms and easy credit access lead many users to exhaust life savings and fall into debt traps.
2. **Mental Health & Addiction:** "Dopamine loop" of instant wins triggers behavioral addiction similar to substance abuse among young adults. (25% rise in "Gaming Disorder" in 2025).
3. **Suicide and Social Distress** due to high-stakes losses. Eg. suicides linked to online rummy debt
4. **Money Laundering:** Offshore betting platforms are frequently used as fronts for laundering illicit money and illegal capital flight. Eg. Mahadev Betting App Scam.
5. **Exploitation of Minors:** Despite age-gating, children often use their parents' devices and identities to participate in money-based games.
6. **Security and Data Privacy:** Eg. **CERT-In** flagged over 2,000 "Phishing Gaming Apps" that stole user banking credentials.
7. **Erosion of Sports Integrity:** Surge in betting volume increases the risk of match-fixing and spot-fixing in local and domestic tournaments.

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Legal & Regulatory Measures Taken

1. **Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act, 2025:** Prohibits all "Online Money Games" (real-money betting) while permitting e-sports and social games.

- Online games are **classified in the following manner:**
- **E-Sports**: competitive skill based digital sports played through organized tournaments.
- **Online Social Games**: skill-based games designed for entertainment, or social interaction.
- **Online Money Games**: Games involving financial stakes. **Eg. Poker, Rummy.**
- Ministry of Youth Affairs & Sports to frame guidelines, establish training academies, and research centres to promote E-Sports
- A national-level regulator to categorize and register games and handle complaints and grievances.
- The Central Government is authorized to appoint officers with powers of investigation, search, seizure, and arrest.
- Offences are **cognisable and non-bailable**.

1. **Online Gaming Authority of India:** Created as a central regulator under MeitY to classify games, issue digital certificates, and handle enforcement.
2. **Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), 2023:** Section 112 prescribes up to **7 years of imprisonment** for unauthorized betting and gambling.
3. **IT (Intermediary Guidelines) Amendment 2023/2025:** Mandates that intermediaries (ISP/PlayStore) block any platform flagged as a money-game by the Authority.
4. **State specific rules:** State of Assam has Assam Gaming and Betting Act (1970)

Major Challenges in Regulating

1. **Jurisdictional Complexity** - Gambling is a State subject, but Online Gaming is under the Union, leading to persistent legal friction.
2. **Enforcement on Offshore Entities** - Blocking foreign-based sites is difficult as they frequently re-emerge under new domain names. (**"Lazarus" mirror-site phenomenon**)
3. **Defining "Skill" vs. "Chance"** - Industry bodies like **E-Gaming Federation (EGF)** have filed 20+ petitions in 2025 challenging the new "Money Game" definition.
4. **Shadow Payments via Crypto** - Eg. **FIU-India** flagged a 30% rise in "Crypto-gambling" settlements in late 2025.
5. **Proxy Betting & IDs** - Eg. **UP Police** busted a "KYC Racket" in 2026 where 10,000 IDs were rented to high-stakes gamblers.
6. **Misleading Advertisements** - Platforms use "surrogate advertising" (news websites or apparel) to promote betting during live sports.
7. **Technological Evasion** - Platforms use decentralized apps (dApps) on the blockchain that no single government can "shut down."

Major SC Judgments

1. **Dr. K.R. Lakshmanan v. State of Tamil Nadu (1996):** Established the "Predominance of Skill" test (Eg. Horse racing is skill).
2. **Dream11 Case (Varun Gumber v. UT Chandigarh):** The SC upheld that Fantasy Sports require a substantial degree of skill and are not "betting."
3. **Skill Games Federation of India v. State of Karnataka:** The SC set aside state-wide blanket bans, emphasizing that "skill-based" games cannot be equated to gambling.

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Way Forward

1. **Harmonized Central & State Law** by leveraging **Inter-State Council**
2. **Strict KYC via Aadhaar:** Link every gaming account to biometric-verified Aadhaar to prevent minor participation.
3. **AI-driven Monitoring** to detect patterns of "Addictive Play" and issue alerts.
4. **Digital Literacy in Schools:** Introduce modules on the "Mathematics of Gambling" to educate youth about house-edges.
5. **Counselling Centers:** Strengthen and expand state-run "De-addiction Centers".
6. **Ban on Celebrity Endorsements** involving real-money risk.
7. **International Treaty on Cyber-Gambling:** Coordinate with G20 nations to target tax-havens hosting illegal offshore sites.

Sports Governance in India

The **National Sports Governance Act, 2025** aims to professionalize federations, ensure athlete-centricity, and prepare India for its 2036 Olympic bid.

Recent News

1. In **January 2026**, the Government notified the **National Sports Governance Rules, 2026**, which operationalized the mandatory inclusion of retired athletes in decision-making.
2. The Union Budget 2026-27 announced the transition of the "Khelo India Scheme" into a **long-term "Mission"** focused on outcome-driven framework.
3. **Operationalization of National Sports Tribunal (NST):** provides a 90-day fast-track mechanism for resolving selection and contractual disputes.
4. **Budget 2026-27:** Total allocation for the Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports reached a record **₹4,479.88 crore** (a 33% increase from RE 2025-26).

Key Provisions: National Sports Governance Act, 2025

1. **National Sports Board (NSB):** An apex statutory body to grant, monitor, and (if necessary) cancel recognition of National Sports Federations (NSFs).
2. **Athlete Representation:** Mandates at least **two SOMs** in every Executive Committee and **four SOMs** in the General Body with full voting rights.
3. **Age and Term Caps:** Strictly enforces a maximum age of **70 years** and a limit of **three consecutive terms** (12 years) for office bearers.
4. A **National Sports Tribunal** has been created for specialist adjudication, with appeals permitted only to the SC.
5. **National Sports Election Panel:** Centralized oversight of elections by a panel of experts with experience in the Representation of the People Act.
6. **Financial Accountability:** Only recognized bodies registered as Section 8 companies or Trusts are eligible for government grants and tax exemptions.

National Sports Policy (NSP) 2025:

- Replaces the **National Sports Policy, 2001** and aims to make India a **global sporting powerhouse** and prepare for events like the **2036 Olympic Games**.

Core Vision

- Promote **sports excellence**, **economic growth**, and **social inclusion**.

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- Transform sports into a **mass movement** and integrate it with **education**.

Five Key Pillars

- **Excellence on Global Stage**
- Focus on **grassroots to elite talent development**.
- Improve **infrastructure, coaching, and athlete support systems**.
- Strengthen **National Sports Federations (NSFs)**.
- Use **sports science, medicine, and technology** for performance enhancement.
- **Sports for Economic Development**
- Promote **sports tourism** and host global events.
- Boost **sports manufacturing and startups**.
- Encourage **PPP, CSR, and private investment**.
- **Sports for Social Development**
- Increase participation of **women, tribal groups, PwDs, and weaker sections**.
- Promote **indigenous and traditional games**.
- Position sports as a **career option** and integrate with education.
- **Sports as a People's Movement**
- Promote **mass participation and fitness culture**.
- Launch **fitness indices** for institutions.
- Ensure **universal access to sports facilities**.
- **Integration with Education** - Align with **National Education Policy (NEP) 2020** to
- Integrate sports into **school curriculum**.
- Train **teachers and educators** in sports education.

Strategic Framework

- **Governance Reform** - Strong regulatory and legal framework.
- **Private Funding** - Increased role of **PPP and CSR**.
- **Technology Use** - Adoption of **AI, data analytics**.
- **Monitoring System** - KPIs, benchmarks, and time-bound targets.
- **Model for States** - Guideline for State-level policies.
- **Whole-of-Government Approach** - Integration across ministries.

Major Issues in sports governance in India

1. **Conflict of Interest -** Active involvement of politicians and bureaucrats in federations often leads to administrative bias and policy paralysis.
2. **Lack of Professional Management -** Most federations are run by honorary members without formal training in sports management or sports law. Only 5% of NSFs have professional CEOs.
3. Several federations faced **international suspensions**, disrupting India's participation in global events. Eg. WFI in 2023.
4. **Gender Imbalance -** Women's participation in governance remains significantly low
5. **Inadequate Safeguarding -** Lack of robust, independent mechanisms to report and investigate cases of sexual harassment and physical abuse. Eg. Brij Bhushan Singh Case.
6. **Ad-hoc Infrastructure Maintenance -** Eg. Many **Khelo India centers** were flagged in 2025 audits for having non-functional specialized equipment.

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7. **Doping and Integrity** - Eg. **NADA (2026)** reported a 15% rise in positive cases among junior-level athletes in "Power Sports."
8. **Political Factionalism** - Rivalries within federations (like in IOA or Wrestling) lead to "parallel bodies" that confuse athletes and international regulators.

Way Forward

1. **Separation of Power:** Differentiate between "Elected Boards" (Policy) and "Professional Secretariat" (Execution) as seen in **Sport Australia**.
2. **Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT):** Move toward directly funding athletes for training and kit expenses to bypass federation-level leakages.
3. Use **Public-Private Partnerships** to build league systems that sustain athletes beyond government cycles. Eg. **USA's collegiate model**.
4. **Sports Science Integration:** Mandate every NSF to have a "Chief Medical Officer" and "Sports Scientist" to reduce injury-related career ends.
5. **Integrity Units:** Establish independent units like the **Athletics Integrity Unit (AIU)** to handle ethics, doping, and match-fixing.
6. **Whistleblower Protection:** Implement the **WADA Play True** model of protecting athletes who report systemic corruption or abuse.
7. Leverage sports governance as **Soft Power**, bidding for international events to force infrastructure and governance upgrades. Eg. 2036 Olympics Bid.

Social media ban on minors

Karnataka announced plans to ban social media for under-16, while **Andhra Pradesh** announced restrictions for under-13.

In March 2026, Indonesia became the first Southeast Asian nation to enforce a ban for under-16s.

Australia - World's First Ban - Online Safety Amendment (Social Media Minimum Age) Act, 2024

- **Bans children under 16** from Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, Snapchat, YouTube, X, Reddit, Threads, Twitch, Kick.
- **Excludes:** WhatsApp and YouTube Kids.
- **Penalty:** Up to **AUD 49.5 million ($34.4 million USD)** for non-compliance.

Need for Social Media Bans on Minors

1. As per research highlighted in the **Economic Survey 2025-26**, adolescents lack the **"neurological brakes"** to resist addictive features like infinite scroll.
2. **Mental Health Crisis:** high social media usage has led to **rise in anxiety and depression** among teens, driven by curated "idealized" lives and constant social comparison.
3. **"Ipad kid" phenomenon** in urban areas especially in dual-income households.
4. Bans aim to **prevent exposure to harmful content** including self-harm promotion, disordered eating, and sexual exploitation by unverified adults.
5. **Data Privacy:** Minors are often unable to provide "informed consent" for the harvesting of their personal data by Big Tech algorithms.
6. **Rising Suicide: Ghaziabad three sisters case (Feb 2026)** linked to digital addiction.
7. **Cyberbullying:** Online harassment, doxing, body shaming severely impact child psychology.

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8. **Gaming Disorder is classified** as a health condition in WHO's **International Classification of Diseases (ICD-11)**.
9. **Academic Decline: Karnataka VCs Conclave (Feb 2026)** highlighted digital addiction eroding academic performance and physical fitness.

Argument against

1. **Implementation & Enforcement Challenges:** Children easily circumvent age verification with fake IDs, parental help.
2. **Privacy Risks of Age Verification:** Verification requires sensitive data (selfies, IDs, bank details)
3. **Constitutional & Free Speech Concerns:** Restricts political communication and expression of young people.
4. **Drives Use Underground:** Bans may push teens to less-regulated platforms or use VPNs.
5. **Loss of Educational, Social, Civic Benefits:** Social media offers learning, connection, social movements, and support communities.
6. **Isolation of Already-Marginalised Youth:** LGBTQ+, neurodivergent, disabled children may rely on online communities for support.

Way Forward

1. **Tiered Access Model:** Instead of a binary ban, move toward a "graduated" model (Eg. strict restrictions under 13, supervised access for 13–15, full access at 16).
2. De-addiction centers based on **Kerala's Digital De-Addiction (D-DAD) centres** model
3. **Statutory Age Verification:** Implementing non-invasive, privacy-preserving **AI-based age estimation** (Eg. face scanning) rather than just identity document uploads.
4. **Algorithmic Transparency:** Mandating platforms to disable "addictive design" features (infinite scroll, autoplay, and feedback loops) for accounts identified as minors.
5. **Digital Literacy Integration:** Incorporating "Digital Hygiene" into school curricula to teach children how to navigate algorithms rather than just avoiding them.
6. **Safe-by-Design Defaults:** Requiring all minor accounts to be set to **Private by Default** with disabled direct messaging from non-followers.
7. **Global Regulatory Standards:** Promoting a "Digital Treaty" through bodies like the G20 to prevent "jurisdiction hopping" by offshore social media platforms.

The vision must transcend the **ban-vs-no-ban binary** towards a **comprehensive child digital wellbeing framework**. "In protecting children, we must not only build walls - we must also light their path with knowledge."

Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement (RFCTLARR) Act, 2013

The **Standing Committee on Rural Development and Panchayati Raj** released a report on the **"Implementation and Effectiveness of the RFCTLARR Act."** Key highlights include:

1. Recommended making Gram Sabha consent **mandatory for all acquisitions**, not just in Scheduled Areas, and granting it "veto power."
2. Proposed transitioning from "cash land value" to **"livelihood value,"** accounting for the loss of access to forests and water bodies.
3. Recommended making the findings of **Social Impact Assessments (SIA)** legally binding on the acquiring body.

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4. Critiqued the **National Monitoring Committee (NMC)** for failing to address grievances in mega-projects like Ken-Betwa and Polavaram.

Major Provisions of the Act

1. **Public Purpose Definition:** Limits acquisition to strategic uses, infrastructure, and projects for "public purpose" only, preventing arbitrary state action.
2. **Mandatory Consent:** Requires prior consent of **70%** for PPP projects and **80%** for private projects from affected families.
3. **Social Impact Assessment (SIA):** Compulsory multi-disciplinary study to evaluate the impact on livelihoods, public utilities, and social costs.
4. **Enhanced Compensation:** Mandates payment of **4 times** the market value in rural areas and **2 times** in urban areas.
5. **Rehabilitation & Resettlement (R&R):** First law to mandate R&R not just for landowners, but also for **livelihood losers** (tenants, artisans, laborers).
6. **Return of Unutilized Land:** Land not used for **5 years** must be returned to the original owner or a designated Land Bank.
7. **Special Safeguards for Food Security:** Acquisition of multi-crop irrigated land is restricted; if acquired, an equivalent area of wasteland must be developed.
8. **Institutional Framework:** Establishes the **LARR Authority** for speedy dispute disposal and Monitoring Committees at State/National levels.

Major Issues

1. **Gram Sabha Consent Reduced to Formality:** Standing Committee (Dec 2025) flagged that consent often obtained mechanically without genuine consultation.
2. **Manipulation of Land Classification:** Agricultural/forest land reclassified to dilute safeguards. Eg. **Bharatmala project** flagged in Standing Committee Report (Dec 2025).
3. **13 Central Acts exempted** from RFCTLARR provisions - including National Highways Act, Coal Bearing Areas Act, Atomic Energy Act, Railway Act
4. **State-Level Dilutions:** Several states have passed amendments to bypass SIA and Consent requirements for "strategic" projects.
5. **"superficial and mechanically issued" SIAs:** SIAs are often conducted by private agencies hired by project proponents, leading to "Conflict of Interest."
6. **Delayed Compensation & Rehabilitation**
7. **Tribal Disproportionate Impact:** Despite being 8.6% of population, tribals constitute **40%+ of project-displaced** populations. Eg. **Niyamgiri (Odisha)**, **Hasdeo Aranya (Chhattisgarh)**
8. **Complexity and Cost** - The high cost of compensation (4x) and complex SIA process has made several infra-projects economically unviable.
9. **The National Monitoring Committee (NMC)** lacks the "teeth" to stop projects where procedural violations occur.

Census

The **Census of India** is the **largest administrative and statistical exercise in the world**, conducted under the **Census Act, 1948** and **Census Rules, 1990**.

Census 2027 will be the **16th Census of India** and **8th since Independence.**

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MAJOR CHANGES IN CENSUS 2027

1. **First Digital Census: Mobile App-Based Enumeration**
2. **Self-Enumeration Option (First Time):** Citizens can self-enumerate through a dedicated **Census Portal**.
3. **Caste Enumeration Included:** First comprehensive caste census since **1931** (last British-era census with full caste data).
4. **Geo-referenced Jurisdictions:** Extensive use of GIS mapping for accurate household identification.
5. **Real-Time Monitoring** through **census Management & Monitoring System (CMMS)** portal.
6. **Strengthened Data Security: Data centres designated as critical Information Infrastructure (CII).**

NEED / IMPORTANCE OF CENSUS

1. **Delimitation Foundation** - Census data used for delimitation of Lok Sabha and State Assembly constituencies.
2. **Welfare Scheme Targeting** - Identifying poor, marginalised, vulnerable for policy targeting.
3. **Reservation & Social Justice - Caste data** essential for reservation policy, SC/ST/OBC welfare schemes. Last comprehensive caste data - **1931 Census** (95+ years ago).
4. **Fiscal Transfers - Finance Commission** uses Census data for inter-state revenue devolution.
5. **Economic Planning - NITI Aayog, ministries** use Census for sectoral planning - health, education, infrastructure.
6. **Demographic Insights** - Tracks population growth, age structure, migration, urbanisation, sex ratio. **Eg. 2011 Census revealed sex ratio at birth dropped to 919** - alarming finding triggered **Beti Bachao Beti Padhao**.
7. Identifying **Migration Patterns** - Inter-state, rural-urban migration data essential for urban planning. Eg. **2011 Census data** showed 45 crore migrants.
8. **Democratic Legitimacy** - Census is foundation of democracy - "**every citizen counts**".

Major Challenges

1. **Digital Divide & Literacy** Eg. Low **Self-Enumeration** rates in rural areas compared to urban.
2. **Data Security & Privacy:** Storing data of 1.4 billion people digitally increases the risk of cyberattacks and unauthorized data leaks.
3. **Caste Categorisation Complexity:** Hundreds of thousands of jatis, sub-jatis; standardisation challenge.
4. **Political Contestation of Caste:** Collecting caste data is politically sensitive and prone to organized attempts at "Data Inflation" by various groups.
5. **"Question of Trust"** among minority communities: Fear of the data being used for NRC or tax scrutiny can lead to citizens providing false or incomplete information.
6. **Delimitation Anxiety:** The link between Census 2027 and future Lok Sabha seat reallocation creates political friction between North and South India.

Way Forward

1. **Privacy-First Design:** Strict adherence to the **DPDP Act 2023** and **Census Act 1948** to ensure data is used only for aggregate statistics.
2. A **"Census Jan Andolan"** to clarify that data is for welfare, not surveillance, and to promote self-enumeration.
3. **Hybrid Verification:** Ensuring 100% human verification for all self-enumerated data to maintain statistical rigour.
4. **Dynamic Training Support:** Providing 24/7 technical helplines for field enumerators.

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Centrally Sponsored Schemes (CSS) and Central Sector Schemes (CS)

Centrally Sponsored Schemes (CSS) and **Central Sector Schemes (CS)** form the **backbone of India's developmental governance**.

Centrally Sponsored Schemes - Schemes designed by the **Central Government** but **implemented by State Governments**, with funding **shared between Centre and States** in a defined ratio.

Central Sector Schemes (CS) - Schemes that are **fully funded and implemented** by the **Central Government** through its agencies/ministries.

- Currently there are **75 CSSs** in 3 categories and they constitute around **10.4% of the Centre's budget expenditure.**
- In the Union Budget 2026-27, central schemes account for approximately **44% of the total expenditure (over 53 lakh Cr)**

KEY DIFFERENCES

Feature	Centrally Sponsored Schemes (CSS)	Central Sector Schemes (CS)
Funding	Shared (Eg. 60:40, 75:25, 90:10)	100% Centre
Subject Matter	State/Concurrent List	Union List
Implementation	State Governments	Central Government
Federal Character	Cooperative federal	Pure central scheme
Number of Schemes (post-2021)	**28 umbrella schemes**	Several hundred (~150+ schemes/sub-schemes)
Examples	MGNREGA, NHM, Samagra Shiksha, PMGSY	PM-KISAN, PMJAY, MUDRA, AB-PMJAY

CATEGORIES OF CENTRALLY SPONSORED SCHEMES - Based on NITI Aayog's Sub-Group of Chief Ministers (2015) recommendation:

1. **Core of the Core Schemes - 6**
   a. **Highest priority - for socially vulnerable**
   b. Funding: **Highest Centre share (often 100% or 90:10)**

   Examples:
   c. **MGNREGA** (100% Centre for wages)
   d. **NSAP (National Social Assistance Programme)**
   e. **Umbrella Programme for Development of SCs/STs/OBCs/Minorities**
2. **Core Schemes - 22**
   a. Funding: **Centre 60% : State 40%** (general states); **90:10 for NE/Hill states**

   Examples:
   b. **National Health Mission (NHM)**
   c. **Samagra Shiksha** (school education)

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   d. **PMAY-G & PMAY-U** (housing)
3. **Optional Schemes:** States have the **flexibility to implement**

SIGNIFICANCE / NEED FOR CSS & CS

1. **National Standardization:** Ensures uniform service delivery and infrastructure quality across all states regardless of their local revenue. Eg. **SBM** - uniform sanitation goals nationally.
2. **Resource Transfer to States:** Eg. **15th FC** + CSS = ~₹15+ lakh crore annual transfers to states.
3. **Welfare Delivery:** Reaches the most vulnerable through targeted programmes. **Eg. NFSA covers 81+ crore** under Mid-Day Meal, PDS.
4. **Cooperative Federalism:** States as partners in implementation + Centre as funder, monitor.
5. **Convergence:** Multiple schemes converge for holistic outcomes (Eg. POSHAN Abhiyaan, Aspirational Districts).
6. **Capacity Building:** States benefit from Centre's technical, financial support.
7. **Constitutional Compliance:** Implements **DPSPs (Articles 38-46)** through welfare schemes. Eg. MGNREGA.
8. **Human Capital Development:** Ensures minimum standards in education and nutrition to optimize India's demographic dividend. Eg. **PM POSHAN (Mid-day Meal).**

MAJOR ISSUES / CHALLENGES

1. **Fiscal Strain on States:** The mandatory 40% state share in CSS crowds out the state's own regional development priorities.
2. **One-Size-Fits-All Approach:** Central guidelines sometimes fail to account for the unique geographical or cultural realities of diverse states.
3. **Delayed Fund Flow:** A **2025 Audit** showed that 15% of CSS funds remained "parked" due to administrative delays.
4. **Inefficient Monitoring:** Monitoring often focuses on "expenditure" (how much spent) rather than "outcomes" (what was actually achieved).
5. **Scheme Overlap:** Eg. **Skill India** and **NRLM** had overlapping vocational training modules until the 2025 rationalization.
6. **Poor Maintenance of Assets:** Eg. Many **Health & Wellness Centers** lack staff and equipment.
7. **Targeting Errors:** Eg. **PM-Kisan validation errors** stranded **2.18 crore farmer families** (Dvara Research).
8. **Bureaucratic Delays:** Multiple layers - Centre → State → District → Block - cause delays.

Way Forward

1. **Outcome-Linked Budgeting:** Transition from "Spending-based" to "Result-based" fund release using the **PFMS 2.0** platform.
2. Allow states a **25% flexi-fund** within every CSS to adapt the scheme to local topography.
3. **Mandatory Social Audits:** for all major infrastructure and welfare schemes.
4. **State-Specific Performance Grants:** Reward states that exceed national benchmarks with additional "Bonus Grants" for regional projects.
5. Use **Geo-tagging and AI** to monitor the real-time progress of physical assets like houses.
6. **Unified Beneficiary Portal:** Create a **"One Nation, One Scheme Portal"** where citizens can see all eligible benefits via a single ID.
7. **Capacitating Local Bodies:** Empower Panchayats to act as the primary implementers and auditors of "Last-Mile" delivery.
8. **Regular Scheme Sunset Reviews:** Ensure every scheme is rigorously evaluated every 5 years by the **NITI Aayog** before renewal.

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